Selling a Dream

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41945991.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Cosplayers, Modern Etheria (She-Ra), Modern AU but still Canon Species, Social Media, Prop Making, Fake Dating, Influencer!Adora, Prop Maker!Catra, Sexual Tension, Muscle Kink, Unapologetic Bed Sharing

Language:
English

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Catradora AUs by n7punk

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Published: 2022-09-26 Completed: 2022-12-09 Words: 76,317 Chapters: 9/9

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Summary

Three years after Adora left the prop-making business and fell out with Catra, they finally reconnect thanks to the same things that tore them apart. Adora just wants to show Catra what her new life is like so she can finally understand why Adora committed to cosplay and modeling fulltime. Their attempt at cosplaying togther spirals out of control and soon they're dating in character.
Off Instagram, they're still trying to figure out how to be friends. Catra is trying to be understanding (gross), but it's hard when she was in love with Adora and then left behind without consideration. Cosplay gives her an opening to explore everything she *thought* she had with Adora, but it turns out there are still consequences.
(Or, a cosplayer Adora and propmaker Catra AU)

Retella

Chapter Notes

Welcome to SAD 😭 The rating is not a guarantee, just a guess. I wasnt sure where this would fall for awhile but I think it' s gonna be M or E. Ill adjust it if necessary once I know . Chapter count is also an estimate.
Conveying time passing in a text conversation is kind of hard, but if a message was left unanswered long enough for "Read" to pop up beneath it, then time passed. In real convos that dynamically disappears as you keep talking but I cant exactly do that lol
As always, I know the way Im "transcribing" social media to text isnt "accurate" to how these platforms look and work, but it' s the way Im converting it for clarity/readability .

See the end of the chapter for more notes

--- uly 16 th ---

Adora ⚕ Meetup @ mentioned you in their story
This replica is INSANE it's taller than I am
@traprops killed it!
Tap to view

--- August 27th ---

Congratulations on the new workshop!
It looks great. I cant wait to see what you build in it
Im so happy you were able to start your own place

--- October 31st ---

I hope you have a good birthday this year. You deserve it
I couldnt find the address of your new workshop to mail you a present this year
I hope you got the last two at least

--- anuary 1 st ---

I mis u
Youre going to do great things this year
I cant wait to see them

--- February 9th ---

I know you dont want to talk to me
But I also know you love hearing that youre right
[illegible]

Ike that
[illegible]

I need your help
[illegible]

Took a commission I cant handle. I know you can do it though
I have all the supplies. And Ill pay you obvs

Wow the mighty She-ra needs help from a lowly propmaker like me?

I always need you
[illegible]

Alright fine. No talking then
I thought taking a commission with electronics would force me to finally learn wiring
I never figured it out and now the deadline is coming up
So yes I need your help. Your builds always look great especially when you use EDs

You realize I would love to watch you fail publicly

Bow will trade favors with me and help me make something passable in time if I ask
We made tighter turnarounds at the horde. You'd make something great

They should have come to me in the first place

Probably. They wanted a full character recreation though and I've worked with them before
Ill send them your way next time they need electronics
Ill do whatever promo post you want if admitting I cant do it is all you want

It's definitely not "all" I want. It's a good start tho

Youll help?

Ill do what you couldnt

--

Turning on read receipts just to be petty was satisfying, but unfortunately it also means that Adora can tell Catra saw her new number in the chat when Catra doesnt reply to the message. Absently, she scrolls up in the conversation as she weighs her options.

The messages that were already on screen when Adora broke down and asked for help arent anywhere near the start of their DM history. Not that Catra has answered a single message before this, but Adora has still sent her a few every year since Catra stopped answering her calls. Catra both loves and hates when Adora messages her. Every message makes her chest warm a bit and she often cradles the phone close to her chest after receiving the small bit of assurance that Adora is still thinking of her, but despite that, the messages also hurt.

They are reminders that Adora would let Catra back into her life with open arms if she called her, but Catra would still never *get* her back. Adora misses her, but she is never going to treat Catra like the life partner that Catra treated her as. She's never going to fall in love with her. Catra has spent three years trying to let it go and it still hasnt happened. The furthest she has gotten is dulled bitterness and a begrudging understanding of some of Adora's choices. It still hurts to think of how easily Adora dismissed her back then.

Adora should have tried this three years ago, but she was probably too proud to admit that she couldnt do something all by herself. She has people to help – people she *left* for – but of course she isnt going to burden them with a rush job. If she thinks Catra is going to give her a discount, she's sorely mistaken. Catra is more expensive now than she used to be. She has her own place and she can charge her worth. The bitter part of her says to hang Adora out to dry the same way Adora left *her*, but being able to do a job that Adora couldnt will be more satisfying in the end. Getting paid is a bonus. She doesnt have any other commissions in the build phase right now anyway.

Maybe, just maybe, she also wants an excuse to talk to Adora again without compromising *her* pride.

"Scorpia!" Catra shouts as she turns read receipts back off before she forgets. Something clatters from the far side of the workshop. A moment later, the angle grinder stops. Two more clashes follow. Catra doesnt even glance up from her phone when Scorpia pops

into the "doorway" – it's a divider wall on one side and some tall equipment on the other – between their spaces with her welding mask still on but flipped up to reveal her endless grin.

"Yeah, boss?" she asks, a bit breathless. Catra points in the general direction of the shop's back lot, though it can't be seen from here. *Wi l ad Wk s hop* is kept in neat order for a workshop that sees regular use from three people, but some of their equipment and storage systems are large, and they have all sectioned off their own "offices" in the space using their favorite equipment as barriers. Catra is leaned over the blueprint table she built herself currently, her laptop open in front of her but thoroughly ignored ever since Adora messaged her.

"Go make sure the noise hasn't run Melog off for a few minutes for me. I need some quiet to call a new client," she tells Scorpia. Really she just needs the sound of metal and sparks flying to stop, but she also doesn't want Scorpia to overhear whatever conversation she is about to have with Adora, at least not until she has worked out the details. Scorpia is going to get all pouty when she realizes Catra is calling Adora. She already judges her whenever she catches Catra scrolling through her Instagram. *M ngonou l goof he* , blah blah. Catra can't and won't.

She might finally be in a place where she doesn't *ha* to, but Scorpia standing over her shoulder and judging her isn't going to help her figure that out. Entrapta is just quietly working in her corner on the opposite end of the shop and won't make a fuss. Scorpia gives her a salute and pulls her mask off her forehead, setting it down on Catra's cutting bench near the wall. Yeah, she's definitely going to forget that's there.

"Got it, boss! I'll bring your cat back," Scorpia promises her. Catra's ear twitches. He's not *he* cat, he's just *a* cat, that happens to be here, and she feeds. He's the shop cat, if anything. He has probably been living here since before they showed up. Scorpia is already walking away, though, so Catra doesn't correct her.

Time to see how badly Adora let herself be backed into a corner.

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The sound of the phone ringing triggers an instant wave of relief in Adora. She is hunched over her workbench about ready to tear her hair out. Her ponytail is still up, but her hair is escaping it and falling in her face, visual evidence of her impending breakdown. The strands falling in her face and getting in the way are not helping her mental state. She feels like she can breathe again when the unknown number comes up on her screen.

"Catra?" she answers, because there is a hope that it's someone else and she just might cry if so. There is a beat of silence.

"Wow, you're in it deep," Catra answers, because apparently she only needs to hear one word from Adora to know how close a project has driven her to a breakdown. They worked together for years and no matter how professional you are, there will always be the occasional project that pushes you to tears. Catra has seen her like this before many times and she has seen Catra the same way. It's still been three years and Adora wasn't expecting to be so transparent to her.

"I've got every part of the commission done except this prop. It's been fighting me for days and I just can't-" she cuts off, like they all learned to do, because if their supervisor overheard them complaining, or worse, admitting something, there would be consequences. There's a reason everyone learned to save even the most wrecked piece of scrap at Bright Eyes.

Eventually you were going to need to break something to deal with another impossible deadline and you had better choose something that was already trash. One time Catra threw the prop they were

working on in frustration and broke it. It already *stuck* ing , but thinking about Hordak's reaction still makes Adora's stomach feel like a blackhole.

"Relax, hot shot, I'm sure I could do it in a *pinch* . What are you even working on?" Catra replies, dismissive and put together , but it makes tears spring to Adora's eyes – in a good way . She knows Catra can. This isn't the first time Catra has had to save her on a build, just the first time in a *long* time. She blows out a steadying breath and blinks down at the mess of wires in front of her.

"A cosplay of Retella from Empires Across T ime. It's an MMO. I made the costume and wig already, but she has a decked-out laser rifle they wanted to have a functioning laser light when you pull the trigger. I figured out the sight and the mechanism, I *thought*, but I can't make the lights work," Adora unloads. Of all the projects to learn wiring on, this was probably an *ambitious* choice , but the prop looked cool and she thought the costume would be fun to put together – plus they were willing to drop a heavy fee – so she took it.

Now it's due in a week. She knows the final details she needs to put on the prop once it's all closed up are going to take a few days to dry. She needs to figure this out now, or at least determine what supplies she needs to replace so she can get her hands on them. Catra lets out a low chirrup, a vague acknowledgement that means she's thinking. Adora focuses on breathing and picks up her pliers so she can tap them against her table surface, trying to calm her frayed nerves.

"Oh, that prop's *huge* , I see why you wanted to make it. I can't believe you tried to build it when you haven't even used EDs, though. You're not a fucking amateur , you should know your limits," Catra says. Being insulted should be the last thing Adora needs right now, but anything except *nonjudgmental* will lift her heart at this point. It looks like a lot for a first-timer – because it *is* – but the pulsing lights along the sides of the rifle were the least of her worries. She actually got those to work, but they were easier since they weren't connected to the trigger .

"Since when were we allowed to have limits?" she returns. At the Horde, you were given your work and you'd better get the job done. There was a barter economy of skills and favors built between the prop makers. If you couldn't do something, there would *always* be somebody who could, and they'd do it for you quietly if you had a skill they were eventually going to need too. Adora still trades favors with her fellow cosplayers, but it's a lot more collaborative. They're all helping each other succeed, not begrudgingly relying on others only when necessary to keep their jobs and survive.

"What was the point of *going* if that didn't change when you left? Cut the shit, Adora. When's your deadline?" Catra immediately bites back. Adora flinches. She and Catra have had multiple fights about Adora leaving the Horde. Catra has had her own workshop for eight months now and she *must* know how much better it is to work for just about anyone else, but the big problem with working for *yourself* is that every opportunity you turn away feels like a financial loss and personal failure rolled into one.

"The eighteenth. I need time to finish the rest of the gun after I close in the electronics, though," Adora tells her. To her surprise, Catra snorts.

"*Fine*. Send me pictures of what you're working with and then bring it all over tomorrow. If I can't figure it out in an hour, Entrapta will be able to do it in twenty minutes," Catra tells her. The tension in Adora's chest releases and she lets out a sigh that feels deep enough to change atmospheric pressure. She doesn't even know where Catra's workshop is, but she has to assume she didn't move more than a day drive away. Adora will drive however far she has to for her help.

"*Thank you*," she tells her. She really didn't know if Catra would be willing to save her. She knew Bow could help, but he doesn't do rush jobs like this. She isn't willing to abuse his kindness and he would never have let her pay him. Catra would –rightfully– want compensation for her time and it makes her easier to ask. Besides, Bow may be better with tech and gadgets, but Catra is rounded out

in all the other disciplines needed to make a functioning prop, so if the design needed tweaks to accommodate the lights, she would have been able to handle it.

"Dont thank me yet. My hourly fee is at least five times what we were paid at the Horde," Catra replies, her tone sarcastic. Even though that isn't great for the state of the commission, Adora doesnt hesitate to reply-

"Good. You deserve it and you have overhead now. I'm not cheap either, but I'd rather lose out on money than put out a shitty product," Adora replies. She has never broken her payment down by hours, but she would bet her work costs more than Catra's – and works out to be a worse hourly rate, because she will spend hours banging her head against the wall trying to get something like this to work. This is why she prefers cosplay now over the constant prop work they did back at the Horde.

"Yeah, yeah, you'd rather die than admit you can't do something, whatever. You have a reputation and I have standards for how I let my work be treated now I'm solo. You're thanking me for helping you with the technical aspects when you post the build. Now get me those photos. Send the client specs and reference photos while you're at it. My email's on my website," Catra says. Adora feels a twinge that finally breaks through the relief she has been coasting on. Catra said *my work*, but they both know she meant *myself*.

"I try to show you I respect your work now. I'll get everything to you," she promises. She has been trying for the last three years – ever since the fight where she realized Catra felt like she had been dismissing her – but they haven't exactly been talking, so the best she could do was post about her builds when she recognized them. Catra's name still wasn't as known when she left two years later as Adora's was when she walked. The fact that Adora was already a cosplayer when they started working at the Horde helped a lot, but she *got* to that position because Weaver let her.

She never let Catra do just about anything. Adora didn't realize that Catra blamed her for that too until it was too late.

"Yeah, sure. We both know that wasn't all it was. I'll text you the address once I get your email. I've got to go rearrange tomorrow's schedule to make room for a rush job," Catra tells her, and then she hangs up without a goodbye.

Well, Adora is feeling better, but now she thinks she needs to lie on the couch and cry for a bit again.

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Catra browsed Adora's Instagram and saw parts of the build here and there. It's easy to recognize now that she knows what she is working on even if she hasn't posted much about the problematic rifle. Between the posts and what Adora sent over ahead of time, Catra knew what the build looked like before Adora arrived, but she still is somehow surprised when Adora hands her the foam block upon her arrival at the shop.

"I know metal would be overkill for this, but do you not have access to a vacuum former or something?" Catra asks as she takes the prop and turns it over in her hands. The barrel is PVC pipe, but the handle and details are all built out of foam. It isn't finished – the whole top half is in pieces so the wiring can be done – but she still wouldn't have used foam as a primary construction material for a prop that was supposed to mimic such a manufactured object. Foam is great for cosplay and some prop details, but she would have done this *completely* differently.

"I'm a cosplayer, Catra. I only have a laser cutter because of the Best Friend Squad workshop," Adora replies, like it's obvious. Catra wrinkles her nose as she dumps the prop unceremoniously on her

workbench. Adora and her new *apprentice* are sickening, but Catra used to be desperately jealous of the workshop they share. One of the big ways the Horde traps its talent – in addition to plucking them straight out of school or amateur productions and never crediting them so they can't build up portfolios – is by providing nearly every state-of-the-art machine you could want. It's hard to leave when you don't know *how* to produce an entire prop by hand without any fancy tools. It feels helpless to try.

Now Catra's workshop is better stocked than Adora's. Adora might not be in the practical effects business anymore and she probably makes more money than Catra does, but it still feels like a victory.

"If my name is going on this, it isn't going to look like this. We're using plastic," Catra replies, pulling a knife out from the drawer unit beneath the table. Adora's eyes go wide.

"I spent two weeks making that!" she protests as Catra lifts the gun up and carefully eyes the center point of its stock. She looks up to send Adora an unimpressed look.

"And it won't be wasted because I'll use it to mold the *new* prop off of. You said this was for promotional events, right? So it needs to be carried for hours and hold up to being shipped around. Foam will be easier to damage and won't feel as realistic when fans touch it. If you have to justify it, you can say you needed my help because you don't have the equipment to make it this way," Catra replies. She knows the pain of having to wreck a prop you spent days on to build something better, but she needs to cut this in half to form each side of the shell. They can leave the foam inside to give it a more realistic weight and keep the plastic from denting, but they do need to separate it first.

Adora bites her lip. She looks conflicted – and a bit like she might cry. She looks back down at the gun.

"I'm sorry, buddy," she says. Catra's tail flicks. She shouldn't find Adora apologizing to an *inanimate object* cute, but Adora cares so

much and it always drew Catra to her. She puts down the knife and picks up a ruler and marker instead.

"Here, hold it for me and Ill mark it out," she says, because she wants to make sure she does this evenly and not at all to give Adora time to mourn a hunk of foam. Adora steps forward to follow instructions, forcing their sides together because they *have* to be close to both have their hands on the same prop, but it still makes Catra's fur fluff up a little. She refuses to look at Adora as she lines up the ruler and starts making marks. If she doesnt acknowledge her, then she can just assume Adora didnt notice.

She clears her throat and begins to talk just to fill the air and distract her.

"Once we get this dissected, you can work on gluing up the final pieces so the forms are complete while I do the electronics. Once I have them working, we can form the new shell, do the cutouts for the lights, and set them in. Well put it together here, but you can paint and finish it on your own time," she orders. Adora nods. Their builds were *usually* pretty equal, but Adora was more often than not the one giving Catra instructions. She was technically their team leader and allowed to. If she could handle a part of a build by herself, she always would.

It used to drive Catra insane. Sometimes it felt like they were doing amazing things together, and other times it felt like Adora was only using her when she had no other choice and she believed she was the only one who could get it all done in the end. It has taken Catra three fucking years—and really, six months of having team members for herself—to realize that wasnt how it was for Adora and she just preferred to overwork herself than them, but it still feels *important* for Adora be accepting her orders without protest.

"How do we make the trigger work with the vacuum former? It's a separate piece settled between the two halves," Adora asks, and just like that they're talking shop and figuring out problems just like they

used to, Catra turning the build over in her hands, asking Adora questions about what she did, and sketching out ideas on the table.

She lets out a soft breath when Adora reaches out and takes the sharpie out of her hand without pausing, drawing another sketch beside Catra's to illustrate what she was actually trying to describe. It's exactly what they used to do back in the workshop.

Catra told herself she was just going to take her money and gloat. She's such an idiot.

--

Catra is just as cunning and creative as she used to be. She has equipment and thus options that Adora doesn't have, but she also figures out how to use what they already have to get the build done faster than starting over and doing it "right"—in her opinion, Adora likes working with foam—would take. She immediately sees a problem when she follows through on her threat and cuts the gun open to reveal Adora's trigger mechanism. Apparently there is more than one, though, and Adora's electrical work is beyond salvaging.

"These *lights*, Adora. I think Entrapta will cry when she sees them," Catra says, holding the tangle of wires she pulled out of the prop up between two claws like it's a dead rat that she's trying not to touch while disposing of. Or maybe she just doesn't want to be electrocuted, but the battery isn't in it right now.

"So they're good?" Adora replies, sarcastic, but she really doesn't know what's wrong with them. The rifle sight she bought premade and just refinished to match the prop. The beam light for the barrel was the most concentrated one she could find that would fit in the build. Catra sends her a withering look, gathering up the sight in her other hand.

"You go back to prepping the form. I'm handing all of this to Entrapta. She'll have it done before your glue is dry," Catra tells her, already turning to leave. Adora rolls her eyes, but she watches Catra slip away between equipment from the corner of her eye. Adora isn't really sure if the workshop is a collaborative effort with Entrapta and Scorpia or if they're Catra's employees, but both of the makers are all over Catra's Instagram and listed on her website. Adora isn't close enough with Entrapta to ask such a prying question and she and Scorpia barely avoid antagonizing each other when they meet.

She *is* close enough with Entrapta to know how skilled she is, though, so she doesn't doubt that she can fix Adora's mess – or more likely, build something new out of nothing – faster than she can work. She turns back to her own prop, stealing a few glances at the space around her as she works. She marveled at the shop as she walked in, but she isn't looking at Catra's CNC now. There are touches of her all around the space that make Adora's chest feel warm.

It's things like the familiar order her tools are in on her pegboard and the dumb "break glass in case of Kyle" box she made when they were nineteen that she apparently brought over to her new shop and hung on the wall. The front panel of the glass *is* broken, which Adora desperately wants to know the story behind, and there's an inexplicable stuffed toy of a tiger inside. Catra has definitely built – or at least customized – the massive worktable Adora is sitting at, her signature striped pattern stained into the wood top that Adora always thought was hideous, but Catra likes how it looks in *her* vision, and more importantly, she finds the process of doing it fun.

Adora absently traces her hand along one of the stripes as she hears Catra's laugh filter from the other end of the shop. She can hear Catra's tones intermixed with Entrapta's excitable chatter, but she can't make out what they're saying. She is almost grateful for it, because she's having a *moment* – just being back in Catra's space without – much – antagonism between them and she needs to soak it in now so she can get ahold of herself before Catra comes back.

She doesn't think them working together like this would have been possible as long as Catra was still working at the Horde – and she wasn't sure Catra would ever *leave* – but she has been hopeful over the last few months. She was at the end of her rope when she called and Catra was always the one who caught her when she threatened to fall. Catra has been teasing and somewhat belittling, but there's some of their old familiarity to it that hasn't been there in three years and she's *hopeful* that she will get more than a prop out of this afternoon.

When Catra comes wandering back to her own corner of the workshop, she has an easy smile on her face. Lopsided, but honest without a hint of mirth to it. Adora was supposed to be getting a hold of herself, but instead she finds her breath taken away. Adora has been pretty demonstrably gay for Catra in the past, but she still thinks Catra has never looked better than she does wearing a pair of ripped jeans, a loose black tee shirt with her new logo on the chest, and an easy smile on her face as she stands in the middle of a workshop that she owns.

"Entrapta asked the wires who hurt them when I handed them over. They look like a chipmunk chewed at them," Catra informs her, giving her no time to recover. Adora forces herself to breathe normally and push through her Catra-induced delirium. It's easy to smile, at least. She shakes her head a little with amusement as she looks back down at her build.

"She's great. You're lucky to have her," Adora says. Entrapta cosplays as a hobby and not a career, so they don't see each other a lot, but Adora at least considers her a friend. They trade messages on occasion and talk when they end up at the same con. They don't have the kind of closeness that Entrapta seems to have with Catra and Scorpia. To Adora's surprise, Catra chuckles and drops down on the stool that she kicked over to the end of the table earlier.

"Don't I know it. Half this shit is hers. She inherited it from her parents, but she only uses the stuff in her corner. It took a lot of work to get it all back in shape, but even half-deteriorated it was easier

than buying it,” Catra says, shaking her head. Adora looks up, blinking in surprise. She had no idea Entrapta’s parents were even dead – most of the time when they talk, it’s just about their cosplays or the con they’re at – much less that she owned the place.

“Is she, like, your investor then?” she asks. Catra’s ears twitch as she obviously suppressed a laugh.

“Yeah, no. *Wild Workshop* is technically a business I own and Entrapta and Scorpia work for, but it’s collaborative. Really that just means I do all their tax and insurance shit for them and find us commissions. Entrapta owns the building, but she never liked working in it alone. It was full of ghosts when I showed up,” Catra explains with a shrug. Adora, not for the first time, is equally unsurprised by Catra and in awe of her. She can barely navigate a few commissions a year, not to mention her *taxes*. She can’t imagine setting up a whole business like this and providing support to two other makers. She isn’t surprised Catra managed it, but she is *impressed*.

“Your workshop really is incredible. You always did amazing work, but I can already see it improving now the horde isn’t dragging you down. I can’t wait to see what your builds will look like once you start getting bigger orders,” Adora says, because she has managed to message Catra small pieces of this sentiment before, but she never replied and Adora *needs* her to know. Catra tries to look unphased, but Adora knows what her ears twitching with embarrassment looks like. Catra’s face heats as she looks away.

“Yeah, well, it helps to actually care about your team and the final result, not just if the client will be satisfied enough to come back. Running my own place feels like a shitshow most of the time, but it’s still less pressure than that hellhole,” Catra returns, catching Adora off-guard. She knows that – she has known it for *three* years – but she’s still shocked to hear Catra say it. Catra must catch something in her expression because her ears pin back. She quickly darts her gaze away.

"We've got a build to finish," she points out, an edge to her voice that Adora knows well. She shifts back on the stool, balancing precariously so she can tuck her legs up and wrap her arms around them. She glares at Adora over the tops of her knees. Adora nods, reluctantly reaching for her prop again.

"The form's almost done, but the glue is going to take a few hours to fully dry," Adora forces herself to say, even though all she wants to do is beg to know if Catra finally understands why Adora had to leave and, more importantly, why she did all the things that Catra twisted into cruel intentions in her mind. She can't fuck this opportunity up. At the end of the table, some of the tension that was gathering in Catra releases.

"Entrapta was offended by your little plastic sight—actually by the whole system—and she's rebuilding it from scratch. I need to forward her the reference photos so she can make sure it matches, but she'll take a bit longer since she has to do some exterior work for the sight and trigger," Catra replies. Adora, despite herself, jolts her head up to make eye contact with Catra. Catra just told her to get back to work, but Catra is obtuse and that almost sounds like her careful, noncommittal way of telling Adora she can stick around for a while. Catra rolls her eyes, but she doesn't really pass herself off as uncaring.

"We need to infuse that thing with resin anyway so the airspace in the foam doesn't make it lose shape under the vacuum. Come back tomorrow so we can get the form finished and check that Entrapta's work meets the client's specs. We can do the molding the next day when it's all dry. You'll still have plenty of time to paint and finish it," Catra offers. Adora's mouth hangs open now, because yeah, the logistics weren't going to pan out to this taking an hour once Catra decided the whole prop had to change, but she wasn't expecting to be invited back *time*.

"My time is money, princess. I'm not going to hang around for hours when we could just spread things out strategically," Catra continues, amused by her gaping. Adora offers her a wobbly smile.

"Not sure I can af ford you for three days, Ill be honest," she returns. Catra snorts as she passes behind Adora and walks on to the desktop she has set up in the corner of the room.

"Y ou technically only hired me for the electronics, I just have standards. Ill charge you for Entrapta' s time and materials and do the rest for promo posts," Catra of fers, casually, not even looking at Adora as she drops down at the computer despite how her desk is facing *out* towards the room and she can easily tilt her head to make eye contact. Adora, for the fiftieth time today, feels thrown for a loop.

"W ow, working for exposure? Y ou would think that you like me or something," she says. Catra snorts and finally looks up to shoot Adora an unimpressed look. Adora beams back at her.

"I like putting out a good product. Now be quiet while I do my shitty admin work," Catra tells her . Adora turns back to her pile of foam, but she's grinning.

It's *good*.

--

Adora ⚔ Commissions closed! mentioned you in a post
Friends who will teach you how to make stuff you cant dream of on your own are invaluable <3
@catraprops' s workshop is awesome! We're gonna make something cool together 😗
PS spot the shop cat! He didnt let me pet him but Im going to earn his trust before this build is done >:D
Tap to view

The video is just a panning shot of the workshop that Adora took as she was leaving, but Melog's tail can barely be seen coming out from under a table. He spent the whole time Adora was there hiding like he always does from strangers, so that is actually an impressive glimpse of him. The video makes Catra smile despite herself.

Wow you think we're friends huh

Besties <3

Ew get away from me

You answered my call now you're stuck with me

I rescind my invitation you're on your own

Then you wont get paid :(
If you dont love me love money

Damn. A compelling argument
Fine you can come back

:D

If you ever say bestie out loud Im actually killing you
Scorpia doesnt need a new word added to her dictionary
It's already bad enough your little "squad" inspired her to nickname us too

The super pal trio is cute!

Didnt know you were stalking my Instagram

You knew

You're right you're obvious

I missed my bestie

I will k-
No
You know what
I shouldnt confess to a crime on Instagram
Theyll totally give the cops my DM history when they find your body

D:

Good. Run in fear

Running back to you <3

--

"Is. Uh. Is this legal?" Adora has to ask when Entrapta hands her the finished barrel with the trigger mechanism hanging out of it, and more concerningly, what looks like it could be a *laser sight*. Entrapta tilts her head while Catra obviously holds in laughter in the background.

"What do you mean? I dont stock laser that arent legal anymore, unfortunately," Entrapta replies. Yeah, that's a *story*, but somehow it doesnt surprise Adora in the slightest.

"It just, uh, looks very real," Adora points out. What she had before didnt look bad, especially once she completely refinished it, but it started out as a toy version of a sight. Adora thinks this one might *work*. Entrapta blinks at her.

"I'm sorry, did you want it to look bad?" she asks, a genuine question without a trace of sarcasm to it. Adora decides to give up. Hopefully

it wont cause problems with airport security when they ship this thing around.

"No, you did great. Thanks, Entrapta," Adora promises her . Instantly, Entrapta beams and pushes back to send her whirly chair spinning away from the improvised doorway of her "of fice." She catches the edge of her desk to turn herself back around so she can look over at Adora again as she picks her tools up.

"No problem! Y our trigger wasnt bad, just connected wrong," Entrapta says. Adora feels herself straighten a little, because *noted* is high praise from someone as skilled as Entrapta is with stuff like this. "Y our lights were bad, though. Dont do that again," Entrapta adds, with the exact same tone of voice that she complimented Adora with. Factual and relaxed. Adora shakes her head with a chuckle, glancing over at Catra to find the corner of her mouth twitching too.

"I wont, trust me," Adora promises, giving Entrapta a small wave before she turns to follow Catra deeper into the workshop. They're nearly done with the form now, they just need to wait for everything to dry. They need to make sure they have everything ready for tomorrow so they dont lose more time, though. Even after they make the plastic body, they have to do some finishing work on it to make it look more like metal before they install the electronics. Adora has foam work to do to build up the details that would just make it look like a kid's toy if they were including in the main body, too. She needs to have everything ready to go if she's going to finish all the paint details in time.

She freezes when they walk into Catra' s space to find a small cat curled up on the table where they were working yesterday. Catra shoots her amused look as she continues on and doesnt hesitate to pull up a chair beside Melog. The cat doesnt even twitch an ear at the stool scraping across the floor, but he must be used to loud noise if he hangs around a large shop like this a lot.

"If he doesn't run from you, he won't bite. He's skittish, but he's sweet," she promises Adora. Adora isn't too worried about getting bit—she's had worse—but she really wants him to stay. She can't imagine he's asleep after the chair leg screamed on the concrete floor, but right now he's balled up with his eyes closed. The second she takes a step towards him, however, his eyes open. He watches her, blue eyes wary. Catra watches with amusement as Adora creeps towards the worktable like it's a live landmine. Melog raises his head when she gets within petting distance and she freezes, but he just eyes her. Cautiously, she holds her hand out for him to sniff.

He immediately hisses and stands up, walking to the other side of the table and turning his back on her as he balls up again. Adora feels her expression crumple. Beside her, Catra snorts and then shocks her by reaching out for her hand. Adora suddenly forgets about Melog, *staring* as Catra lifts Adora's hand to her face and rubs it against her cheek. Adora's entire face feels hot and she forgets how to breathe as Catra covers her hand in scent marks, finally dropping it with an amused smirk. Adora's hand falls by her side like a dead fish, most of her body and *brain* offline.

"There you go. You can pet him now," Catra says, turning back towards the table like she didn't just *wreck* Adora. Adora swallows, looking down at her hand and then back towards the balled-up cat.

It turns out Catra was right when Adora eventually manages to reengage her legs. Melog lets her pet him now and even purrs as she scratches his cheek. Because Catra just did *that*, Adora boldly tries to pet Catra next "as a joke." Catra shrieks as she ducks out of the way, and then Adora has her in a headlock and is giving her ear scratches against her will as she laughs and demands that Adora let her go. She's struggling and calling Adora childish, but her claws aren't out and there's a reverberation in her chest that Adora knows well.

Catra could be charging her the entire damn commission fee and this would still be worth it.

--

Adora 🔪 Commissions closed! has updated their story
@catraprops and @catrapta1o1 helping me make the coolest prop at Wildcat Workshop!
Keep an eye out for it on @empiresacrosstime's page soon!
Tap to view

The video shows a flat table with a piece of plastic ballooned around it. The plastic deflates quickly until it reveals an object on the table beneath it, molding around the shape of a flattened rifle. A loud machine whirrs in the background as all the air sucks away.

Catra's lower half can be seen in the background as she stands in front of a parts wall with her hand on a lever. She pulls it and the overwhelming drone of the machine cuts off.

--

Adora, predictably, is reluctant to leave on her last day at the shop. The gun's body and its electronics are all finished. Adora has even begun to attach back on some of the foam parts they decided would be removed from her prototype and added back separately, so she really has no reason to hang around now that she needs her own tools and paints to do the rest, but she lingers, insisting she needs to hunt Melog down and say goodbye to him or hell hiss at her "the next time she comes over."

Catra watches, unimpressed, as Adora lays on her stomach on the shop floor to talk to Melog where he is curled up under one of the shelves. They keep the shop clean, but the floor is usually only swept, not mopped, and she wouldn't have volunteered to lay on it like this without a reason. Well, Adora has a reason, but Catra is certain it has nothing to do with Melog. She raises a brow at Adora when she finishes her several minutes of chattering at Melog and stands up again. Adora sends her a look like she just kicked a puppy as she reluctantly begins to shuffle towards the door.

"This isn't going to be the last time we talk, right?" she finally forces herself to ask. Catra's tail lashes behind her. Catra isn't willing to go so far as to say Adora *is* an asshole for how she started to ignore her in favor of her new cosplay friends, but she can't blame her for wanting to leave, even if she shouldn't have just *left* they should do it without ever talking to her. As much as Catra wants to blame her for always being the golden child and then throwing it all away to seek validation from everyone but Catra – the only one who should have *mattered* – she knows that isn't fair.

It all goes back to Weaver shit, and they were kids during that, *pretty much*. It isn't like Adora had it easy either when she failed Weaver's twisted child star aspirations, she just got closer to fulfilling them than Catra between a few modeling jobs and her interest in cosplay. Neither of them turned out to be the stars Weaver wanted to bleed dry. They both ended up working backstage in the theater group she had them join instead of being out in front of crowds to potentially be scouted. When they managed to snag jobs at the Horde based on their amateur work, they thought they were finally getting out, but it turns out Hordak was just a new, slightly less demonic version of Weaver.

"I never said you could come back. Unlike some people, I have a real job," Catra says. Anyone else would take it as an insult. Adora, instead, beams.

It wasn't a no. As much as how Adora left grates at Catra, it has been three years. They've grown, maybe. She can't find out unless

they talk. Adora still seems a bit like an overexcitable child – Catra still *l oth* – but Catra knows the last three years have changed her a lot, and while she's sure Adora wasn't going through the same shit she was, she knows it isn't *ea* to be an influencer, especially not for someone like Adora who is sensitive and caring and shit.

Besides, Weaver would *at* them to hate each other. Catra might be bitter by nature, but she isn't about to let that bitch win. She isn't ready to be nice to Adora, but she can talk to her at least. If these last few days are anything to go by, that's enough for her right now.

Chapter End Notes

I was just pulling stuff out of my ass so any resemblance to real conventions/characters/properties (aside from She-ra itself) is a coincidence. Idk why but it tends to "break immersion" for me when other properties come up inside of fic so I won't be using anything real.

The Horde is like the prop workshop equivalent of Buzzfeed in this universe lol. They're a well-known (non-unionized) juggernaut a lot of studios go to. It's consistent work, but it sucks.

There will be a lot more cosplay/public-facing stuff in other chapters, this one was just the re-uniting thread and then I got way to into the logistics of the build. I have absolutely no idea if the infusing resin thing would actually work, but I know how tough resin is so shhhh it's fine

Jilt x Ginger

Chapter Summary

> Jilt - reluctantly - goes to BannetCon. She meets an eager Ginger.

Chapter Notes

> Everybody has Instagram and Twitter accounts, but their handles are the same for both. Display names differ and also are updated as time passes anyway. In general, however: Catra |Wildcat W orkshop =Instagram. Wildcat W orkshop = Twitter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Considering how frigid Catra's response was to Adora asking to talk more, she wasnt expecting them to suddenly be best friends again, but she's still disappointed with how little they are talking. Catra has turned off read receipts now they arent helping her be petty , so Adora cant really tell what she has seen and what she has ignored, but she only replies to about half of her messages in the first two days after Adora leaves her shop.

Its still big progress for them, but every unanswered message leaves Adora feeling hollow and the letdown leaves her unmotivated. She forces herself to work on the prop whenever she can –she cant fuck up the first thing they've worked on together in a long time –but there is plenty of downtime while the prop is drying that she just cant make herself do anything with. She still has two cosplays she needs to finish for a con coming up, but instead she lays around and spends too much time on Instagram.

Its technically her job, but she' s wallowing. She decides she needs advice on how to get out of a slump and, like a true addict, she asks Instagram for it via her story. She isnt expecting anything that

helpful, really, mostly just inviting conversation – something something it's good for building relationships with her fans, really she's just lonely and bored while both Glimmer and Bow are at work – but she is shocked when, for the first time in *the* , Catra initiates conversation for herself.

Catra | Wildcat Workshop replied to your story
My mood's been down lately and it's totally killing my creative process
Anyone have recommendations for getting out of rut?
Tap to view

What's so serious that S3EP13 won't fix it

You remember 😟

That emoj makes me want to commit unspeakable violence

Why :(

Because it's pathetic and must be destroyed for its weakness

Wow. Your next cosplay should be a supervillain

Tell Entrapta. She's the one who decides that
I could totally pull off Skeletor's loincloth

Okay, so Catra is apparently willing to show that she cares in certain circumstances. She didn't need to say the show for them to both know she was talking about She-ra, and she didn't need to ask to still know it was Adora's comfort show. Adora doesn't need it when she has Catra *taking* to her though, especially when she is doing her best to come up with any reply to Catra's loincloth comment that

could be appropriate. If Catra was any of her other friends, she wouldnt hesitate to tell her how hot she would look as Skeletor , but it's *fine* , so Adora cant just say things like that no matter how badly she wants to.

I thought this was , she settles on sending back. Skeletor was the big bad for season three and his costume was ridiculous. Adora loved the season three finale because She-ra finally reunited with her sidekick who had been kidnapped all season. As a kid, Adora both loved and hated the plotline –on one hand, she believed She-ra and Teela were meant to be, and on the other hand she loved the magicat character that took over Teela's role for the season and worked with She-ra to rescue her –so the episode where it came to a close was the best of both worlds.

She found out a few years ago that the whole season was written that way to get around Teela's actress being pregnant and unable to film for a few months. It made her appreciate the plotline more, even if Skeletor was a dumb villain who totally wouldnt have been competent enough to keep Teela captive. She has watched the finale a few times since losing Catra and almost every single time was to deal with the fact that Catra wasnt there –or with something that would have been *fine* if she had Catra to turn to.

She loves Glimmer and Bow. Theyre her best friends. But they arent her soulmates the way Catra was. It' s so much easier to breathe with Catra texting her back immediately, insisting she doesnt *actually* say anything to Entrapta because she would do it without any concern for laws or Instagram's policies banning her for rocking Skeletor's shirtless look. Adora takes a risk on teasing her back and Catra doesnt leave her on read, she just keeps teasing her.

Maybe, *maybe* , theyre going to be okay . Maybe Adora caught her at bad times before, or maybe this is just going to be touchier than she hoped, but Catra is talking to her on occasion at least. It's something after *years* of nothing. It will be enough.

--

"Got a new job for you, trapta," Catra declares as Entrapta walks back into the shop with Scorpia. Entrapta squeals and shoves her lunch bag into Scorpia's arms, rushing forward and leaning over Catra's desk.

"Oh, I was getting so bored, *tell* me it's exciting. Does it have lasers? Robotic limbs? I want to build something that walks around this time," Entrapta gushes. Catra's tail twitches beside her. She is more than aware of Entrapta's current boredom. Entrapta roped her into going to BannetCon with her just last week despite the short notice because she decided she needed to make another cosplay to fill her time. Her character was one half of a duo anyway, and Catra agreed mostly because *her* laser whip looked like a lot of fun—playing with cool props is pretty much the only reason she ever cosplays—but she needed to find a job for Entrapta fast before she decided to use her free time to assemble a nuclear reactor or something.

She doesn't need to be added to *another* watchlist. Being on the no-fly list would really hamper her ability to attend cons, and she loves to do that.

"Robot squid for an interactive horror experience. We have a call with the client tomorrow to go over details, but I already sent the rough size and appearance specs to your workstation," Catra tells her. A fire lights in Entrapta's eyes and she immediately takes off, rushing past Scorpia and snatching her bag back out of her arms as she disappears back to her corner. Catra chuckles to herself as Scorpia blinks at the air where Entrapta used to be.

"Well, good she's having fun," Scorpia decides, one of her classic non-observations that used to annoy Catra when they first met, but she's gotten used to them now. She almost finds it endearing. Catra

throws a hand up, making grabby hands in Scorpia's direction. Scorpia walks forward, placing her to-go bag on Catra's desk and pulling out the various containers for their lunch. Catra immediately snags one.

"Anything new for us?" Scorpia asks as she digs around in the bag for a plastic fork. Catra shakes her head. Scorpia is kind of new to this business and Catra is still working on building up a client base now that she's broken from the Horde. Entrapta has been making robotics and tech for the movie industry for years and she already has her name on several people's call lists, so she tends to be in higher demand than Catra and Scorpia, especially with her more specialized skillset.

The whole administrative side of those jobs was kind of a nightmare for her, though, and for her own good she needed a supervisor to reign her in from, say, *hypothetically*, hacking into a government database to make sure her build matches specifications that civilians *absolutely do not have access to*. Catra handles the business side of things, as well as material sourcing, while Entrapta and Scorpia get to just build. In Scorpia's case, she also works on shop and equipment maintenance in her downtime.

"I'm trying to see if I can get some more props commissioned for this living horror movie thing, but no word yet. Ill let you know. Focus on the spaceship build for now," Catra tells her. Scorpia nods as she starts digging into her own food. The thin periods between commissions are stressful, but it's still better than the *constant* stress of working at the Horde.

"I'm almost done with the welding. I think Ill have it ready by tonight. Youll have plenty of time to work on it before the con," Scorpia tells her before taking an *extra*-sized bite. Catra nods. She has been prototyping how she wants to go about making it. It's whip during her free time ever since Entrapta asked Catra to go with her on their delivery to BannetCon – Entrapta was supposed to deliver the scale-model spaceship on her own until she got bored – but Catra will be happy to set it aside for a paying job. Their first prototype for the

spaceship turned out to be perfect, so they'd ahead of schedule on the build and Catra isn't worried about running out of time to get both done despite the con's swift approach.

"I checked it out while you guys were gone. It looks good. Your detail work has really improved," Catra tells her . The model is going to be a mix of materials, but in addition to the arm affixing it to the base, some of the outer plating is metal too. Scorpia produced some scrap trying to get it right, but it looks great in the end. Scorpia beams at her as she takes another bite. Catra doesn't tend to give out compliments freely, but she knows that if she wants to hang onto her talent, she has to provide something the Horde doesn't. She can't guarantee a steady paycheck, but she can make an environment worth being in. It has nothing to do with *affection* for her friends or anything equally stupid.

She's making progress, alright, slowly and largely due to Scorpia and Entrapta's presence in her life ever since they all happened to meet on a rush job at the Horde that had them hiring extra freelancers, but sometimes emotion is still a bit too raw for her. It's why she still sometimes ignores Adora's messages despite how fucking badly she has missed her. She clung to bitterness to drown it out for a long time, but that has been harder to do as time has passed and Adora has continued to try, especially now Catra is in a good place in her own life.

It felt supremely shitty for Adora to start *ignoring* her as she dove deeper into the cosplay community and prioritized building connections there, but three years later she's still sending Catra messages to show she's thinking of her. Catra is touchy and prone to regression, but Adora has been trying to worm her way back into her life for a long time and Catra finally feels ready to let her. She's doing a lot better since shaking free of the Horde. She can give praise now without needing an immediate exit strategy to cut its importance. She can just sit beside Scorpia as she smiles into her lunch and find the silence comfortable.

Maybe shell message Adora tonight. It will be easy to if she has posted something dumb on her story that she can make fun of. The chances are good.

--

Adora 🔜 BannetCon @SJ

Con crunch is real 😩 Note to self: dont commit to two new cosplays for the same con ever again #BannetCon

💬 🔁 ❤️

Glimmer @Gimmebuff *@Syngto*

You do it because you love us <3 Y our Ginger is going to look great!! Once you finish it lol

---

Adora 🔜 BannetCon @SJ *@Syngto*
@Gimmebuff

The group cosplay was your idea and that means YOURE going to help me sew in the hotel room at 2am

---

Glimmer @Gimmebuff *@Syngto*

Brb checking to see if Perfuma has space in her room for me

Mermista *@Sky Starlight*

You live together cant you just make her help now

Adora **BannetCon** *@Sky Starlight*
@Glimmer

Omg wait

Glimmer *@Sky Starlight*
@Glimmer

Next time Sea Hawk sets something on fire Im not helping you put it out

---

Adora **BannetCon** *@Sky Starlight*
@Glimmer

Cherry helped Ginger get ready for the embassy ball <3 get over here

--

"You know, you've had weeks to work on this," Glimmer points out. Adora pouts at her, but Glimmer isn't looking at her, busy marking a dart point with pins for her. Adora *has* been working, just mostly on her other cosplay since it was more complicated. She can sew

Ginger's bodysuit by hand on the road if she needs too. She couldn't do that with a battledress that needed Worbla and paint.

"I've been busy ," Adora returns. She' s the only member of the house who doesn't have a normal fulltime job, but that doesn't mean her job *i s n't* fulltime, not if she wants to maintain her momentum. The internet is fickle and she knows it could all go away at any time. She spends a lot of time interacting with people on her page when she isn't sewing, or prototyping, or trying to get commissions, or arranging travel, or taking photos-

She does a *l o t*, it's just untraditional.

"Busy *m o o n i n g*," Glimmer replies. Alright, so Glimmer and Bow have also found her lying on the couch a lot recently, but she had her whole downturn when Catra didn't immediately fall into her arms and then she had her *u p s u n* where Catra started talking to her more and Adora would drop everything to reply to her, sprawling across the nearest surface and kicking her feet in the air like she's still a teenager. Glimmer and Bow spent about a year trying to encourage Adora to let Catra go before they seemed to realize it was hopeless. They've been equally relieved and concerned by the recent turn of events.

"That' s mostly in the evening when she's free. Your sample is skewed," Adora tells her . Truthfully, she and Catra are not talking nearly enough for it to impact her productivity. If anything, it helps. She feels better and that helps her creative drive and her motivation. Catra is still ignoring here a bit, but she's replying more, and the longer it lasts the less terrifying it is when a message goes unread.

"Uh huh. Y ou know you have to finish this if you don't want to be naked when you see her next weekend," Glimmer says. Adora would point out that's not how any of this works – she has *t w o* other costumes she could wear, after all, not to mention the ones in storage – but she is too busy freezing at Glimmer 's words.

"She' s going to be at BannetCon?" Adora asks. Catra has mostly been posting about builds on her Instagram and she hasn't been offering a lot of personal information when they do talk. Catra likes working with her hands and the challenge of bringing a fictional build to life, but she isn't really in geek culture herself. She never really cared about cons, or even cosplay outside of the props. Adora knew Entrapta was going, but Catra doesn't have much reason to.

"I guess. Entrapta messaged Bow about adding her onto the photoshoot they were going to do Sunday. She's going to be in it. Nova's partner," Glimmer tells her , shrugging. Adora's tongue darts out to wet her lips.

"What time was that going to be again?" she asks. Glimmer sends her an unimpressed look. Whatever. Adora knew she was desperate three years of unanswered messages ago. If Glimmer didn't want her to go, she shouldn't have mentioned it.

--

If they didn't have a display piece to deliver , Catra would have turned down Entrapta's request for a cosplay partner , but there was no way to make a replica of this spaceship without some small –breakable – parts. Entrapta isn't unreliable or anything, but there are certain things she shouldn't be trusted with and that includes anything breakable. Catra only buys a ticket for Saturday, though. They're expensive last minute and between the delivery Friday night and going along with Entrapta's photoshoot plans on Sunday, the weekend is going to be busy enough for her.

She will have plenty of free time to kill, but she still doubts she is going to see Adora. Adora was at least smart enough to bring one old cosplay –her signature one –but her posts leading up to the event show that her workshop is even more hectic than it was when

she was crunching on the commission. Even if she isn't sewing into the night, she's a featured guest and part of a panel, so Catra is anticipating that she'll be busy all weekend. Unless Catra wants to show up to her meet-and-greet like a pining loser, she's unlikely to stumble upon her.

Unfortunately for her, the only memo Entrapta ever got regarding Adora was that she and Catra were talking again, so she doesn't hesitate to drag Catra through the con and straight to Adora's meet-and-greet table when Catra isn't paying attention.

"Entrapta! Oh, h-hi, Catra," Adora stutters out, like an *idiot*, breaking character in an instant and blinking down at Catra. Catra raises a brow at her—Adora doesn't need help making a fool of herself, but usually she doesn't *start* that *right* off the bat—before she remembers how she is dressed. Catra isn't ashamed and Adora has worn less at cons—not to mention her *holy* participation in Thirsty Thursday on Instagram—but this is the first time Adora has seen her in just a tight leotard, leather jacket, and thigh highs. Well, good to know Adora can still appreciate her, even if she never *did* anything about it.

"Hey, Adora," she purrs out, lifting her hand to give a noncommittal wave. She's always up for flirting with Adora, but Adora has to work for it, especially after Catra was dragged along to her booth. She can't risk Adora thinking this was her idea. Entrapta managed to find Adora at a moment when she was alone, but Catra can already see a hopeful fan lurking a few feet away out of the corner of her eye. She doesn't want to deal with any of that. The few times she has seen Adora in passing over the last few years of delivering to cons, Adora was *always* talking to somebody.

"Uh, both your cosplays look great! Those pauldrons look so cool, you did a great job, Entrapta," Adora compliments, sending them both a smile as she reaches out and runs a finger along the zipper decorating the edge of Catra's flared pleather pauldrons. The jacket is ridiculous but Catra kind of loves it. Entrapta outdid herself. Catra would usually growl at someone attempting to touch her costume

without asking, but it's Adora, and it's to admire Entrapta's work, so she lets her. It has nothing to do with the fact that Catra wants Adora's hands on her at all times.

"Isn't it great? I couldn't be Nova without a jet, but I also just really wanted to make the jacket. We're going to take pictures with Bow tomorrow, I can't wait!" Entrapta gushes. Adora asks a question about what Entrapta used for her own vest and Catra checks out of the conversation. Not that she is ignoring them, Adora just isn't looking at her right now and she can't pass up the opportunity to trace her eyes over her body and enjoy the wonderful form her unitard is giving her.

Catra has seen her sewing it on her Instagram story – it is deceptively detailed, with a lot of panels from like six different fabrics and some hand-placed gem details – but she isn't familiar with the character, so Adora just looks a bit dumb and hot to her. It's a good look on her. Her She-ra cosplay shows off most of her arms and legs, the little battle skirt doing nothing to hide her form, but Catra always appreciates a new way to ogle Adora. She hasn't gotten to do it in person in a while. She knew Adora wasn't slacking on her workouts since she posts a photo of her in the gym with her muscles glistening like once a week, but *damn*. Appreciating it in person is so much better than glaring at her phone and taking a reluctant screenshot.

"Oh, look, Catra, show her the whip! It's going to be so cool on camera," Entrapta suddenly blurts out, attention switching on a dime and turning all eyes back on Catra. Entrapta beams at her encouragingly as Adora's eyes snap to her. Catra quickly pulls her whip off her hip and takes a step back so she can unfurl it and distract the pair from the look she definitely wasn't giving Adora's arms. She gives the whip a small crack and squeezes the button hidden on the handle beneath the cloth wrap, throwing Adora a confident smile as the light sparks to life along its length.

Catra is *never* going to get tired of people looking at her builds with stars in their eyes, wondering how she even managed to bring a

fictional – and often, functionally useless but impressive-looking – item to life. The laser whip is more of an interpretation than an exact recreation – mostly because that's *impossible* – but it's still pretty damn impressive if she says so herself. Adora's hanging jaw – and the small murmur amongst those within eyeshot – seems to agree with her.

"How are you not the prop master for like, every show at this point?" Adora asks. A few people are pulling out their phones now, but Catra releases the button for the moment and the light dies, leaving her holding what *looks* like a normal – if blue – whip. She doesn't want the lights to overheat and she has a feeling someone is going to ask her for a picture as soon as this conversation is done.

"Because half the industry is waving around little green placeholder rods at this point," Catra comments derisively as she begins curling her whip back up. She freezes when Adora steps forward – steps *close* – and reaches out to run her fingers over the whip.

"How'd you do it?" she asks. Catra is relieved Adora's eyes are fixed down on the prop, because if Adora looked her in the eye, standing so close and looking like *that*, she might make a fool of herself.

"Light rope, window frosting spray for diffusion, and then I wrapped it in the most plasticky nylon I could find so the threads catch the light," Catra lists off, even though she really shouldn't be giving away her secrets to the enemy. Whatever. It's not that hard to guess once you've seen it, most people are just thinking too small. The hard part is making the button and battery pack work in the handle anyway. It took Catra awhile to figure out, but Entrapta was doing real work and she didn't want to bother her.

"This is one of the coolest things I've ever seen at a con," Adora says. Catra's ears twitch and she does her best to keep her expression aloof as Adora looks up and makes eye contact with her. She's so damn *cute*, her smile lighting up her whole face and her blue eyes *taunting* Catra with their sparkle.

"You have low standards," Catra replies. Adora pouts and it's *cute*, making Catra want lean forward and nip her lip, but no matter how many times Catra has had that intrusive thought, she has never acted on it and never *would*. There have been so many times when it seemed like Adora felt the gap between them as much as Catra does, but as soon as they step close – as soon as it seems like they're finally going to cross it – Adora always pulls back. Adora seems to have an appreciative eye for her and that's about it. Catra would honestly prefer Adora *not* give her the hope of kissing her if all she would be interested in was one night, but it fucking kills her sometimes.

"You set a high bar. It looks great," Adora shoots back. Catra's face feels hot. Adora is still standing *right* there while Catra's thoughts are turning as dirty as they are bitter and she cant handle compliments on a good day.

"Even you could do this. If you left the wiring to me," Catra returns. Adora snorts, glancing down at the whip one last time and then dropping her hand from it.

Catra cant decide if she is grateful or annoyed when one of the lurkers chooses to interpret that as a cue the conversation is done and slides in asking for a picture. On one hand, Adora finally steps back. On the other, *[illegible]*.

Whatever. It was going to happen. It always does.

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Do you still take your workbag with you everywhere

It’s not everywhere

To every prop installation, which you are doing right now

What do you want

I need you to save me again

Are you sure you should even be taking commissions

It’s not a commission
The battery burnt out in my sword. I have to open it up to replace it
Which I didnt really plan for when making it, so I basically have to cut open the side
I need to borrow a knife and some clamps to hold it together while the glue dries
And hopefully the paint will still look halfway decent and it will hold together for the panel

Wouldnt it be better to go one day without the lights and use the proper tools at home

I cant. It needs the lights. Im not She-ra without it
We have a panel and photos tomorrow. Not having the lights will be more of a problem than hiding damage on one side

How do they even work anyway

It’s a remote control. I just hide it in my pocket usually

Did you check the battery in the remote first

…

Wow
Is your little squad your minders

How did you make it this far on your own
You need to be kept on a leash at this rate

Power of friendship <3 do you have a tiny screwdriver I can borrow

Yeah sure
Room 415

--

Adora cant know if the remote or the sword itself is the problem until she gets up to Catra's room and can take the backing off to check the remote's battery, but of course Catra is right. Adora pouts when Catra sends her a smug smirk, but she would far rather Catra be right than have to cut into her beloved prop. It's the first big piece she made after leaving the Horde. Her She-ra cosplay is basically synonymous with her face. The character had been dormant when she picked it up as her first – in her opinion – good cosplay as a teenager.

With thirty years passed since the show wrapped filming and a resemblance to the actress in her younger years, Adora has become She-ra on the con circuit at this point. Wearing a cosplay – especially She-ra, since she is Adora's most familiar character – gives her the confidence to do things she normally would be a nervous wreck during, like host retro fan events for the studio . She failed all of Weaver's attempts to teach her acting, but she can get in character, especially *this* character, and the idea of damaging her main prop for it was kind of panicking her. Call it a crutch if you want, but she watches with relief as Catra weighs the sword in her hand, not *quite* swinging it around but clearly testing out how it feels.

"I don't know how you don't hit more people walking around with this," Catra comments, tossing the sword from her right hand to her left. Anyone else and Adora would feel an instant spike of anxiety, but she knows that Catra isn't going to drop it. Her hands are quicker than that, and if anybody understands how important the sword is to her, it's Catra. They watched every episode of She-ra together as kids. They weren't allowed a lot of things that were fun, but once Adora started parroting the lines, Weaver let them watch it whenever they wanted in hopes that it would ignite a passion for acting. Adora just liked the characters and Catra just enjoyed being allowed to do something frivolous for once.

"I used to be clumsier with it, but I'm really used to it now," Adora admits with a shrug. To her surprise, Catra chirrups and turns the sword over, inspecting it. It's way better than the first sword Adora built as a teenager—it's not *good* with some clever finishing, for one thing, and Bow did a great job with the lights—but she doesn't know what Catra is thinking about when it comes to the sword. After a minute of inspecting, including holding the sword up to her face so she can sight down the length of the blade as if looking for asymmetry, Catra finally lowers it and looks back at Adora.

"Scorpia's really good at metalwork," Catra says, a non sequitur, except it's *not*. Adora stares at her, her hearing suddenly staticky. Catra shrugs, as if that's a casual statement to make, except she is holding her body carefully still in a way that will never transfer to her tail no matter how she tries. It's twitching nervously behind her. "And Entrapta has a new fiberoptic set I think I could make mimic the magic from the show better," she adds, running her finger along the edge of the sword where a thin piece of rainbow acrylic is wedged to let the light rod core shine out through the sword. Adora is still just staring.

"I know it's your baby, but this one *is* going to burn out eventually. Just something to think about," Catra finishes, shrugging as she holds the sword back out to Adora by the handle. Adora tries to lift her arm and nothing happens. Catra looks away, nudging the sword

a little towards her as if Adora somehow *mi ed* it. Her face is steadily flushing as Adora continues to just stare at her .

"Are you *se e* you don't like me?" Adora eventually says, because she doesn't know how to act like a normal human and just say thank you. Luckily for her , neither does Catra, because that startles a laugh out of her. Catra looks back to throw her a lopsided smile as Adora finally manages to reach out and take the sword from her. Its weight is familiar in her hand – comforting. She can't imagine just replacing it, but she also knows that Catra has a point. The sword is well-cared for, but it is also *ba -l od* and even if its lights are working again – for now – it has gotten a number of dings and scrapes over the years that she has just had to fill in and cover up as best as she could.

"Positive. I've just wanted to make that sword since I was five," Catra tells her. Adora is pretty sure both statements are lies. Catra liked the show, but not as much as Adora did, and the sword isn't that interesting from a prop perspective, not unless you go in *he d* on the lights, and even then it's more likely to make the build a nightmare instead of fun.

"I'll keep it in mind," Adora tells her , because she *fi ni te w l* , even if she needs some time to think about it – and probably time to save too, if she decides to go through with it. "You know, the one in the show wasn't even metal," she adds as she runs her hand down the length of the blade. There were a few shots in the show where you could see the prop bending in ways that metal *ba y* shouldn't. The lights were her own addition too. The show used 80s-quality special effects for its magic that Adora will always find more charming than anything photorealistic CGI can do, and a realistic recreation of the prop would probably just be rubber with a solid core.

Catra's smirk curves further up.

"Then the new She-ra gets an upgrade," Catra says. The smile on her face makes Adora desperately want to kiss her. That's not a thought she's supposed to have, but Catra's *si l* in her ill cosplay and Adora kind of wants to shove her incredibly well-made jacket of f

her shoulders and run her hands over the bodysuit that is tight enough she might as well be naked in it.

Entrapta is hacking *something* on the other end of the hotel room, even if her back is to them, and Adora can't ruin her chance at getting Catra back by making a move now.

"Thanks for saving my ass," she settles on. Catra snorts as she bends to put the screwdriver back in her bag.

"It's only the thousandth time," Catra replies. It really is.

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Wildcat Workshop *@wildcatworkshop*

Just had to save the mighty She-ra from the powerful dark magic of dead batteries 😳 Don't worry the sword of power is ready to slay demons again #BannetCon

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Adora | BannetCon panel Sunday *@wildcatworkshop*
Replying to @wildcatworkshop

My hero <3 Eternia will thank you

Wildcat Workshop *@wildcatworkshop* *Replying to @wildcatworkshop*

You're such a nerd I dont know why I talk to you

--

After Saturday, Catra isnt really that surprised when Adora shows up in the middle of her photoshoot with Entrapta. Shooting with Bow has always been a mixed bag – on one hand, he's really good and super nice, on the other, he's Adora's best friend and Catra hated his existence for a while there – but Entrapta has always shot with him, so Catra has begrudgingly endured it. It isnt really a problem this time though, mostly because he has no reason to try to corner her and talk about Adora or her *feelings* in between takes with Adora already here.

She mostly lurks in the background and calls encouragement. Occasionally she helps them throw the whip up into the air for a shot or something similar. It feels *nice* to be dicking around together again, just like it did when they were in the shop. They never got to play around as kids, but with cosplay they can. It's sad that they can finally feel free at twenty-three, in some random parking garage, but Catra finds herself laughing when Adora trips over her whip – despite the fact Catra has it lit up specifically so Adora can see it because she *thought* she might do that – and it just feels nice.

Its a good thing, because they want action shots with the whip and it makes the shoot take a *long* time. It would be arduous if they were sniping at each other. After so much time, they arent about to leave before theyre happy, so Catra ends up sitting at the base of a concrete wall with Adora leaning beside her as they wait for Entrapta to go through Bow's photo roll with him and decide if what they have is good enough. Catra is tired, and she blames that on why she leans back to rest and just slightly slumps over so she's also leaning against Adora's legs.

Adora *gasps*, calling attention to the touch in a way Catra absolutely did not want her to. She pins her ears back and gives a low growl. Adora, wisely, doesn't say anything else, not even moving. After a few moments of silence, Catra drops her growl and lets her eyes fall closed. Entrapta better decide she's done because *Adora* sure is. As much as she wants good pictures of the whip, she really just wants a nap at this point. She has a long drive back to the coast before she can get that, so they kind of need to *pack things up* here.

"I was talking to Entrapta at the panel this morning," Adora says, in a tone of voice that immediately makes Catra's ears twitch back. Catra spent the morning laying around their hotel room, taking a half day off while Entrapta went and explored the last day of the con. It was nice carving out some small time for an actual vacation in the middle of this trip, but it was a *mistake*, because Adora is clearly up to something. Adora decides to respond to her twitching ears by dropping a hand into her hair and petting over them. This touch is way too intimate for them now and she should shake Adora off, but unfortunately it feels *nice* and she has to force down a purr.

"I've always wanted to make a Clawdeen cosplay," Adora continues, causing Catra's ears to twitch again. Catra has been very resistant to Adora's attempts to involve her in cosplay in the past. She didn't mind Adora's cosplay at first even if it didn't interest her personally, at least aside from some bitterness that Weaver let her do it when she wouldn't let Catra do fucking *anything*, but Catra wanted nothing to do with it once it started feeling like cosplay was taking Adora away from her. Catra was suddenly bitter and unpleasant to be around when Adora was making her costumes, so they spent even less time together as Adora dove further into the community.

Catra just wanted it all to *stop*. She wanted them to be best friends again, and for Adora to actually be focused on her or even on *work* when they were together, just anything other than the thing that was tearing them apart. Catra felt like she lost her long before Adora told her that she was going to quit the Horde and she blamed cosplay for all of it. She never would have agreed to cosplay with her three, or

even five, years ago. She was only willing to do it with Entrapta because her general attitude towards it was so far removed from Adora. She can guess that's what they talked about after the panel.

"What, you want a racial sensitivity consultant? You'd look dumb in cat ears," Catra replies, even though she *knows* what Adora wants. Really she just needs time to think. Cosplaying with Adora is at the bottom of Catra's list of reunion activities, but it could be a good test, if nothing else. She doesn't know *what* she would be testing, but it feels like some significant shift would come from it. It could be a bad one. The odds might lean more that way than anything else, actually. In her hair, Adora's hand stills.

"I wouldn't do that, you know I don't do cosplay like that," Adora mutters back. Catra flicks an ear in acknowledgment. She knows. Some cosplayers will put on prosthetic ears – or on the other side, edit their tails out from photos – to "match" a character. It's kind of a divisive topic in the community. Catra mostly finds it dumb and annoying. Adora, meanwhile, doesn't even do character makeup. She will put makeup on to *match* a character that wears it, but she doesn't try to change her face with contour like the shit Catra sees Sea Hawk doing on his live. It's fine, impressive maybe, but she likes Adora's face how it is.

"I'm just asking for one con. I'll buy your ticket. Please? I just... I want you to experience it like I do," Adora says, shifting her hand to cup the side of Catra's head. She rubs at the base of her ear with her thumb, but she's definitely just trying to encourage Catra to stay close. Adora's logic is – *honestly* – kind of flawed. Catra never cosplayed when they parted ways, but she's done four in the last few years, even doing one on her own just because she wanted to make the character's stupid big gatling gun – complete with rotating barrel – and Entrapta offered to make her the costume so she could get some good photos with it to promote her build. She only went to a con in cosplay once – well, twice once this weekend is done – but she *has* experienced it.

She just hasn't done it with Adora.

"And you think the way for me to do that is to cosplay as your *sidekick*, and not even your main one?" Catra responds, because yeah, she *kind of* gets it, but it also feels a bit like proof that Adora hasn't changed. Catra would have come back to her years ago if she thought Adora would actually make her a priority – not even her main one! Just *one* – but Adora obviously missing her didn't mean that she had changed.

Above her, Adora blanches. She shifts, not pulling away, but definitely looking down at her. Catra doesn't open her eyes. It needs to be said, but despite the bitterness still lurking in her heart, Catra is too tired to fight. She's tired *of* fighting. She doesn't want to get back at Adora – she wants *this*. She just knows it is never going to be in the way she wants. She has been working on accepting that for three years, but she has to make it clear that she won't let herself be treated like that again.

"Catra, *no*, I just– She's the only recurring magical girl in the show. This isn't– I– I want to cosplay with you because I want you to *see* – it was never about ignoring you," Adora says, inelegantly, but Catra wasn't really expecting her to come up with better. "I know I messed up, but I never saw you as secondary, I just couldn't imagine *anyone* wanting to stay if there was another option. I know it was a mistake, but I always cared what you wanted." Catra growls lowly under her breath. It isn't a warning – she *hates* to hear Adora say stuff like that, even if she's still a dumbass – but she's annoyed.

"We would have talked about it more if I wasn't desperate, but I couldn't have lasted there much longer. It was killing us both. I was a few weeks away from collapsing and ending up in the hospital," Adora adds, her voice quiet and strained. Catra snaps her head up, finally looking at Adora. Adora's face is pinched and her gaze is fixed on her dumb boots, but considering Catra is leaning against her leg, it doesn't do anything to hide the anxiety in her eyes. Adora *never told her that*. She complained about how abusive their job was by the end, sure, but she never told Catra it was affecting her that badly. Catra assumed she felt the same way about it as she did: it was

awful and they were all overworked, but it was enough to make rent, and at least it wasn't W eaver.

Catra swallows, leaning her head to the side to press it against Adora's leg. Adora's eyes dart to her, expression still anxious.

"I'll do it with you if the con is within driving distance and I don't have to sew," she finally says. For the first time ever , she doesn't feel like there's a point in going back to three years ago. Clearly they were both in vastly different – and *h* – mental spaces. They've both missed each other. Maybe that can be enough. The idea of being only a friend to Adora – not even a best friend, because she has new ones that took Catra's place years ago and that she lives with now, people who are actually part of her cosplay world – hurts, but she knows that's likely where they're headed. As much as she hates it, it has to be better than just stalking her Instagram and yearning.

"Are you sure?" Adora asks, her voice soft. Her expression is raw , but at least it isn't overtaken with anxiety anymore. She' s looking at Catra with hope, like she really just *wants* this and she doesn't mind Catra being unable to give her admission the acknowledgement it would deserve from everyone else, but from her this *i s* a lot. Catra swallows, cautiously turning her head to press her cheek against Adora's leg. She doesn't rub against it, that' s just too much, especially considering Adora is in She-ra's mini battledress and Catra is leaning against her bare leg, but her cheek is still there, inherently leaving some traces of her scent on her.

"Y eah. Just listen to me, this time. *Value* me," Catra replies. It has to be said. Adora offers her a wobbly smile.

"I will. I'll show it better ," she promises. Catra flicks her ear that isn't pressed against Adora. Adora draws in a breath, clearly steeling herself for something as she forces herself to hold eye contact. "Don't ignore my messages?" she asks. Catra nods, which rubs her cheek against Adora's leg. Oh well. Adora knows what it feels like to be ignored now. Catra doesn't have a point to keep proving, not as long as Adora actually does better now.

"Yeah, okay," she agrees. Just two words, but Adora gives her a smile that is threatening to fill with tears. Fuck, Catra's heart hurts, but she thinks it's good. Adora cares. She's trying. Catra can try too.

She's still grateful when she hears Bow call them over. She can only do so much in a day, especially when she's tired like this. Adora offers her a hand and helps pull her up. When they walk over, Bow is watching them carefully, but she doesnt think he has anything to worry about. Despite Adora's wet eyes, she thinks they're okay. Theyll be okay.

She's so ready for that nap now. Maybe shell make Entrapta drive them back so she can curl up for a bit.

Chapter End Notes

She-ra was basically a Xena Warrior Princess-style show in this AU. She-ra's costume for it was a mix of hers from the 80s original and Xena's. When I was researching to decide that, I got paralyzed by how gay I was looking at screenshots of Lucy Lawless.
Also, no it's not an error, the sword of power is what He-man's sword was called. Im using a lot of He-man elements too because I Can and I dont often get to play around with them. Apparently this AU is more niche than I thought so if there's ever anything in here that needs elaboration (do people know what a CNC machine is? Yes? No?) feel free to shoot me an ask or something.

Clawdeen

Chapter Summary

Clawdeen gets her hands on She-ra's sword

Chapter Notes

As usual in my modern AUs, the Concept of homophobia exists, but it is considered an old, bigoted mindset. That's why the original She-ra was allowed to be as gay as it was (but still not explicitly, textually gay) like fifteen years before Xena aired. Referring to a costume as a character's name ("Packing up She-ra for the con") and referring to the costume as the character 's pronouns ("I'm working on *he* right now") is normal in the cosplay community and the language I'm going to use for this fic because it would just come across as stilted to me otherwise. **CW**: casual slut-shaming language as a joke between friends. There will probably be more of it going forward, but when Catra teases Adora about how she posts on Instagram, she really is just teasing.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora posted a story
Gonna be making my dream cosplay with my dream person soon <3 3
Any guesses what it is?
Type something

--

Adora replied to your story

Just got roped into doing the lamest cosplay ever

Tap to view

:((it’s not lame

Have you looked at it
The skirt alone
It looks like a leather loincloth
With fur sewn on the bottom for. Idk. What’s the reason
It certainly isn’t aesthetics

She’s the queen of the Crimson Waste

So put her in something queenly
Or at least practical
The top is fine ig
It’s the least offensive part

It’s gonna look hot when I’m done with it

So you’re redesigning it

Never
But you can pull it off

I can look hot in spite of it yes
But it’s dumb

We should trade

I do not have the tits to fill out your She-ra dress
I’d prefer not to get banned on Instagram when it falls off

That gives me ideas
But no
I meant Ill make the costume and you make the sword

She-ra’s sword?

Yeah
I mean Ill still pay you obvs
I know the cost of making Clawdeen's outfit is way less than the sword

Alright
We just got a pretty big commission

Good!!

But it's mostly on me
So after I find time for prototyping the sword Scorpia can get started on it
Entrapta is building a robot too but she doesnt need help with that
At least not until it's time for me to do the silicone
Adora it's fucking huge the skin is going to take me ages

Ooo what is it?

Giant man-eating squid
Emphasis on giant
Im working on more props for its exhibit
But Ill probably have free time by the time Scorpia is done with her part on the sword

Okay!! I have to work on Clawdeen's costume too
Im also going to open commissions again now the con is over
So Ill have stuff to keep me busy
But you should still come visit
I need your measurements and I wanna show you the workshop

Maybe when I need a break
How far are you

A little more than an hour from the workshop

Gross
But honestly not that bad
Okay Ill think about it

--

Adora is so eager when Catra comes to visit that she actually waits for her out in the driveway for the last twenty minutes, roaming around the front porch because she has too much energy to sit still. Luckily, Glimmer and Bow are at work—which is good for *multiple* reasons, actually—so there's no one around to judge her, even if Catra seems amused when she pulls up. She can't know how long Adora was waiting there though, so Adora just beams at her as she lets her in. She gives her a small tour as they go, but they head straight up to the bonus room that takes up most of the second floor.

"Welcome to the best friends squad workshop!" Adora declares proudly, sweeping a hand to show off the space. It isn't the perfect space for a workshop—one wall is slanted from the pointed roof and the floor is carpet, so they've had to put down some mats in the area where they paint to keep from screwing up the floor and losing their security deposit—but Adora loves the workshop. There are big electric letters on the wall declaring its name and Glimmer did a great job decorating the space. Catra's workshop is a traditional build space—which is to say, garage-like—but their studio is more of a maker space and it has the décor to match.

Catra's tail flicks as she wanders between the large work table in the middle of the room and the various stations around the walls. They all share everything, but each one of them has a wall with "their station" and the equipment they favor most. Adora has custody of the primary sewing machine, but they all use it, and Glimmer has the second one. Catra lifts her hand and trails her fingertips along the top of the cutting table as she walks past it. Adora does her best not

to follow the movement with her eyes, but there's something enchanting about such a light and intimate touch from Catra, especially in a space that Adora wasn't sure she would ever get to see her in.

"This is probably the cutesiest maker space I've ever been in," Catra decides. She definitely means for it to at least *sound* like an insult, but her tone is a little too casual to make it there. She pauses in front of Bow's 3D printer and bends to inspect it. Adora has used it to print a few accessories before, but it's kind of beyond her, so she needed Bow's help to model them. She prefers to just craft things herself.

"The hearts are Bow's thing. Glimmer is more of a rose gold and pearlescent white type. I haven't really decorated anything. I know it helps with staying inspired *now*, but when I first got here I just thought it took up space and we didn't have enough to be wasting it," Adora says with a shrug, finally moving from the entrance. She wanted to hang back and give Catra room to explore, but she's circled the room by now and made her way back to Adora's chair at her sewing machine. Catra throws her a lopsided smile as she throws herself into it and looks up at her.

"Can't decide if I can call this a downgrade or not," Catra observes as she lounges in the chair. Adora rolls her eyes, moving to lean back against the worktable in the middle the workshop so she can face Catra. She crosses her arms.

"I don't have as much equipment, but it's a nice space to be in, and it's right upstairs. I don't *need* more equipment for what I do now," Adora points out. Catra mostly seems amused by that, casting an eye around the room. Her gaze definitely sticks on Bow's heart lamp, but Adora maintains that it is cute. She usually has it turned off when she's painting because it has a red glow, but it's pretty when it's lit up and turns pink.

"I mean, a cat moved into my shop to chase the mice out, so I can't exactly judge, but I would die if I had to give up my toys," Catra tells her. Adora can't help but smile. When she first texted Catra for help,

she's pretty sure Catra would have insulted her workshop and *mat* it, but now she just seems at ease in it. She watches Catra's eyes dart to the side. "The mannequin is creepy though. At least my shop isn't haunted," Catra adds on. Adora laughs, shaking her head as she glances over to the corner of the room.

"There's a reason we usually keep it covered. Whenever it shows up in the background of a post, all the comments are about Glimmer's handiwork," Adora says. The dress form didn't come with a head, just a nob on the neck to make it easier to move it around. It would have been fine like that, except sometimes they need to make things with a hood, so they wanted *something* to help it hang from an appropriate height.

Glimmer chose to resolve that by buying a cheap foam wig head from the craft store and impaling it on the nob, but then she thought it might be uncanny or something, so she used paint to give it "monster makeup" to make it cartoonish. It wrapped right back around to creepy again. It's also funny, so they keep it, but usually they throw a cloth over it when they aren't using it. It still manages to startle one of them on a regular basis. Adora uncovered it since they're going to be doing a fitting today, but she also thought Catra would find it funny.

"I would have torn that thing up if Scorpia or Entrapta tried to put it up in our place. It's funny, but I hate it," Catra replies, eyeing the figure lurking in the corner. Honestly, Adora feels about the same, so she just shrugs. At this point she's used to it, but when it first went up she definitely spent a few days feeling unnerved by it.

"It's useful. It's not exact to any of us, but we don't really do draping so with some removable padding it works for everything except fitting," Adora says. Catra's ear flicks and she looks back to her with a raised brow.

"Speaking of, how do you want to do this? I have a feeling Entrapta's method for taking measurements is unnecessarily scientific," Catra asks, leaning back in the chair until it hits the desk and can't go back

further. It's an artful sprawl, her arms and legs everywhere, and it puts her body on display, reminding Adora that taking measurements means *taking measurements*, getting close with Catra and wrapping a tape measure around her body.

"I, uh, the normal way? I'm going to be working with inflexible material probably, so I'll make a mockup for you to check the fit on before I start using the actual fabric," Adora says, trying to focus on whatever the hell Entrapta could have done instead of what she is going to *have* to do in a few minutes. Catra snorts and then stands, raising her arms above her head and stretching out her back with a soft, satisfied groan.

The muscles in her arms quiver and a sliver of her shirt rides up as she stretches her arms. Adora's gaze is caught between the flash of Catra's stomach and the way her arms are quivering as she finishes her stretch with a satisfied sigh and drops them back down. Adora's mouth is *dry*. She tries to dart her gaze back to Catra's face and keep it there, but Catra's ears twitch with interest and Adora knows she was too late. Catra's eyes dance and then, slowly, she smirks, cocky and sure of herself in a way that makes Adora's hands want to find her waist beneath her shirt. She wants to spin her around and back her against the nearest surface until there's no room for anything in the world except how close they're pressed together.

It's a fantasy she isn't allowed to have. Catra's smirk curves further as her gaze drops down to where Adora's hands unconsciously flexed at her sides.

"Wow, desperate much?" she asks, because that fantasy didn't come from *nowhere* and they've been close once or twice.

Close, but never *there*. Adora swallows and looks away quickly.

"You just look...uh, good. Healthy," is what she manages. Catra bursts out laughing, because Adora totally deserves it. Adora's face feels hot as she hunches her shoulders. "We were always one deadline away from half-dead, alright? You look *good* and you're

actually relaxed for once. I haven't gotten to see you happy a lot," she rushes out. Catra is hot, yes, but her standing at ease and smiling at her does a lot for Adora. Catra openly snickers at her.

"Smooth. Is that what you tell all the girls you invite back to your place?" Catra teases, but she takes a step closer, and she has that *smirk* on her face, and her tail is twitching, and they've reconnected, but they've only *just* reconnected, and-

Adora is going to *die*. She never knows what to do when Catra gets close like this, but least of all now. Before, it could have ruined their friendship. Now, it could ruin any chance they have of ever rebuilding it. Adora can't *take* that. She thought she didn't want to ruin it before, but now she actually knows what life without Catra is like and she hates it.

"You invited me over first," Adora mutters, even though Catra didn't invite her over to *leer* at her. She thinks Catra is giving her signals to go ahead, but she could also just be teasing Adora because she loves to do that until she's red in the face. Even if Catra actually wants her, she has only just started replying to her messages again. What if she changes her mind and it ruins everything because Adora was desperate for her and went along with Catra's momentary impulse?

"After you *begged* me to," Catra replies, in that same flirty, teasing tone that drives Adora wild, but she takes a step back and her smirk loses its predatory curve, turning more lopsided. The charged intent dissipated from the air with Adora's words. She meant for it to.

She misses it.

"I was desperate, but it worked out in the end," Adora returns, uncrossing her arms and rolling her shoulders a little to try to work out the tension or *heat* that was that entered her body. Catra sends her a look that Adora wishes wasn't inscrutable, because the intensity of it makes it clear that it's important, but Catra doesn't say

anything to give her a clue what it means before she turns and tries to casually wander back over to Adora's sewing table.

"Says you. Im going to have to wear a fake leather bikini while you swing around a *beauti ful l y* crafted sword. Kind of got the shitty end of the bargain," Catra says. Adora tries to breathe normally , taking a second to control her pulse before she pushes off the worktable. She crosses over to the drawer where she keeps the measuring tape.

"Y ou know I do my shoots in character. Youll get to have plenty of fun torturing me," Adora replies. Catra' s ear twitches, and then she turns and looks over her shoulder slowly. Adora swallows as Catra's blue eye fixes her with a burning gaze.

"Let' s recreate the ambush scene from episode one," she says, a barely restrained *gl e* in her voice.

Oh. Oh *fuck* .

--

When Catra agreed to cosplay Clawdeen, she wasnt really thinking about who the character was. She thought about her role, sure, but not her *personali ty* , as least not until Adora mentions being in character.

Clawdeen's entire *thing* was flirting with She-ra. It was coded like it made her a villain – because she was hitting on someone even the straight viewers could pick up was already committed to Teela, or because being gay makes you an evil slut, take your pick – but it was also hot and gave Teela a run for her money even in Adora's books. Doing a shoot in character gives Catra permission to basically flirt however she wants and none of it *matte rs* . It's all a tease for the camera, riling Adora up like Clawdeen always did.

When Adora seemed uncomfortable with Catra pressing close, she backed off with a sense of disappointment so familiar it was mostly numb, but the idea of finally being able to flirt with Adora without having to worry about if the next thing she says will be one step too far, a mistake that will ruin *everything,* lifts her mood right back up from the floor where it fell.

"You do cons in character too, don't you? So are we going to be running around the convention center pretending it's the Crimson Waste or something?" Catra asks, grinning as Adora takes about a thousand measurements of her arm so she can pattern out Clawdeen's weird fingerless gauntlets on a piece of paper. Adora normally uses cling wrap and duct tape to make her pattern pieces, but Catra wasn't letting *either* of those things near her, so Adora is testing out a different measuring technique by making one paper mockup right now before she tries to scale it up for her full outfit.

Adora can keep touching her for as long as she likes, Catra's having *fun* now. Her tail whips behind her as Adora shoots her a glare. She looks flustered, but she was flustered earlier and seemed uncomfortable with Catra's attempt to move forward then. Now she's just red in the face and doing her best to work around Catra's teasing. This is how it usually goes. It gets intense, it gets *bad*, and then they both go back to teasing as if to cover up whatever just almost happened between them.

"Only kind of. If someone comes up to talk because it's *me* rather than the character, or asks a question about cosplay, then we just have a conversation. Usually it's the same for talking to vendors because I don't want to annoy them, but I'll slip into character whenever it feels right. Otherwise, I generally stay in character walking around and taking photos," Adora explains as she cuts out the shape of the gauntlet she drew on the paper. Catra chirrups, thinking that over. That still gives her plenty of opportunities to toy with Adora, and hopefully it will be less than annoying than constantly pretending to be Clawdeen. She has no idea if she's going to hate that side of it or not.

"We should rewatch some episodes. I *know* you still have your boxset and a DVD player around somewhere, but I haven't watched anything in years and I'm hazy on some of it," Catra returns. She has seen enough of the show with Adora to have a good idea of it – her sharp memory helps – but it would take some effort for her to quote lines. Not that she has any plans to do so, she mostly wants to get a better idea of what kind of flirting she can get away with before it becomes clear she took the prompt and ran with it.

Adora brightens a little, looking up from taping her paper pattern together to send her a grin.

"Sure! I even have an old CRT TV I got last year," Adora replies. Catra, like a smitten *idiot*, purrs. Adora's eyes snap up to her and Catra feels her face turn red. It should be ridiculous and pretentious, but instead it's just dorky and cute.

"You're such a nerd. Why would you want it to look worse?" Catra responds, actively daring Adora to mention her moment of weakness. Adora smiles *slowly*, the kind of smile that makes it clear Catra didn't fool her, but she never really thought she did, she just wants her to keep her mouth shut about it.

"I bought it for a photoshoot, but I ended up liking it. It's how I used to watch the show. Besides, having it in my room means my DVD stuff doesn't take up space in the living room," Adora replies, shrugging. Catra feels her tail flick behind her, but she's *glad* this time and she doesn't purr despite how fucking endearing that is. Adora is so sentimental. No wonder she never let go of Catra.

"Arm," Adora instructs and Catra obliging lifts it so Adora can do her best to bend paper like fabric around her. Adora sticks out her tongue a little as she tries to wrangle it in a way that will preserve the fit enough to be *useful*. Catra tries not to think about how cute she is as Adora frowns down at it.

"Good enough, probably. I'm making a mockup anyway. We can fix any issues then," she decides. She sets the bracer back down and

tries to straighten and smooth the paper out on the table, looking up to throw Catra a smile. "I'll give you a tour and then we can watch the start of the season?" Adora of fers. Catra shrugs. They already had to walk through the main space of the house to get to the stairs, but she'd like to see all of the place Adora has been living in for the last three years.

Mostly she's excited to get to her bedroom, though. She hasn't been in a space that was Adora's – *just* Adora's, none of the replacements' touches within it – in a long time. The fact that they'll probably get to cuddle a bit or at least sit next to each other while watching the square TV is just a bonus. She flushes when Adora reaches for her hand, but Adora isn't even looking at her , already guiding her back towards the stairs. Catra pretends her tail isn't lashing as she does her best not to *cling* back.

Be cool , she tells herself. She's never been good at that.

--

Despite their history, Adora did not expect Catra to walk back into her life and start *flirting* with her. Two days after she powered through taking her measurements and then rewatched the *position* with her, their sides pressed together as they sat on her bed and Adora already mentally dying as she pictured the future shoot, she gets a message from Catra on Instagram that makes her mouth go dry.

Catra | Wildcat Workshop sent you a photo

Tap to view

Adora sucks in a sharp breath when she opens the notification and is greeted with a photo of Catra, in a muscle tee version of her shop shirt, with her back to the camera and both her arms flexing as they hook through a reel of dyed-black rope. She is carrying the long length over her shoulders. She must have dyed it –or at least got the supplies for it –right after she decided to recreate the scene featuring it. Adora was too overwhelmed and horny to say no once Catra asked. She didnt have a reason to reject it other than how hot it would make her and she couldnt exactly tell Catra that.

Adora finally manages to release her death grip on her phone and looks down from Catra's muscled arms to notice the caption is just

Did you just send me a thirst trap

Did you just screenshot it?

!!
I didnt know it would notify you!

Wow isnt social media your job

Ive never gotten a screenshot notification before

Then you arent sending enough thirst traps princess

Oh, it's on. Adora doesnt even hesitate to stand up and take of f her shirt. She can do Catra one better. It's hard to take a photo of her back herself and she doesnt have anything heavy to carry within reach, but she can flex her muscles and show them off just the same. After a few tries she manages to line it up in her mirror without being able to see. The final photo is a little blurry and has worse

lighting than Catra's, but Adora's sports bra does nothing to hide how toned her back is.

Her body is her job as much as social media is and she works on it appropriately. Catra is strong, but Adora carries her muscle more visibly than Catra and she managed to flex most of it in the photo. She doesn't hesitate to send it off, her blood thrumming with competition in a way that she, logically, knows can end in disaster, but she can never stop herself in the moment. It isn't like Catra hasn't seen worse on her Instagram.

Catra | Wildcat Workshop took a screenshot

Easy

You sent one first!

It's called cunning. Look it up princess

I just wanted to send it to Bow
So he can see what we're shooting with

Uh huh
That's why you thirst comment on all your friend's posts too I'm sure

It's not being thirsty it's complimenting!!
Being supportive and stuff

Sure. How many of them have you kissed again

Photoshoots don't count ok

How many

None

Catra |Wildcat Workshop shared a post

Tap to view

What is this then

How did you find that so fast
It's Ulta kissing Manx

Manx isn't real

And neither is the kiss
Mermista has a boyfriend. He was literally part of this shoot

Good to know you're just as delusional now as you always were

--

Catra didn't mean for the photo to be a thirst trap, except she totally did. She just didn't think Adora would *notice*. She wanted to tease her with the rope's existence, and carrying it in a way that showed off her muscle instead of just a taking a photo of it on the bench or something was a purposeful choice, but she didn't know if Adora would recognize it – and she certainly didn't think she would *acknowledge* it. It was far from the carefully posed thirst traps Adora posts. She expected Adora to call her out on screenshotting her response – she even had the excuse ready to go that she was just showing her what a screenshot notification looks like – but she managed to distract her with the talk about her past photoshoots.

Maybe Catra has been jealous about *single photoshoot* Adora has done with her friends where they held each other, or worst of all, *kissed*. The first time Adora did that for a ship photoshoot, Catra almost broke her phone, and then she spent any time she was alone for the next two days crying. She knew it was probably just for the

photo since Mermista –last that she could tell, anyway –was in a relationship, but that was *one* than Adora having gotten a girlfriend.

Catra had already lost Adora, after all, but Adora being willing to casually kiss her friends lost Catra her memories of her too. It always felt like they had something, but Catra was too scared to do anything about it and be rejected. Ever since Adora posted that first photo in another woman's arms, Catra has had to sit in her doubt and wonder if what they had was *nothing*—if Adora just turns her eye on her friends and pulls them close without thinking about it, without *feeling* in any meaningful way.

She still doesnt know the answer. It helps, some, to know now that Adora never kissed her friends outside of photos, but there's also the comments she leaves on their posts. Comments that are different but still *similar* to the flirtations they would send each other that Catra always hoped had real intent and werent just two friends messing around. Adora cant be pursuing this many people, so they *have* to be for fun, and where does that leave them? Just as meaningless as everything else?

Catra both dreads and looks forward to the photo shoot in equal measure, depending on the time of day. She wants to assert her claim and take this piece of Adora –a piece that *always* belonged to her –back for herself, but she cant forget that she's just another one on the list to Adora. She doesnt want Adora to be comparing her to her experiences with her other friends in her head. Catra cant be her only, it's far too late for that, but she still wants Adora to be *hers*.

She knows Adora's job involves a lot of things she could be jealous over, but she got desensitized to Adora flaunting her body a long time ago. She still saves every thirsty Thursday post Adora makes and touches herself to them regularly, but she's accepted them as a fact of life. They're hot, and she doesnt mind them from that perspective, just when Adora's friends comment on them and say things that cant. She didnt ever want anybody else to have Adora

like this, but if they are going to have it anyway, then Catra wants it too.

Maybe that's why she says yes when Adora texts her, despite how astonishingly bad the idea is.

--

So Glimmer knows why I really watch She-ra

What's that mean

Im gay

Ok yes continue

She asked if this is going to be like the Teela photoshoot

Did you even know that girl

Starla? Not really
We've messaged once or twice
But she was going to be Teela at a con I was bringing She-ra to so we took the chance to shoot

So how is this relevant

It was a ship photoshoot

I thought you shipped She-ra with Teela

I do but I like her and Clawdeen too!
I didnt really want it to happen in the show
But idk it would be fun to explore
And Instagram will love it

Is this part of your "experience cosplay" thing

I just know that it's probably the only Clawdeen shoot I'm ever going to do
You can say no
I know it's a lot

Fine

Yeah?

Sure. Why the hell not
Like you said. Probably going to be the only one I ever do
Since kissing Entrapta would be like kissing my sister
So sure

Entrapta but not me?

Entrapta's innocent
You post your ass on Instagram like once a week

I do not!!
And Entrapta isn't innocent

No but she isn't a hoe

:(

I'm joking

I know

Ok

So should I tell Bow?

Sure. Whatever
I'm still going to tie you up

I didnt think you werent
That can be part of the fanfic too

like I said
be

--

Adora was really glad she did the mockup, because math isnt her *strong* suit and there were several issues with how she calculated the fit from Catra's measurements. The final outfit looks great when Catra tries it on. It doesnt have any details yet, mostly missing the decorations she has to make out of foam like the line of fangs studding the single shoulder pauldron – not to mention *the thing* the pauldron – but the main body is done so she wanted to have Catra come over to try it on before she put more work into it. It has taken her a while to get here in between her other commissions, too, and she kind of just wanted to see Catra in person again. They've only hung out once since the first fitting, and Catra wont let her come to her shop because she's hiding the sword from her until it's done.

"It looks great," Adora tells her as Catra turns in front of the mirror to check the side view of the costume. Catra snorts, swishing her tail and then wrinkling her nose. She clearly isnt a fan of the wrap on the end of her tail that a small string of polymer beads Adora made is attached to, so maybe theyll have to leave that off for the con and only use it for the photoshoot, but the costume fits her *tail*. The leather wrap top and short skirt show off how her muscle flexes every time she moves, strength normally hidden by her clothes suddenly obvious in a way that makes it a little difficult to concentrate.

"You did a good job. The skirt is still dumb," Catra decides, picking at the fringe of fur with her claws. Adora grins at her. Catra glances up

to make eye contact and rolls her eyes. "If you hadn't built underwear into it, I'm pretty sure we would have an indecency incident no matter I wore," she adds, lifting the skirt as she says it. Adora is sure she *isn't* trying to flash her, but she still feels her face heat as she is confronted with Catra's ass in the dark brown spandex she used to make sure the skirt didn't ride up and reveal more than it should.

"I did the same with my She-ra costume and it works well," she says, valiantly doing her best to stay on track. Catra glances up, her lips quirking when she notices Adora carefully not looking down. Catra releases the edge of the skirt and straightens up, apparently done with her inspection. A light is dancing in her eyes that Adora *hates*. She can't keep her thoughts about her when Catra is dressed like this and looking at her like *that*.

"Shooting this with Bow is going to be so awkward," she admits, looking away and grabbing onto any conversational thread to distract Catra. In the corner of her eye, Catra's flicking tail stills. A moment later she turns away. Adora almost turns back to look at her again, but then she sees Catra's arms raising to remove her top and she turns her head fully away, just like she did when Catra first changed. She's used to changing with her friends in small rooms and even helping them into their costumes, but it's Catra. It's different.

"Didn't he do your other ship photoshoot? What, are they always miserable?" Catra asks, her voice uninterested. The sound of fabric moving follows.

"No, well, I mean he didn't do *all* of them, Starla's brother actually did the Teela photoshoot for us and that was its *own* kind of awkward, but- just because it's us, you know? Glimmer thinks it's stupid for us to do something like this when we've only just reconnected, that kind of thing," Adora rambles, doing her best not to think about how Catra had to strip down to her underwear to try on the costume and is now likely standing in the middle of her workshop undressed.

Catra doesn't reply, the sound of movement continuing to Adora's side. She bites her lip. She already knows that was a mistake, but hopefully not an obvious one. She thinks this shoot would actually be *more* awkward, at least on her end, if she didn't have feelings for Catra. Then again, she never would have brought up the possibility of a ship photoshoot if she didn't, even with Glimmer's teasing. She wouldn't risk jeopardizing their relationship while they were still rebuilding.

"It can't be more awkward than kissing a stranger in front of her brother," Catra points out after a few moments, her voice closer now. Adora huffs out a relieved laugh – that felt *close* – and risks turning her head. Catra is standing only a few feet away, fully dressed now and leaning back against the edge of the cutting table with her arms crossed. Despite the nonchalant position, her gaze is locked on the wall and her body is tight.

"No, you're right," Adora replies, taking a cautious step closer and mirroring Catra's position to lean against the table beside her. There are still a few inches between them, but she doesn't want to be distant right now. *Casual* is, but the last thing Adora wants her to think is that she is more opposed to kissing her than any of her other friends. Then she might wonder why. It's always a little awkward to do, but Adora isn't worried about feeling *embarrassed* when she kisses Catra. She drops her hands to hold the edge of the table just so she can squeeze something without obviously fidgeting.

"Speaking of, though. Um, have you- you know... last time we spoke you hadn't?" Adora manages to almost ask, *artfully* for professional reasons. She fumbled all over it, but she does have an excuse for why she's asking. Catra's ears twitch and her eyes finally dart to meet Adora's eyes. Adora feels as transparent as glass as Catra looks at her.

"Not everyone goes around kissing their friends," Catra finally replies, a reluctant mutter with her ears pinned back. She seems embarrassed – at least, Adora hopes so, because the alternative is *upset*. There could be multiple reasons for that. It's dangerous to

consider the hopeful ones, but Adora can't forget that *she* always thought Catra would be her first, nor can she forget the inexplicable spike of jealousy she felt the first time Catra posted a story of her casually hanging out with Scorpia. She takes a deep breath.

"My first kiss was during the photoshoot with Mermista. I was too embarrassed to tell her that beforehand and I was so awkward, it wasn't usable at all. I had to admit it then because it was just- Anyway, Mermista like, walked me through it after that. The shoot with Starla was kind of like a redemption round. And the one with Perfuma was just to prove to my friends that I wasn't completely useless after they all witnessed the first one," Adora explains, rambling a little. Catra's ears prick up as if listening carefully, but now *she* is the one avoiding looking at her because even remembering it makes her face red.

"You're an idiot," Catra says beside her. Adora's face is *shot*, and it isn't helped when she looks over and finds Catra watching her with a cautious expression, but there isn't any suspicion in it. If anything, it's hopeful – but it could just seem that way because of the contrast with how stiff she has been ever since Adora said the shoot would be awkward. Adora offers her a smile despite how flushed she knows her face still is.

"Mostly just socially awkward," she corrects. Catra chuffs, but she's relaxed again. Adora taps her fingers on the edge of the table. She could drop it. She thinks they got past Catra maybe being hurt by her careless comment. She just knows this topic is going to come up again and *soon*. They haven't set a date for their shoot yet, but Clawdeen is almost done, and she knows Catra is making progress on the sword.

She releases the table and scoots a few inches closer. Catra's tail thunks against the table leg as it lashes.

"What, want to kiss me too bad to wait for the photoshoot?" she asks. *Yes*, of course, but Adora can't say that. Catra has a lopsided smile on her face and a teasing tone to her voice, but Adora can *see*

there's more. The charge that is usually in the air when she thinks they might be close to doing this is missing, but she also thinks they're both too *tired* to summon it right now. They never said they were going to kiss for the photoshoot, but Adora was definitely on her way to asking.

"It's up to you if we do it for the shoot. I'm just trying to spare you the awkwardness of having your first kiss on camera if we do," Adora offers with a shrug, trying to downplay it. It's not exactly a staple of these type of shoots. They really don't have to, but Adora would rather know where they stand *now* than try to awkwardly ask in front of people on the day of. Catra's tail is still lashing, her ears pinned back and face turning red. She looks away and reaches up, tucking her hair back even though it wasn't falling past her ear anyway.

"Fine, I guess. Might as well get the full experience if I'm only doing it once," Catra mutters. Adora hasn't seen her this flustered often, gaze focused down and tail *still going*. She draws in a breath. Technically, that's only an acknowledgement for the shoot, but she's pretty sure Catra wouldn't agree to that and then *not* agree to kiss her first too. Glimmer and Bow are going to be there. Catra would definitely prefer to do something embarrassing with just her than in front of all three of them.

"You sure?" she asks, voice soft, as she pushes off the table and turns to face Catra, cautiously stepping in front of her. Catra keeps her face tilted down, but she glances up to make eye contact, her face still red. Adora can see her lashing tail now rather than just feel it. Catra lets go of her own arms with seeming effort, uncrossing them and grabbing the table to brace herself instead. Cautiously, she finally angles her face and body up to meet Adora's gaze head on.

"Unless you turn out to still be a terrible kisser, yeah," Catra replies, throwing Adora a lopsided smile. Adora huffs a laugh, feeling some of the tension slip from her – from them *both* – with the exchange. Cautiously, she steps closer, one foot between Catra's own and only a few centimeters between their chests now. She finally lets her gaze drop to Catra's lips. She watches them part, Catra's breath hitching.

When Adora makes eye contact again, Catra is watching her with a familiar burning intensity to her eyes.

"Ok," Adora agrees, a warning more than anything else. She lifts one hand, cradling Catra's jaw with it so she can direct her as she leans in. Catra draws in a sharp breath the moment before their lips connect.

Adora has never been anyone's first kiss before, at least she doesn't *think* She doesn't know Starla well enough to be sure, but it certainly didn't feel like her first kiss. She's a little too awkward to feel like she can lead Catra in this, but she can kiss her softly without any expectations placed on her, and she hopes that's enough. Catra isn't stiff beneath her, but she feels just as hesitant and unsure as Adora was her first time, her lips soft and pliant but *shy* beneath Adora.

It feels fucking *profound* . Whenever she pictured kissing Catra, it was usually fiery, Catra electric against her and Adora giving as good as she got. This is soft and oh-so-intimate as Adora cautiously slides her lips against Catra's and coaxes her into a slightly deeper kiss, lips parted but going no further because Adora *likes* it like this and she has no reason why they should do more anyway. This embrace is sweeter than any she would imagine between Clawdeen and She-ra, sure, but Adora is hardly considering the photoshoot right now anyway.

She wants to keep kissing Catra like this *for* , to kiss her again and again with each one growing deeper and more erotic, but instead she lets her lips soften and reluctantly pulls back after several long seconds. Her heart is pounding as she pulls back far enough to make eye contact again, opening her eyes to find Catra fluttering hers open as well. Both their chests are rising and falling faster than such a simple kiss warrants, but if Catra isn't going to call her out on it then Adora won't either . That was Catra's first kiss. Adora doesn't have an excuse.

"Good?" she asks, her voice low . Catra's eyes go from hooded to wide in a moment as the utter stillness of the moment shatters. She

releases her death grip on the table to shove at Adora's shoulder.

"Shut up! You're so full of yourself," she accuses. Her tail is lashing again after carefully holding it still while they kissed and her cheeks are reddening. Adora lets the shove push her into taking a step back despite how she doesn't want to go. She can't linger for an awkwardly long time. She can't fuck this up now. She rolls her eyes.

"I meant are *you* good, not if I am. I know I'm not experienced enough to be," Adora replies, relieved at how easily the teasing tone returns despite how she really wants Catra to grab her by the front of her shirt and reel her in again. Catra still looks flustered – her hand on the table is still gripping it tightly – but her breathing is returning to normal and her flush is receding. She snorts, throwing Adora a smile with a condescending curve to it. It doesn't match the look in her eye.

"Well, lucky for you I don't have anything to compare it to," she replies. There's a slight breathiness to her words. Adora's face feels hot and her body is barely obeying her command to not strain forward. This feels like *something*, but Adora has already stepped back and she doesn't know that she has the guts to step forward again. She already asked to kiss Catra – she already *did* it. She can't tell if Catra is looking at her now with hope or if it's just embarrassment from the lingering awkwardness.

The last thing she wants to do is pressure Catra when she was so hesitant, even if she knows that hesitance could have just been because she didn't know what she was doing. Adora wasn't really planning anything leading up to the kiss, just thinking *gogogo*, but she did still think it would tell her something. Now she feels just as clueless as before with the added complication of wanting to kiss Catra more than ever because she knows it's fucking amazing now.

"Bow will tell us if it looks bad, I guess," Adora replies with a shrug, forcing herself to step away so she isn't awkwardly staring Catra down. She moves to gather Clawdeen's outfit from where Catra placed it on the table. She folded it neatly, but Adora wants to lay it

out flat until it's all done. As she fixes the stack of clothes, she glances over at Catra. It's a shy glance and it's met with an equally shy one in response – for half a second, until they both realize they've been caught looking and quickly look away again.

Fuck. Is it something? She kind of expected that Catra would grab her by the front of the shirt if she wanted to keep going, but given how long they've been dancing around their attraction – or feelings, if Catra shares them – she could be just as scared as Adora. She could also just be *bad*. Fuck.

"There's plenty of other things we can do instead if we have to. I think She-ra with a bite mark on her shoulder and Clawdeen's claws digging into her bicep would look good," Catra says. Adora nearly fucking drops Clawdeen's pauldron.

She doesn't know how she's supposed to survive this shoot, and it's all her own doing.

--

Catra has commissions. She's supposed to be focusing on them, the sword a side project with no deadline that *has* to come second. And technically, it is. During the "normal business hours" when she tries to do most of her work, she does work on the commissions. It's just that after five o'clock rolls around she drops everything and turns to the sword instead, because she *needs* to finish it so she can give it to Adora. Once she does, they can finally schedule the photoshoot.

She wants to push Adora against a wall and leave her breathless. That was the best six seconds or *whatever* of her life. She feels warm to her toes and her fur ruffles up when she thinks about it. She wants to drive back to Adora's house and do it again, but she *can't*, not when it didn't ruin everything. They just did it, and it was

fine – fantastic, electrifying, fucking magical – and then they continued to hang out for another hour just swapping stories.

She doesn't know if she's more or less hopeful than before, but she feels like Adora has invaded every one of her senses. Either that felt as incredible for Adora as it was for her and this is the start of something, or the fact they kissed like that and then *nothing* happened is confirmation that this is all in Catra's head. They are in the exact same limbo they always have been, a cautious dance where the song never ends to let them finally stop spinning away from each other, except now Catra knows what kissing Adora softly feels like and it's driving her up the wall.

She got so hopeful when Adora explained those other photoshoots. Now she doesn't know what she is aside from *awkward* and *pathetic*. She can't stop fucking thinking of Adora and it makes her want to finish the sword so she can – hopefully – see her eyes light up when she hands it to her. She has work, and she has to sleep, and she has to spend a nominal amount of time at the shared Super Pal Trio apartment or Scorpia will start sending her sad eyes – she hates when Catra doesn't take care of herself – but she finishes the sword in a week. Almost immediately, she texts Adora.

--

The sword's done
Some of my best work tbh
It deserves the big screen so you'd better appreciate it

wow!! did you do that so fast
I think it took me longer to finish my current one!

It didn't take that long
I just had other work

Clawdeen isnt even done and you've made a whole MAGIC SWORD?

I think that's more of a problem with your work ethic

I thought it would take longer. I've been focusing on commissions
How good IS Scorpia?
The blade alone

I had to pivot on that. You'll see
Prototyping took the longest. I had a couple of iterations
But it wasn't too bad once I figured something out

I'm going to finish Clawdeen this weekend like it's con crunch
Catra I need to see it
Please
Dont make me bust out the pleading emoji

No photos no peeking
You have to come over and see for yourself

I just opened paints but I could be there in two hours

So eager

I want to see my magic sword!!

You can come over tonight I guess

YES

--

Adora's jaw drops when she steps into Catra's corner of the workshop. The sword is laying on what appears to be a hastily-constructed display stand consisting of two pieces of scrap wood. The stand doesnt matter – the sword is turned on and it is *gorgeous*. Adora runs her hand down the blade, marveling at how Catra managed to strike the balance between realism and *magic*. The blade appears and feels like metal, but where the edges should come to a perfectly-sharpened point, it pulses rainbow instead.

It must be two halves to accommodate for the lighting between, but is all looks seamless. The two halves are very close together, the light beaming out in a narrow but powerful sliver. When Adora runs her finger over it, it feels like a *very* dull edge, but it looks and feels better than the "metal" suddenly dropping of f into acrylic edges on her current prop. The handle itself is a perfect recreation of the one from the show, and the gem in its center beams rainbow just like the edges of the sword. Even the proportions look better. Catra had her take a photo of her arm with a measuring stick to base the size of f of and it paid off.

"*How*," Adora has to ask, too much disbelief in her voice to really make it a question. In her periphery she is aware of Catra walking up beside her, but she isnt looking away from the sword as she runs her fingers other the handle.

"Cant give away my secrets, princess, especially not after all the prototypes it took. I finally managed to keep the look and feel of metal while making all the lights work though. The solid metal blade prototypes didnt work out, and they wouldnt have been allowed at cons anyway," Catra says, and then her fingers are brushing Adora's. Her breath hitches as Catra grabs the handle and lifts the sword up, turning to face Adora with the sword in her hands and its tip pointed down. Catra grabs the guard and, to her shock, unscrews the handle. The lights flicker out as a battery pack is revealed in the base setting of the sword.

"It's a tough, lightweight core with lights and metal wrapping it. The battery can be replaced easily, and the lights should last thousands

of hours before burning out. I stuck with the remote set-up you already had because hiding a button in here was near impossible without compromising some other element of the design. It changes color modes, though,” Catra tells her , screwing the handle back on. The lights flicker back on as she does so. She holds the sword out to Adora. Adora takes a deep breath and reaches to take the sword from her.

The weight is different from what she’s used to, but it’s not much heavier. It’s longer, so the weight is centered differently and some extra would be expected. The blade certainly feels like metal when she runs her hands over it, but if it’s some kind of wrapping that makes sense. Experimentally, she presses down on the blade, trying to see how solid it feels. It does *f e* solid, but she thinks she can feel a slight flex.

“Dont try your hand at sword fighting, but it should stand up to *f a l* use with other props,” Catra immediately warns. Adora glances up, throwing her a grin, and then has her attention drawn back down when Catra raises her hand and clicks a button on a small remote – which is mostly just a single button – in her hand. The lights of the sword immediately die. It is less impressive with them off, of course, but Adora sets to inspecting it again now she can look closely at the seams.

It *s l l l ook s good* . The edge of her current sword looks a little shitty when the lights are off, a wedge of transparent rainbow acrylic where the sharp edges of the blade should be. Here, the lights Catra has used are so thin – and sealed in well with a touch of resin Adora can only feel and not really see – that the edge of the blade’ s appearance is largely maintained. Sure, it’s dull, but she doesnt want to get kicked out of cons for bringing a real weapon either. It looks *s unni ng* , especially when Catra clicks the remote in her hand again and turns it back onto a dim mode, the rainbow lights pulsing along the edge of the blade and the gem shining a moderate amount. It is subtler, likely easier on the lights, and will work better in low lighting or with some cameras.

Catra thought of *thi ng* . Adora knew she had three more years of prop experience, but this is the first time she has seen a stark contrast. Adora swallows and takes a step back, experimentally swinging the sword through that air. Watching the light trails immediately makes her heart pick up. She's used to "being" She-ra, but fuck, this is the first time in a long time that she's felt giddy excitement about it. Holding a piece of the show in her hands like this isn't just like having the prop they used, but like having the *actual* from straight off the screen.

"Catra, it's the most amazing thing I've ever seen in my fucking life," Adora manages to gush, breathless as she pulls it close to run her fingers over it again. In her periphery, Catra's tail is lashing.

"Psh, of course it is, I made it," Catra responds, her tone light. Adora finally looks away from the sword to find Catra standing with her arms crossed as if to look tough. It's cut by her tail swinging back and forth behind her. Her ears are trained forward on Adora, her cheeks are red, and her eyes are sparkling. She isn't as composed watching Adora's marveling as she wants to be. Adora looks back down at the sword.

"We have to shoot *tomorrow* . Catra, look at this!" Adora holds up the sword Catra made to her own eyes like she somehow missed what she had done, "It's the real sword! I need to play with it!" Adora all but whines. Her blood is thrumming with excitement, and it doesn't fade when Catra smiles like the sun at her, fond and *proud* .

"We can. whenever you get your ass in gear and finish Clawdeen, anyway," Catra returns, grin tilting into a smirk, but her eyes are still sparkling. Adora makes an affronted noise, pulling the sword back and all but cradling it in her arms.

"As soon as Bow has enough free time, it will be done," she promises. With a challenge like that, the only thing that could prevent her from finishing it tonight is how long things will take to dry. It's a good thing she isn't behind on any commissions, because they are all in the backseat now compared to Clawdeen. It's investing in her

future print sales, or something. Catra can torture her as much as she wants on this shoot, Adora cant *eat* .

Chapter End Notes

Adora's new sword goofing.
Bow's heart lamp is real btw.
Adora's sword I picture as a mix of She-ra's from the original and her season five sword. They basically just keyed rainbows around it for the special effects, plus the gemstone.

Clawdeen x She-ra

Chapter Summary

Clawdeen toys with She-ra, like she always does.

Chapter Notes

Shot lists are pretty much what they sound like: a list of shots you need to get. Ive mostly heard them in reference to video shoots but eh they work here too.
CW: References to the possibility of being pressured with physical contact/sexual intent (does not actually happen).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Do you have a shot list for the shoot btw
Aside from the ambush

Not really. ust some cool posed shots to show of f the costumes and some flirty stuff

Ok I know that's a lie
I know you have a whole fanfic for these two

Ok. Fine
Sure
Well I imagine for them it's like a hatesex thing
All the flirting and stress from traveling the Waste
Until they finally break
So I guess we do some of that teasing stuff. Photos with /tension/ you know?
And then they finally break and we do some shots close up

together and a kiss
If that's still okay

I can work with that

No input?

Not my fantasy, princess. This is all on you

It's not a fantasy! Just how I think it would go

Uh huh
And then what, they make sweet love in the sand?

I dont think it' s sweet

But you have thought about it

I have work to do :(

--

The point of the photoshoot – once Adora finishes Clawdeen and they manage to set it up – is to get photos of Clawdeen and She-ra together, but Adora also wants pictures with her new sword. Catra doesnt care about Clawdeen photos, so while they plan to take a couple to show off Adora's work, the first part of the shoot has Catra just watching and trying to pretend Glimmer isnt there – *maybe* *or* , Catra doesnt know , she certainly isnt doing much to help them set up and she keeps trying to tease Catra with a little too much bite – as she watches Adora set up character shots.

This part, Catra is used to. It's pretty much what she does when she does a shoot with Entrapta. There's no need for Adora to be in character between shots – if anything, it would hinder the process –

so it doesn't take that long to try out different angles and poses. They don't have a lot to work with around them considering they're set up at a pretty barren patch of land along the side of a road – it was the closest they could get to the Crimson Waste without driving for a few hours to reach a proper desert setting – so it's all down to Adora and her posing.

It doesn't take Adora long to finish her photos, but really Catra thinks Adora just spotted her returning from her car with the rope over her shoulder and lost her ability to appear hard and serious on camera. There's a hint of a blush on her cheeks when she tells Bow that they have enough for now and walks over to where Catra is prepping the rope. Catra tosses her a smirk, projecting confidence despite how she isn't entirely feeling it. Occasionally she remembers that she's basically standing in a field in her underwear, or that she and Adora are about to spend half an hour "pretending" to be viscerally infatuated with each other, and she suddenly feels awkward.

"Are we really opening with this one?" Adora asks, her tone sarcastic, as Bow moves the camera in the background. Catra is sure Glimmer and Bow are exchanging looks right now, but she ignores them as she sets the rope down.

"No, we wouldn't want you to get rope burns, princess. I just figured I'd do something with my downtime," Catra tells her, tail flicking with her smugness as she cocks a hip out and rests her hand on it. Adora narrows her eyes at her – it's a *good* look with a flush dusting her cheeks – as Catra grins lazily up at her.

"You're way too excited for this," Adora accuses. Catra purrs lowly, but there's no cars driving by right now, so she is sure Adora hears it. Her tail lashes in excitement, the polymer beads quietly clicking against each other with each sway. This is the part she was looking *forward* to, and she's only getting more excited with Adora reacting so readily before they've even touched.

"I didn't think you'd be so coy after everything else you've done for photos," Catra teases. Adora's face is definitely getting redder.

Catra's grin gets wider in response. Adora breaks first, reaching a hand up to push her tiara back despite the fact that it was *already* slipping and taking the excuse to look away.

"They weren't *tiny* mice," she mutters, apparently too flustered to speak at full volume. Catra knew this was something that *gets* to Adora based on her reaction when she first proposed it, but she didn't think Adora would so readily admit it, however quietly.

"Aw, princess, I'm your first? I'm flattered," Catra teases, stepping closer. *Click, click, click* the beads on her tail go behind her, and distantly she is aware of a *loud* click she should be more concerned with, but she can't look away from Adora's face as she attempts to shoot Catra a smirk around her blushing cheeks.

"I'm *your* first," she corrects, immediately cutting through all the confident layers Catra was wrapping herself in. Her ears pin back and she feels her face turn red. They are on their way to starting the actual shoot and thus *kissing*, but Catra did not expect Adora to bring it up before it was time, and especially not bring up their *other* kiss.

"Shut up," she mutters, trying to maintain some composure and control as Adora's smirk turns infuriatingly smug, her own fluster abandoned in the face of Catra's. They're close and Catra can feel that familiar *heat* to the exchange, teasing that could go further and *is going to* – in a few minutes anyway – for the cameras. She's almost fucking there and she should just wait, but nothing has every made her as competitive as Adora's cocky smile. Catra's ear twitches as she hears another click to their right and she thinks *fuck it*.

She growls and snatches her hand out, grabbing the front of Adora's precious costume and yanking her down. Adora gets half a startled exclamation out before their lips are colliding, Catra stretching up on her toes to force their mouths together in a demanding kiss, one she doesn't entirely know how to do, but she goes for it *anyway* because she knows no one else has ever kissed Adora like this, and

moreover, she knows Bow has been taking pictures of this entire exchange that she can use to justify her actions with later .

Adora fumbles to catch up as Catra presses against her, hot and insistent and *the only one not to* , *taking part* . All she wants is for Adora to kiss her back with as much passion – determination, whatever – but the moment Adora gets with the program and moves past fumbling at kissing her back to actually reaching for her, Catra shoves her back. Adora goes from trying to steady herself on Catra's shoulders to stumbling back, eyes wide and bitten lips gaping.

Catra throws her a triumphant smirk, her tail swishing, before she turns her head to where Bow is holding up his camera, remaining *fairly* professional. Glimmer is standing behind him and gaping.

"Did you get the shot?" she asks, if only to establish for *Adora* that Catra knew the entire time that Bow was taking pictures and that's why she kissed her.

Adora was kissing her back too. Did she know? Did she assume Bow would jump in and take photos? *Did she get that alone?*

"Probably going to be the best one all day , though I'm sure Instagram will appreciate the ambush photoset," Bow says, like he was in on the plan with Catra, but when he lowers his camera he is giving her a *significant* look. Adora is still gaping at her. Catra's smirk doesnt dim.

"Oh, I'm sure I can come up with something else," she promises. She's running on the adrenaline rush of kissing Adora. She's coming up with *ideas* .

--

"Come on, She-ra, you're supposed to be passionate and *annoyed*," Catra teases, an artful curl to her voice that makes Adora want to kiss her breathless and tug on her hair. Adora's face feels hot. They were supposed to *start* with the composed shots and work up to the flirty ones. Adora was kind of a mess after the kiss broke her brain, though, and she's just been rolling with the punches ever since. They tease each other, growing closer and further apart, as Bow circles around them.

At this exact moment, however, the teasing has *stopped* and they're pressed tight together, Catra draped with her back against her chest and smirking up at her. It's not that far from some scenes that were actually in the show, but Adora is definitely more flustered than She-ra ever was. She commands her hands to lift, grabbing Catra's biceps and holding her firmly, not quite sure if she wants to push her away or pull her closer.

It looked like that sometimes in the show, too. Adora is far from *annoyed*. She feels like there's so much blood is rushing to her head that she can't think clearly and she's going to do something *stupid*. She absolutely doesn't want Catra to be further away, but she would be safer with her on the other side of the clearing. One of Catra's hands is crossed over her own torso to rest on what little of the symbol on Adora's chest is exposed, her touch light and flirtatious. The other is repeatedly tracing her fingers across the back of Adora's hand. When Adora glances down, she finds the hold has done nothing but make Catra's grin grow wider.

"There you go. Flex your arms for the camera, big girl, people eat that up. And look forward again. Like the moment we make eye contact again, you won't be able to stop yourself," Catra teases, because Adora has joked about her being a sadist a few times but she was clearly *right*. Adora's eyes immediately snap up, focusing on the road up the hill. This will be a *good* shot, and she has been trying to focus on that thought whenever it comes, but right now she feels

like she's dying. She doesn't have to *pretend* to feel that way, it's exactly where she's at.

She honestly can't tell if Catra knows that or not. If she does, she's *definitely* enjoying it, so Adora has to believe she doesn't, because then she isn't going to be able to stop herself from kissing her before the shot comes up – if they're even going to *do* another after Catra sprung one on her when Adora didn't even realize Bow was ready. She already knows they're not going to get a better take of something like that, but a proper kiss, with them holding each other and not straddling the line between fucking or something close to fighting, might still be on the slate.

They're still standing on that line, mostly because Catra is driving her *hips* in the exact way that makes her clench down on nothing. She needs to keep it together or either they're going to run off from this shoot to have sex in the back of Catra's car – *fuck*, Adora would love to do it, and right now she can't think of a reason why she shouldn't try – or Adora is going to be *too much* and fuck everything up, the shoot snapping from sexy and infuriating to awkward and potentially friendship-ruining in a split-second.

When Glimmer said she wanted to "help," she said she was coming to watch the shitshow. So far, she's gotten exactly what she was hoping for, whatever Adora's protests were at the time. Adora has to get it together. The kiss caught her too off guard and she hasn't recovered, but She-ra is supposed to be calm and collected, as strong as she is caring. She takes a deep breath, setting her mouth in a firm line, and looks down at Catra with a hard expression. A moment of hesitance flashes across Catra's face, an infinitesimal gap appearing between them as Catra's eyes widen and she shifts forward, away from Adora.

Adora can see her thinking *attitude*. Slowly, Adora quirks her lips up and smirks at Catra's startled expression. Bow's shutter is going as Catra seems to realize what Adora is doing and pouts, the hesitance leaving her as she puts on a disappointed air. She struck

out with She-ra – this time. Who knows what will happen the next. Adora is taking the day shot-by-shot.

--

Adora ⚔ Commissions closed! has updated their story
@SUMMERBOMB TRANSFORMATION!!
It's a good thing they're supposed to be eyefucking each other because they can't stop for 5 minutes 😐
Tap to view

The photo is taken from a distance away, the shadow of Bow's shoulder and his camera visible just off to the side of the frame. The focus is on a pair in the middle of a clearing, several feet between them as they face each other down. They're both in ready stances, as if about to fight.

--

Adora ⚔ Commissions closed! has updated their story
@SUMMERBOMB TRANSFORMATION PT 3
We've been doing this for like 15 minutes and they haven't

stopped flirting once

Tap to view

The camera is still a distance from its subject, Bow visible in the background as he moves to get a shot. A couple is at center frame, standing back-to-back. They're too far to make out their faces, but while She-ra has her sword planted in front of her, the tip resting in the dirt, Clawdeen has her head lolled back so she can look over her shoulder – and She-ra's – to look at her . Even with their expressions obscured by distance, the flash of white fangs is visible.

--

Adora ✨ Commissions closed! has updated their story

@SUMMERBOMB T AKEOVER PT 5

The breeze blew and it's too much for the queen of the Crimson Waste

Tap to view

The video is a loop of just a few seconds, shot from a similar distance as before, but the wind can be seen pulling at the hair of the couple in the center. Clawdeen is huddled against She-ra's chest, her arms and face tucked in as She-ra cuddles her standing up.

Another story immediately follows it, this one a pink screen with text written over it.

"Clawdeen" wants it known that this is why you fight in real armor instead of a bikini. Didn't have a response when I pointed out Clawdeen spends all her time in a desert.

--

Catra barely contains herself from kissing Adora again *a few* times, but she manages to hold back. It's the only thing she limits herself on, teasing Adora with her words, touch, and smile as much as she can, even when they're supposed to be taking their serious shots together, at least until Glimmer yells at them to *stop hugging and start fighting*. Not that Catra doesn't immediately want to continue just to annoy her, but she feels like she can't push too far after Glimmer has called attention to it.

Adora started out a *mess*, and though she's gotten herself under control since, Catra is high on a deep sense of satisfaction. She is happy with what she already got out of Adora and she is equally turned on by Adora turning the same treatment on her, but she's better at *hiding* it, trading taunts back and forth even while her internal monologue is chanting *top me top me top me*. Adora comes kind of close when they get a shot of her holding Catra down and glaring at her as Catra, ever in character and with no ulterior motives, keeps taunting her.

She thought it might *work*, but Adora pulls away when Bow declares he got the shot. Oh well. The photoshoot is everything she could have wanted, endorphins and adrenaline mixing pleasantly in her body before they even get to the shots that are *supposed* to be steamy. They've gotten their teasing ones, and their serious ones, as out of order as they were, but their last two planned sets remain in place: the ones that might just end up too hot for Adora to release, and the ambush scene.

Bow tells them to "get as close as they're comfortable." Catra raises a brow at him and immediately snatches out for Adora's waist, yanking her close and grinning when Adora makes an affronted noise. It's just her competitive spirit; she *definitely* didn't mind Catra molding their bodies together earlier. Adora responds by wrapping a strong arm around her, forcing her even closer as she buries her other hand in her hair. Pretending to make out shouldn't be a competition, but it is, because Catra immediately throws her a grin and shifts to run her hands over Adora's arms, feeling up her biceps and trailing her claws along them as she stretches up to kiss her.

Except she doesn't. Adora draws in a sharp breath, waiting, but Catra leaves her lips parted centimeters from Adora's, nose nudging against her cheek. Her eyes are hooded, likely just a sliver of them visible, and she can't make eye contact with Adora without opening them and painfully crossing them to focus this close, but after a moment Adora seems to get with the program. She blows out a breath and then Catra feels the shift in the air from her lips parting.

Bow's shutter starts snapping as Adora shifts so her other arm is wrapped around Catra, leaving her hand closest to the lens free to run possessively down Catra's side, bared by the costume. Catra's tail lashes, her fur fluffing up a little without her command. She pulls her head back just enough to tilt her head the other way and line up to nip at Adora's jaw instead, not holding an *arm's length* for the camera this time. Adora's breath hitches as Catra's teeth scrape against her and her hand buries in Catra's fur, pulling her closer for a moment – *enough to make sure* – before she returns to feeling Catra up in her skimpy outfit.

Catra is aware of Bow moving around them, and even more distantly she is aware of Glimmer standing several feet back, probably filming something for Adora's "behind-the-scenes" Instagram story, but none of that fucking matters because Adora is touching her. The plan for this part of the shoot was *get handsy and look good*, and it was unspoken that it would be short because they weren't likely to use more than one or two photos out of it – if any were even good –

but every second feels like it is both stretching on forever and too short at once.

Adora's hands are running over her body, her arms moving too much for Catra to keep feeling up, so she slips her hands down, wrapping them around Adora's back on either side. She gives herself a moment of enjoying the muscle there as she shifts the bury her face in Adora's shoulder as if she's biting her – Adora gets with the program immediately this time, probably because Catra is breathing a bit heavily and *does* have her fangs bared – and she tosses her head back to give Catra more room. And maybe to sell the illusion of being overtaken with pleasure, who knows, Catra *hopes* so.

She splays her fingers out, letting her claws carefully prick into Adora's shoulders as Bow circles around Adora so the camera can hopefully pick up the pressure of Catra digging her claws in just above where the back of Adora's precious costume begins. She doesnt want to damage it – Adora already had to take a moment to check it over after their kiss earlier once she gathered herself enough to remember to care – and she wants to dig her claws *in* to Adora. Without fabric between them, however, she has to be more careful. She regretfully slides her claws back once Bow passes Adora's back, instead *clutching* onto her with all the force she wanted to dig her claws in with.

Adora's hands are *still on her* and there's obvious desire in her scent. It has been there off and on for the entire shoot. Catra fucking hopes none of Adora's other shoots were like this, but her descriptions certainly didnt make them seem like they were, and the way Glimmer and Bow have been *acting* makes it seem unusual too. Catra is one step away from tugging Adora away from the shoot entirely and pulling her into her car. They both *want* . Why the fuck isnt that enough?

Catra isnt thinking about their friendship in this moment, way too turned on for concerns like that. She lifts her head from Adora's shoulder – and her hand from Adora's back – fisting her ponytail in her hand and pulling her into position so she can press up and nip

on her bottom lip, giving Bow a second to line up and Adora a second to stop *gasping* before she gives it a slow, arduous tug. The tiniest moan slips between Adora's lips, taken by the wind from all but Catra, if she's lucky. The feeling of Adora's soft lip slipping away from her is both satisfying and makes her wildly crave more. She wants to bite her again, wants to kiss her, wants to drag her claws over this tiny dress and rip it off of her.

Instead, Bow clears his throat so subtly Catra isn't sure Adora heard him – or that it was even *supposed* to be heard yet, the sound hesitant in a way Bow usually isn't, so maybe he hasn't decided if he's going to interrupt yet – and Catra reluctantly drops down to stand flat on her feet again. She's breathing deeply and so is Adora, who takes a moment to catch up before she stills her hands and just holds Catra there, close against her.

To her shock, Adora doesn't drop her hands, or step away , or even try to restart it. Instead, she leans forward and presses their foreheads together.

"One more shot. Of us close together . Deciding whether that was worth it," Adora whispers. Catra only barely suppresses a shiver from running down her spine, tail lashing back and forth as she tries to look at Adora through hooded and unfocused eyes. The best she can get is that Adora has her eyes open as well, and her eyelids are similarly heavy. They haven't truly kissed again and Catra desperately wants to, but the lip bite might have been better. She thinks that entire embrace was already more than Adora bargained for, anyway.

If her scent signals are anything to go by, this entire shoot has been. Catra needs to back off before she creeps her out, even if it's only in retrospect. Adora's words seem to be a signal to slow down. Catra draws in a deep breath, her lungs quivering as she blows it out steadily and lets her eyes finally slip close. She honestly isn't sure if Bow even heard Adora, but after a few seconds that feel like forever and not enough, he steps back from them.

"Alright, guys, I definitely got enough," *she* *shouted*, "we could wrap up now or do that recreation shot if you still want to."

Oh. *Right*. Catra was so caught up all but fucking Adora in front of her friends, she nearly forgot.

Well. It was a power move, if nothing else.

--

As much as Adora has dreaded and looked forward to recreating She-ra and Clawdeen's meeting, it turns out to be a breath of relief. Sure, she's turned on, but she's also *tied up* and can't really do anything to fuck this up. Despite them having a knife on hand to cut the rope if necessary, this isn't nearly as dangerous as the greedy spark that lit in her chest at having Catra beneath her hands. She barely held herself back from kissing Catra full-force like they did earlier. She's *still* fighting disappointment that they didn't kiss again as Glimmer and Catra both help her lay down without cracking her chin open after they wrap the rope around her.

Catra did bite her earlier, though, and that is going to be featuring in her fantasies heavily from now on. Not that it wasn't already there, but she didn't know what it *felt like*. She is going to be running her mind over those fleeting moments of Catra in her arms – it couldn't have been more than a minute and Adora wishes it were an *hour* – for the rest of the day, if not her fucking life. It feels good to have time to process, even if that "time" involves laying down and looking pained as Catra gets in position above her, the end of the rope in her hand.

It was actually a stupid big bola in the show, fired out of a canon. Catra fashioned weights for the ends of the rope – not *big* weights, though they are kind of heavy – to make it look more realistic. She

swings one around as she circles Adora for a minute, trying to get a shot that shows her casually spinning it and strolling like Clawdeen did in the show without it turning up blurry on Bow's camera.

Adora tries to work on processing in her head as Catra circles around her back. She doesn't make much progress in the few seconds she has. She has a feeling it isn't going to sink in for hours – for her *or* Catra – and she can't begin to guess how they'll feel about it or *each other* once it does. Well, she knows how she'll always feel about Catra, but that was intense, and she's still too caught up to decide if it meant what she wants it to.

"Going to do the triumph shot, look defiant and keep breathing," Catra warns with no trace of teasing in her voice – probably because this is kind of important. Adora grunts, turning her head a little and carefully resting her cheek in the dirt. It isn't comfortable, and it's a good thing they're doing this last so Catra doesn't have to nuzzle or kiss her face like this, but it will be a good shot and Adora can wash her face – and costume – *later*. She does her best to look up and back towards Catra, but she can't see anything more than her shadow as she feels Catra's foot on her back.

Slowly, Catra puts her weight on it, and then Adora is aware of Catra leaning in close behind her as Bow's shutter goes. It's kind of hard to breathe with Catra essentially standing on her – she only has one foot on her, but she's bearing all her weight on it as she leans down to whisper in her ear – and her arms bound tightly by her sides don't help. She focuses on her breathing and looking defiant as Catra reaches her ear.

"You're doing well, princess. We're almost there," Catra purrs. It's supposed to be quiet encouragement, but instead there is a moment's delay as Adora's brain processes the words and then her eyes go wide.

Fuck, not the *jaws*. She's suddenly as turned on as she was when she had Catra's body beneath her hands. She feels a slight shift in Catra's weight on her, almost like she is pulling back a little – *almost*

I i kbeoti d —as Bow' s shutter goes again. At this point, she hopes Catra decides that she has a thing for being stepped on, because that feels less dangerous for her to know ."Catra could try to use that against her at a later date and it wont really do anything.

It doesnt get easier to breathe when Bow signals they're good and Catra shifts her weight off of her.

--

Larry the Lobster afer HRT has shared a story with you
@LIMMERBOMB T AKEOVER PT 4
Vote: Are they fighting or?..
Tap to view

You okay there Wildcat?

Of course I am

Looks like a pretty intense shoot

The most intense thing is how intensely annoying Glimmer is

You sure you're okay with all of this?

Im fine Scorpia

I just know you havent been talking again for long
And Im trying to be positive! Talking is good
She's just hurt you a lot
And I know what the pressure to make someone happy is like

Scorpia my favorite word on the planet is no
Right before fuck”

I know! I know you can handle yourself
It’s just
Adora

Yeah. It’s Adora. She’s made out of sunshine and rainbows
Fucking around with her for half an hour is far from a burden
We already finished anyway. Im just checking the map before I start driving back

Okay! Good
That’s great
Want to watch a movie when you get back?

Fine. Pick something with spies
I need to get changed and probably shower when I get home though
There’s dust in my fur

Okay!!

--

Catra drove separately, but Adora drove herself, Glimmer, and Bow out to the location they found to shoot. It made sense for her to drive, even if they took Bow’s SUV, because the whole thing was for her benefit. They all help each other with their cosplays and shoots, but at the end of the day this was only for Adora’s Instagram page and her friends would never let her pay them back with anything other than dinner and maybe helping them with laundry here and there.

Driving is the least she can do, but when they go to get back in the car, Bow gets in the driver's seat without asking. Adora was a bit distracted saying goodbye to Catra, so she finds herself relegated to the passenger seat when she turns back to the car. Not that it's a bad place to be, she's just *confused* – at least until the inquisition starts.

"That was pornography ," Glimmer says, without lead-up or any kind of qualifying statement, as she leans forward over the center console. Adora almost chokes, twisting around to look at Glimmer in the backseat. Bow doesn't seem as nearly shocked as Adora is, eyes focused on the road, though he has a *look* on his face that Adora has come to associate with the phrase *not to talk about emotions* . Glimmer raises a brow at Adora.

"You were probably too busy feeling her up to notice, but half the time it looked like you were five seconds away from fucking each other in the dirt," Glimmer says. Adora gapes at her , speechless for several seconds. Okay, so maybe she had *some thoughts* a little too close to that, but there were a good ten minutes there when they didn't even touch as they took more serious shots, Adora's hands on her sword rather than Catra. Her concentration was desperately thin but it *was* .

"It's just a ship photoshoot!" she defends, her voice a little high. Bow coughs politely from the driver's seat and Adora whips her head around to glare at him. She does *not* need his input making this worse.

"I've seen less passionate photoshoots from *couples* . Those shots where you were somehow making out without kissing are going to get banned from Instagram," Glimmer returns, her gaze burning as she fixes it on Adora. Adora's face feels hot. Now she *really* wants to see those pictures. It felt amazing to have Catra beneath her hands and she wants to see what it looked like, but she's sure Glimmer is exaggerating. Adora has posted some risqué stuff before without ever getting flagged.

f was tasteful,"Bow says from the front seat, his voice neutral, but he's clearly working for it. Adora holds a finger up to Glimmer, which *is by* makes words simmer beneath her surface as she barely holds herself back from continuing. Adora focuses on Bow instead, narrowing her eyes at him.

"W e were doing exactly what we said we were going to. Bow?" she asks, because he was the one actually holding the camera and he would know best. He s also the *one* one out of the three of them. She blanches when Bow's face turns red. Glimmer's indignation at being told to quiet is gone, a victorious grin spreading on her face as she shoots Adora an obvious *told you so* look.

"It was, hm, *more than* . Listen, Adora, we're not trying to shame you. You two were so wrapped up in each other it wasnt even that awkward to watch, but *you could* *see* *both* ," Bow points out. Adora's face is definitely red. Okay, now she's embarrassed. Bow is kind of like a brother to her. She was definitely too caught up to worry about their audience, but she thought not going far enough to fuck things up with Catra would be an appropriate line for PDA or whatever you want to call it in front of people.

Apparently not. Apparently she and Catra have different lines than other friends have. Not that she didnt already know that, especially on her end, but it makes her heart beat a little faster to be confronted with it – and the *possibilities* related to it – so openly .

"Sorry . I didnt mean to make you guys uncomfortable," she manages, dropping her hand back to her lap. Unfortunately, Glimmer barks out a laugh in the backseat and Bow actually sighs.

"Please, it was kind of hot even if it was ridiculous. No, we're fucking *worried* for you, Adora," Glimmer clarifies for her . Adora feels her lips part, her brow furrowing as she looks back to Glimmer. "I know you want to be friends again, but that was *not* friend behavior, and we would be shitty ones if we didnt say something. She might want to rail you, or she might break your heart again," Glimmer says. Adora's

teeth click as she closes her mouth again quickly, blushing. Yeah, she *hopes* it's the first thing, but she's confident it at least isn't the second. Glimmer raises a brow back at her as Bow nods in her periphery.

"We've always flirted, we just played it up for the camera. We both fucked up with our fight, but we've worked that out. She's not going to break my heart. At least not on purpose," Adora says, the final sentence quieter. Catra could absolutely break her heart if she doesn't return her feelings, but as long as they stay friends it will be fine. Glimmer and Bow – unfortunately – have guessed how Adora feels about Catra despite her tight lips on the subject, but when they talk about her heart breaking, they don't actually mean romantically. They mean the way their entire friendship fell apart and they lost each other. Adora can take Catra only being her friend – that's *normal* – but she can't take losing her again.

"She didn't hurt you on purpose last time either – *hope*," Glimmer points out. Adora frowns.

"No, I-" she draws to a halt. Glimmer raises a brow at her, but Adora isn't realizing she is right. No, she's realizing something very different. This isn't three years ago. They had fought before then without everything falling apart, but they were young, and stupid, and insecure, and under *immense* stress. Everything came together at once to break them apart. It had to, because no matter the intent behind it, Adora knows they both loved each other so fucking much, it had to take a shitstorm to overshadow it.

They haven't had emotionally deep conversations again yet, but Adora knows Catra missed her as much as she did her. Stuff like Catra offering to forge her a new, improved sword – something she knows Adora relies on as a safety net and is Adora's prized possession – says all that it has to. She knows Catra has already dug her claws in again and that it would take something ripping Adora away – injuring them *both* in the process – for Catra to let go again. She didn't know that before today, and she can't even say what part of today convinced her of that, but she *knows* it now.

"We're not going to break up again. No matter what. We're going to work for this," Adora finally says, her voice leaving no room for discussion, because there isn't. She *knows* this. Unless she tells Catra how she feels and it's too much for her, Catra isn't letting go, and Adora isn't either. Adora is going to fight for her. In a way, she has been for a long time, but Catra has stopped fighting her back. They're making this work and they're going to *keep* making it work, no matter how incredulous Glimmer looks.

Glimmer glances over to Bow as if to exchange a look with him, but he's driving and doesn't look away from the road, though his gaze is thoughtful.

"You're sure that feeling's mutual?" he asks. Adora blows out a breath, dropping back in her seat to face forward and sit comfortably instead of staring Glimmer down.

"With Catra you can never be sure of anything. But yeah, I think so," Adora returns. She may not know the nature of Catra's feelings for sure, but she *suspects*, and she knows the depth of them. She felt Catra's intensity during that shoot. She damn neared drowned in her. She felt when Catra shivered beneath her touch.

This is *something*. They are. They always were.

--

Catra is definitely dirty from shooting in a dust field for an hour, and she does need to change out of the costume Adora made her and check if it needs spot cleaning, but really she tells Scorpia she needs a shower when she gets home so she can *fuck in private*.

Adora's hands were all over her, running through her fur and pulling her close. On paper, Adora has touched her similarly when petting

her once or twice, but it was still *nothing like that*. Catra leans back against the tile wall and muffles her cries with her hand as she touches herself, something she doesn't normally need to do, but she's too worked up to contain herself as she remembers Adora's possessive touch and the competitive, aggressive, fucking *fire* look in her eye when she pinned Catra to the ground for a shot.

Catra doesn't know why she got back in her own car when they were done – or at least, why she didn't pull Adora into it with her. Glimmer and Bow were in the background, chatting about everything they just watched quietly as if Catra couldn't hear them, but they were technically in the background as she and Adora kissed too and that certainly didn't stop her then. She wants Adora's hands on her again – she *needs* it. All the times she has held herself back, not knowing Adora's touch feels like that, good enough to make her toes curl just remembering it. She doesn't know how she's ever going to hold back again – and she doesn't know if she *has* to.

If she texted Adora right now – if she sent her a photo of her undressed and worked up all over again remembering how riled up she was for the shoot – what would Adora do? Adora was turned on, her desire lacing the air whether they were touching or not. Catra never doubted Adora was attracted to her, but fuck, Adora *wants* her, maybe as badly as Catra wants her. Maybe she's back in her bedroom right now, touching herself the same Catra is at the memory of fangs on her lip. Even the thought makes Catra whine, her hips twitching forward.

Existential thoughts and worries about *love* or whatever else is getting in the way of Adora railing her through the mattress don't matter right now. She lets the ghosts of Adora's hands bury in her fur, the memory of how possessively Adora held her enough to get her through as she squeezes her eyes shut and ruts into her hand. Her fur stands on end as a burning pleasure builds and then floods out from the fever point between her legs to sweep through her entire body.

She heaves a sigh of relief, going limp against the wall and panting, utterly spent after all the buildup. That was the release she needed or she would have been a bitch the entire night. She breathes heavily as she lets herself just lean limply against the wall for several long seconds, the aftershocks and endorphins working through her. She doesn't know what Adora was playing at for that shoot, but after years of dancing around each other, one afternoon made her sure that eventually they *were* going to break and fuck.

She doesn't know if it will ruin everything, but at this point, it just might be a risk she's willing to take. She'll try to wait until they're in a better place – a place where it *won't* – but considering the endorphins aren't even done working through her and she already feels like she wants to go again, she isn't sure how long that will last.

--

Glimmer teased her about it in the car, and Adora certainly *felt* the sexual tension, but she wasn't expecting her entire Instagram following to know about it when she gets home. The photos Glimmer posted weren't really damning, but the captions *were*. Adora debates deleting the one about eyefucking, but Glimmer numbered the stories and it would be obvious something got taken down to anyone who hadn't seen it yet. Then she checks her DM replies and immediately decides it has to go.

There's a *lot* of the eyes emoj in her inbox – and pretty much any emoj with the tongue out. Adora is used to getting comments like that, she even encourages it, but she feels extremely flustered as she clicks through all the messages expressing excitement – or just unfiltered horniness – for the results of the shoot. People talk about her like this, but she never sees stuff like this on *Catra's* posts, and she feels conflicted about it. The attention is directed at them both,

and maybe it turns her on a bit, and it *thinks* they makes her feel unfairly possessive, but it also makes her anxious.

The shoot was a lot. She knew that even before Glimmer and Bow ambushed her in the car. Catra was the driving factor behind that, far from shy and insecure like Adora felt in her shoot with Mermista, but they were both caught up and Adora is still *thinking* about it as a result. She is starting to process everything that happened. She feels a bit like a moron for being so focused on controlling herself that she didn't realize she might not *have* to in the moment – and she's worried now that the moment has passed, there won't be another like that and she missed her chance, because if she thought there had been tension between them before, she had no idea what it could really be like – but she is worried about how Catra will feel once she processes.

Adora was running on an endorphin high the entire time. She doesn't know *what* Catra was running on aside from pure, distilled brat energy. She hopes it was the same endorphins, because there's no way she was that turned on and Catra didn't pick up on it, but she still kept going. The problem is she doesn't know. What if Catra was being impulsive, and now they're apart – now she's watching it back through Adora's story, because she is on the list of viewers – she's starting to regret it? Catra has always been a flirt and it was never limited to just Adora. She had fun at the time, but it could be sinking in now that her friend is hot for her, and it could be making her uncomfortable.

Adora meant her declaration to Glimmer, but even then she had the caveat that her feelings could make Catra uncomfortable enough to force them into a distant friendship. After everything they just did, she doesn't *think* she has to worry about that... but worrying might as well be her full-time job, so she does it anyway. If nothing else, if Catra *saw* having fun like she was, she might be dealing with an endorphin crash right now. Adora needs to check in on her.

Hey
You get home safe?

Yeah
Watching a movie with Scorpia

Okay. Cool
Soooo
It occurred to me I might be desensitized to taking photos like that
But I know my first shoot like that was a lot
So I wanted to check in

Princess you've never had a shoot like that

Well. Okay
My cosplay partners aren't usually that eager to torture me

Aw they're missing how funny it is when you blush to your tits

I do not!

Bow has photographic evidence

:(
Clearly you're fine you're still being a meanie

Are you FINE?

Out of 5 <3
My DMs say you're lucky btw

They don't know you
If they knew you had so much ass it transferred to your personality they might change their minds

You've been looking at my ass huh

Kind of hard to miss
It's as big as your ego

Awww come on. My DMs are also talking about how hot you are
They want your handle

Tell them I'm taken
I don't want creeps in my DMs

Are you sure you'll be okay with me posting the photos?

Sure I don't mind people knowing I'm hot as fuck
Just don't want straight guys DMing me

Okay. I'll run the photos by you before I post them
It's gonna be a couple days before they're edited
And then I'll be posting them slowly

You need time alone with them first huh

Catra!
Come on
It takes time to make them look like they're from the Crimson Waste

Don't think anyone's going to be looking at the background when my abs and your arms are in frame

Then to make them look cinematic

Speaking of cinema, Scorpia's pouting that I'm ignoring it

Okay enjoy your movie!

When Catra doesnt reply , Adora scrolls back up through the conversation, her face red. As far as flirting goes, this is tame compared to what they did during the shoot, but it's also more explicit. Catra didnt really comment on her body then, at least. It would fluster Adora any time, but it hits even harder with the added relief that Catra seems fine. She's being bitchy –like always –but she wouldnt still be flirting if she was uncomfortable. She doesnt regret it, at least not yet, and that only makes Adora want *more* .

She really needs to find them a convention to go to.

--

Adora ⚔ Commissions closed! has updated their story
Ill introduce Clawdeen properly when the time' s right
All you need to know right now is that she's taken
Tap to view

--

Scorpia tries to steal a peek at the screen the entire time Catra is texting Adora. She didnt bring up the photoshoot when Catra got home, or when she got out of the shower, but Catra can see her *wati ng* to even as an assassination is thwarted on screen. Scorpia knew she was doing a photoshoot with Adora today, but Catra might have conveniently forgot to mention it was a ship photoshoot. She

wasn't trying to hide it from her – Scorpia follows Adora on Instagram to keep an eye on her, so trying would have been pointless – but she didn't think Scorpia would be following along as they shot.

"What does she want?" Scorpia asks, her voice failing at neutral. Not that she sounds bitter or anything – she's still *Scorpia* – but she is clearly invested despite her best efforts otherwise. Catra snorts, sending Adora one last text and putting her phone to sleep.

"To check in," she informs her, setting her phone aside. Scorpia's face gives a very obvious twitch.

"Nice of her," Scorpia manages, because even when she isn't sunshine she's still rainbows. Catra snorts, pitching over on the couch to lean into Scorpia's side. Scorpia seems to immediately forget her bitterness, gasping and lifting her arm up so Catra can tuck into her side. It's a little too warm – Scorpia runs even hotter than Adora does – but she's kind of in withdrawal after having Adora all over her and then *nothing* so she lets Scorpia wrap an arm around her.

"She's sweet like that," Catra mutters. Normally she doesn't let her affections show, but it's far too late when it comes to Adora. Catra was broken when Scorpia walked into her life, and one night she was too far gone to care about being vulnerable. She told Scorpia everything. She had never said that she loved Adora out loud before, but she couldn't keep holding it in. As low as she felt at the time, she thinks the moment she finally said it might have been the one where she started healing. Having Scorpia right there to wrap her in a hug – after a protective blanket layer, at least – helped a lot too.

There was just Scorpia's crush to deal with.

"Good. She has a lot to make up to you," Scorpia mutters. Catra snorts. Scorpia was obviously jealous the first time Catra mentioned they were talking again, but she was at least already in the process of trying to move on from Catra. Catra couldn't work so hard to build a business together only to have it fall apart. She told Scorpia that if

they were going to do this, they had to do it as friends. Scorpia had to let any chance she thought they might have together go.

Dating within the team was only going to end in disaster. Scorpia finally seemed to accept that it wasn't going to happen then, and more importantly, why. Catra was never going to turn off Adora's post notifications, but she couldn't fuck around with Scorpia because she couldn't take *losing* somebody else. Scorpia still side-eyes Catra's phone when she's texting Adora, and her jealousy isn't completely gone, but she's gotten better over the last few months.

"Have you forgiven her?" Scorpia asks. They're still talking in murmurs despite being the only ones home. Entrapta passed out at the shop this afternoon, so they moved her onto the couch with a blanket and her phone tucked into her hand. They've tried bringing her home before, but she got really disoriented and upset when she woke up, so now they just move her into a better spot. It happens more often than it should, but at least they're here now to move her. When she worked alone, she had problems with waking up hunched over her desk with a back injury, or worse, on the floor. Sometimes she wouldn't leave for days at a time without even realizing it.

"Yeah. I guess. It was a shitty situation for her too. And she never stopped trying to fix it," Catra mumbles, tucking her face into Scorpia's shoulder. She's bad at talking about this, but she needs her to understand. She wants Adora in her life, for the rest of her life, but she wants Scorpia there too. She wouldn't have gotten this far without her. She still feels like she might fuck things up with Adora if Scorpia encourages her to hang onto her bitterness. Scorpia is quiet for a long moment. Then she squeezes Catra a little closer.

"As long as she treats you right," Scorpia settles on. Catra snorts. That is a *hell* of criticism coming from Scorpia, but she can work with that.

"I'll make sure she does," she promises. Adora definitely *treated* her *right* earlier. She's hopeful about their future.

Chapter End Notes

Friend break ups can be just as devastating as relationship ones, but given all the language Adora uses around Catra, Glimmer and Bow began to suspect the almost-nature of their relationship a long time ago. When they brought it up, Adora would immediately shut them down, but that didnt exactly convince them otherwise. When someone's response to "Did you have feelings for her" is "We werent dating" and not "No" it's a little obvious.

She-ra x Clawdeen

Chapter Summary

Clawdeen takes her first steps at a convention.

Chapter Notes

Adora mostly cosplays live action and video games. She likes the challenge of video game cosplays since they're don't have to be realistic, but she doesn't do a lot of stuff with animated shows/movies.

So uh
I may have fucked up

Not surprised but in what way

I'll let you bully me this time because I deserve it
Don't look at your comments

I'm checking my comments

Let me explain first!!

Make it quick, I'm running errands

You said to tell them you were taken
And they may have jumped to conclusions

Conclusions

Well I've tagged you before
So people recognized you on my story

You're taking too long I'm checking my comments

I didnt say you were my girlfriend they just assumed!
I didnt know how they would take it
Catra come back
Catra I was trying to do what you told me

I have DMs Adora
Is this what your DMs look like

Honestly? Mine are definitely way worse

I just got a thirst comment on a video of me using a chainsaw

Is that unusual?..

YES OF COURSE ITS UNUSUAL ADORA
I just checked your story
How did you not think this would happen

I dont know!! I just said what you told me to
This is your fault actually :(

You can tell yourself that
Youre going to regret this btw

Im sorry I didnt mean to

Not what I meant

?

Adora replied to your story

Back in the shop re-energized from a great day together

Ready to finish this build

Tap to view

CATRA
THEYRE GONNA THINK THEYRE RIGHT

le in our bed that you made Adora

-

Catra goes to the shop without finishing her errands because she *ne*d to work. It's that or break something, but she already punched her hand through the *i ne*f*K*e box on an especially bad day. Kyle is such an idiot, he came in and wondered how he had managed to fuck something up enough to warrant the break without even knowing about it. It had nothing to do with him, but this, *thi s* has a source.

She doesnt care about the comments. She really doesnt. Only a few annoying people have migrated over to her page, and fewer to her DMs. No, what she cares about is that she and Adora are now engaged in a *w* and Adora posted a preview of her editing one of the –less risqé photos on her story , gushing about how it's hard to focus on editing when she's looking at someone so pretty.

It's the exact kind of thing that Catra has fucking dreamed of Adora saying about her, except it's all a game they're playing – or *i s t*, because she doesnt know anymore, not when Adora' s hands felt like *tha* on her and now she's encouraging this. Sure, Catra started it, but Adora could have posted a clarification – it technically wouldnt contradict Catra's story since it's *p s be* she meant just as friends – or even just ignored it. Now Catra is distracted, shivering randomly when she remembers Adora's hands on her or the *mo* she managed to earn.

She hates not living with Adora anymore. She hates only keeping up via DMs. She hates not being able to look her in the eye and get a *hi nt* to what she's thinking. She hates the fact that she isnt in Adora's arms right now. She can count how many times they've seen each other in person since reuniting on her hands. It's just not

enough, not after yesterday. She goes to the shop so she can work through her frustration – actual and sexual – doing some heavy work, but it's still hard to focus.

She hopes Adora finds a con for them soon. She needs to get Adora to herself for a few days. She wants to go to sleep and waking up with her again. She thinks it would help their relationship a lot, and also she's fucking desperate. Maybe she'll drop hints. Maybe she'll just ask Adora over. She's too worked up to make any decisions right now. She's going to channel this frustration into something and then maybe she can spend the evening texting Adora guilt-free. It won't be the same, but it's what she has right now.

--

Perfuma @perfuma@tusky.social 1m

The line-up for my AnimaCon panel just got posted! It's going to be a great discussion on the intersection of cosplay and gender. Follow the link in my bio for details and to buy passes <3

Adora @adora@tusky.social replying to @perfuma@tusky.social

This is going to be such a cool panel. I'm so glad you finally got it off the ground!

Perfuma @perfuma@tusky.social replying to @adora@tusky.social

Thank you, I'm really excited! You should totally come.

Adora @Tuf *Pyngto@us.n*

Bow's already bummed he cant see it so I might have to and report back lol

---

Prtuma *@us.nTuf* *Pyngto@s*

Yes! Bring your girlfriend too so I can meet her

--

Good news: I found us a con and it's soon

Im waiting for the bad news

Why does there have to be bad news

Still waiting

Even other cosplayers think were dating now

Not news
Still funny
What's the con

AnimaCon
I didnt consider it cuzAnimation
But Im sure there will be other nerds there
And honestly there's a panel I really want to go to

The gender and cosplay panel?

How'd you know

1) Scorpia is an animation nerd and she was interested in it
2) Your twitter

Is Scorpia going?

No that would be so awkward she hates you

Wait she does?

Well not really
But she's the one who picked me up after the fight
So yeah she kind of doesn't like you. As much as she' s capable of it

Oh
Okay
She's a good friend I guess?
Honestly I used to be really jealous of her
So I guess it's kind of mutual

Jealous huh

She was your friend when I couldn't be

Yeah
Well
I think you two would like each other if you gave each other a chance
Guess it's best for the rest of us you're not though
You would be insufferable in the gym together

Now I have to win her over

Get Perfuma's number for her
She just looked at the line up and turned red

Oh yeah? Interesting
Does she know who Perfuma is?

She does now

--

Adora headed to AnimaCon mentioned you in a post
"Never thought I'd see the Princess of Power in a place like this. What's the matter, cat got your tongue?"
This was such a fun photoshoot and there's more to come! Until then, come see us in person at AnimaCon. I'm going to be in character with @catraprops as She-ra and Clawdeen all weekend. Catra made me an AMAZING new prop, but you're going to have to wait until the con to see it!
Costumes by me, @catraprops as Clawdeen, 📸 by @bowtastic
Tap to view

--

AnimaCon is kind of a last minute choice, but that's actually ideal. Catra manages to arrange things at the shop so she can take a weekend away. She'll probably still have to deal with emails while they're gone, but they'll have plenty of time together. Adora is *overjoyed* to pull up outside of Catra's townhouse for the first time to pick her up. The con is a few hours away, so they head out early on Friday morning.

"Good timing, Scorpia and Entrapta just left," Catra tells her as she climbs into the passenger seat after dropping her suitcase in the backseat. Adora throws her a smile as she puts the car in drive and feels her heart skip when Catra returns it.

"I wouldn't mind seeing Entrapta, actually. I haven't talked to her since BannetCon," Adora says as she pulls out of the driveway. Catra snorts, slouching down in her seat and shifting around to get comfortable before she seems to decide it isn't going to work and sits up to adjust the seat. As Adora pulls out onto the main road, Catra angles her seat back and goes boneless, sighing happily.

"Yeah, well, she's a package deal with Scorpia for the weekend, and Scorpia would probably ask if you brought condoms, so just message her on Instagram or something," Catra says, showing no concern for the fact Adora is driving as she shorts out her brain. Adora feels a headrush come on, equal parts blush and consternation.

"Excuse me?" she coughs out, throwing Catra a desperate look in the one second she is comfortable looking away from the road. Catra seems unbothered, or perhaps amused. Adora can see her tail twitching in corner of her eyes as she looks forward again.

"Interrogate you on your intentions, that kind of thing. You're sweeping me away for a weekend getaway, princess. With the Instagram dating, she's protective. She wants you to treat me right," Catra says, composed and amused, a smug curl to her voice. Adora's face is so hot. Catra is teasing her, definitely, but she's also flirting with her, and after the photoshoot and said *hand holding*, as staged as it is…

Adora wants to reach over and take Catra's hand – or maybe her tail, twitching on the seat beside her, or maybe even put her hand on Catra's thigh and *see*, but that's far too bold, too fucking creepy, for her to try without warning. She wants to say something, *do* something, but she's also scared because they're about to be in the same car for four hours, and then in the same hotel room all weekend. It's not too late to turn around if something's too much, right? She can't be bold, but maybe…

"I'll treat you right," Adora says, trying for something passable, but her voice is too soft, feels too *obvious* in the quiet air of the car.

Catra's tail thumps against her seat. Fuck. *Pl ease*, please just let it be okay. If she doesn't like it, let it at least be okay.

Catra's head turns away in her periphery, looking out the side window.

"I know," she replies, her voice just as soft. Adora swallows. She has nothing she can say that wouldn't be too real or *wr ong*. Of her options, reaching for Catra's hand seems the least dangerous, but despite how many times they have held hands in the past, there would be a heavy implication to it this time that she can't quite muster.

She lifts her hand. She wants to do it – but she doesn't. She reaches for the radio instead, turning it on. Catra's ear twitches in her periphery, but she doesn't say anything either. Adora turns the volume down to make sure it's not too loud for her, but for the moment, she lets the silence fall. It doesn't feel awkward, even if it's a bit heavy. They'll strike up another conversation in a few minutes, and knowing them, it will be completely unrelated.

The moment came, and it went, but she thinks that maybe she doesn't have to be disappointed by that. Maybe every time they step closer, they don't step as far back.

--

Catra | Wildcat Workshop posted a story
This idiot likes to sing along with every song on the radio
Tap to view

The video is brief, but pop music comes over distorted through the speaks as Adora gives an impassioned – and off-pitch – rendition of a Top 100 hit. Her singing isn't bad, but her lack of

training is obvious. She’s beaming and obviously aware of the camera, even though her gaze is focused on the road.

--

Adora headed to AnimaCon posted a story
Princess wants you to know we're on our way to the convention with a new prop in tow 👀
Tap to view

The photo is of Adora, with a French fry hanging out of her mouth, blinking at the camera in surprise. Three wrapped fast-food items and a container of nuggets are piled around the steering wheel in her lap. She has the fry container in her hand and the straw of her soda can be seen poking up from the cupholder.

A second photo follows, this one of two wrapped items sitting on the lap of a magicat. The caption clarifies: that was all for her btw, this is mine.

--

It’s nice to spend an afternoon with Adora, mostly joking around and telling stories, but it’s a long car ride, especially without stopping. They want to get to the convention as early as possible so they dont miss too much of its first day, so they barely pause for a drive-through. Once they finally arrive, Catra walks over to get their passes while Adora checks them into their hotel room next door.

They're staying in the convention center 's attached hotel, so it saves them a bit of time to split up.

Adora texts Catra their room number before she has even gotten through the line to pick up their passes. She expects to return to find Adora already half unpacked. Instead she finds her standing in the hall outside their room, bouncing on her heels. Catra barely turns the corner before she picks up on the scent of anxiety in the air. Adora's ponytail bounces as she whips her head around upon spotting Catra. Adora throws her a smile that does nothing to fool her.

"Alright, what broke?" Catra asks, coming to a halt in front of her .

"Nothing! Everything is fine- *i nth a* ," Adora rushes, her cheeks darker than usual. Catra crosses her arms and cocks out a hip, waiting. Adora winces. "There may have been a... miscommunication with the hotel," she says, looking up at the ceiling like she has no idea how that could have happened. *Mo mmuni ti on* has always been a pattern with Adora. Catra narrows her eyes at her.

"What, did you get the honeymoon suite? Out with it," she tells her . Clearly they have a room, so she doesn't really know what Adora is making a big deal of. Adora takes a deep breath.

"I said I needed a double, and then they were talking about only having one available and..." Adora trails of f, embarrassment still evident on her face. Catra stares at her. Adora finally tilts her head down and meets her eye. "W ell, it ended up being just one double bed," she admits. Catra blinks at her , her tail flicking behind her. It isn't a big deal, right? They used to have sleepovers all the time. It will be awkward after so long, probably, but if she's being honest, it gives them an excuse to cuddle. Maybe by midnight she'll regret it, but right now, she kind of *l i ke* s it. Her tail swings a few more times without her consent as Adora tugs at the edge of her sleeves to pull them over her hands and fiddle with them.

"Okay . Fine. You're an idiot, but I already knew that. I assume switching rooms isn't an option?" Catra asks, moving again to face

the door and holding her hand out to her side expectantly. It's Adora's turn to stare at her, but after a moment she shakes her head and reaches into her pocket, pulling out a room card and handing it to Catra.

"No, they're booked up with the convention. We could try a different hotel, though," she says, her tone still nervous even as Catra unlocks the door. Catra flicks an ear in acknowledgement as she sweeps inside. It's a fairly standard hotel room, a small bathroom to the right of the door, a large window on the far end of the room, and a bed in the middle of the space. The TV looks pretty nice, there's a wardrobe that will be good for their costumes, and the chair in the corner clearly isn't designed for hybrids with tails. The furniture and finishings are slightly different, but it's pretty much the exact same room she stayed in for BannetCon.

"Having to drive somewhere else every time we leave the con is going to be more of a pain than sharing a bed," Catra calls over her shoulder as she crosses to the bed and sits on the edge. It is small for two adults to be sharing, but it really won't be that big of a deal. At least it's not a *twin*. Adora follows her inside, still holding her sleeves over her hands but no longer twisting and pulling at them. She looks hopeful, throwing Catra a cautious smile.

"Guess it's going to be a bit harder to convince Scorpia of my intentions than I thought," Adora says, trying for a joke. Catra snorts, glancing down at their bags that Adora left against the wall.

"I'm the one you really have to convince, and it's going to take more than that," she tells her, throwing her a smile that she hopes passes for as casual as it does flirty. They had a *moment* back when she first got in the car and despite how nerve-wracking it was, it felt good. She'd like to keep some of that *peace* up all weekend long, if she can. The photoshoot almost felt like a fucking breakthrough and Catra doesn't know how many more *hurdles* she can take.

She just wants. She has two days to decide how badly. Adora blushes at her words, taking a step closer and offering Catra a smile

with more confidence than the last.

"Well, you know I'm a try hard," Adora says, and it shouldn't be endearing, but it reminds Catra of every message Adora sent over the years even after the last dozen were unanswered, and she smiles back. Adora's smile turns into a full-on beam and she bounces on her toes a little as she glances around the room. "You ready to experience the con? Then we can get dinner and, I don't know, come back and watch TV to wind down?" Adora asks, genuine excitement in her words.

It's a bit of a disappointing topic shift, except maybe it isn't. Adora has been clear on wanting to experience cosplay with her. The dinner could even – depending on where they go – be skewed as a date. Watching TV is almost certainly code for cuddling together given the TV's placement opposite the foot of the bed. Catra doesn't want to hang out in the hotel room anyway after being cooped up in the car for so long, and the whole point of getting here as early as possible on Friday was to dip into the con when it was still sparse of attendees so she got a softer introduction to Adora's whole *bit* thing.

"Sounds perfect," Catra agrees, adding a purr to her voice as she stands. A light immediately dances in Adora's eyes. Catra briefly considers saying fuck it and pulling her into the bed then and there, but she manages to keep her reaction down to a teasing smile.

Maybe the weekend will be enough to know. As scared as she has always been to lose Adora, after getting a taste of her, she kind of just wants to *know*.

--

Fridays are a slower time for cons, if they're even open for them. Most people opt to wait until the weekend proper, or only arrive late if they do come for Friday. Perfuma's panel isn't until Sunday, but starting off when the crowds are thin seemed like a good call, especially since they're leaving early on Sunday, when the attendance diminishes again. Catra is good at bravado, but she almost seems to get nervous as they make their way down to the vendor hall. Adora doesn't dare mention it, but she makes sure to walk close by Catra's side.

The con has only just opened to the public, but it isn't particularly busy. Glancing around, there are even a few empty tables for vendors that haven't arrived yet. They will get filled—AnimaCon is a pretty well-known convention—but for the moment it is the perfect environment for Catra to take her first steps as Clawdeen. Adora is honestly glad for the smaller introduction for her new sword as well. Catra wasn't wrong when she brought up accidentally hitting people with it, okay, and having a little more time to get used to the new one before diving into a tight crowd is good.

The sword is actually what draws them attention initially. The first three people who come up to them do it to compliment and ask questions about the piece, set on its dim setting but still eye-catching. Catra seems to tense up—or at least pause—for the first few seconds when someone stops them, clearly unsure what to do or say before they ask a cosplay question and staying in character is no longer a concern.

As soon as they're asking questions about her work, it's easy. She can smile and be nonchalant as she keeps her secrets but drops enough non-specifics to satisfy curiosity. The third time, Adora finds out Catra is carrying business cards *in her top* after she pulls one out to give to the person she got into conversation with. Adora looks away, feeling a blush on her cheeks, as she waits for them to wrap up.

"What's the matter, princess?" Catra purrs as soon as she has bid the congoer goodbye. Adora glances down to find Catra with a

familiar grin on her face, tail twitching back and forth behind her. It occurs to Adora that this whole little exercise might have been pointless, because Catra doesn't have to do character acting to be Clawdeen, she just *is* her. Or at least, Clawdeen represents a side of Catra, one that Adora is intimately familiar with.

"I just didn't know you had those there," Adora mutters, rubbing at her neck. She was in the bathroom while Catra changed, and vice versa. She had no idea what Catra was doing when she reached for her chest for the two seconds before she pulled out her card. Catra smirks at her, reaching up and wrapping herself around Adora's arm as if to hang off of it, except what she really does is press her tits up against her bicep. Adora's forearm is against the soft fur of her stomach, but she can *feel* the solid muscle beneath it. Her blush isn't going to retreat any time soon.

"If you had given me pockets, maybe I'd have somewhere else to put them. I don't know where you expected me to put my money," Catra returns, rolling her eyes, but she still has that teasing smile. Her tail is lashing from side-to-side, slow but powerful. Adora glances down involuntarily, eyes taking in *all* the skin exposed by Catra's outfit, which she only manages to be desensitized to for so long before she remembers Catra is near-naked and gets flustered all over again.

"Uh, I mean, that's where I keep my money and stuff too. There's not a lot of room. It just surprised me," Adora manages, flexing her arm a little just to feel it shift against Catra. She has a small pocket – more of a slit, actually – sewn just inside her bust for keeping her money and con pass if she can. Right now she's just wearing it around her neck, so she hasn't shown the utility of it to Catra, but it is there. She also has a small zipper bag almost the exact size of her phone attached to her secret shorts beneath her skirt for storing her phone, but she didn't bother doing that with Catra's. She figured this would be a one-off costume, and her skirt is shorter than She-ra's, so it would have been harder to hide.

"Hm, I think that She-ra just isn't as big and bad as she wants to be," Catra purrs back, her smile predatory in the exact way that makes

Adora's mouth go dry. The words light the competitive spark in her, however, her arm immediately flexing against Catra. She allows herself a half second of enjoying the touch before she pulls her arm away and reaches behind Catra. Catra's eyes have just enough time to widen before Adora grabs her tail right above the tail wrap that she was surprised Catra put on again and *pulls*.

Catra squeaks, face flushing and tail immediately lashing. It pulls out of Adora's hand as Catra gives a small jump backwards, bumps into a congoer, and then jumps *forward* again into Adora's side before the congoer can even turn around. Adora fumbles to catch Catra, blinking down at her, as Catra turns her head to glare at the turning lizardfolk she just bumped into as if it's his fault. Adora feels a slight growl rumbling against her arm as the lizardfolk looks at Catra over his shoulder, unhappy if the way his nostrils are flaring is any indication.

"Sorry about that," Adora says, throwing him an apologetic smile before she wraps her arm firmly around Catra and hurries her away. Catra's chest is still buzzing slightly as Adora hurries them down to the end of the row of booths so Catra can get a moment of air. Adora has never been surprised cons weren't Catra's thing given how loud they can get, not to mention how many scents must be mixing on the show floor, but until this moment she hasn't seemed fussy. Growling at strangers who didn't do anything is a solid indicator that she's getting overwhelmed though.

"Alright, let's go for less in-character," Adora tries for a joke. It would be *funny* Clawdeen to bump into someone else and threaten them over it. Catra rumbles, tone deeper this time, and Adora assumes it's a purr now as she tucks her face down into Adora's shoulder. It's momentary like one would be, anyway. Her tail is still lashing, though not as furiously as before. Adora just holds her as she waits for Catra to recenter.

--

Animal at AnimaCon posted a story
Spotted @adora.cos and @catraprops at AnimaCon! They're so cute. I need someone to hype me up to ask for a picture
Type something

The photo is slightly blurry, or perhaps just low-quality from being zoomed in, but Clawdeen can be seen huddling in She-ra's arms near a set of exit doors despite a passerby's back taking up almost half the frame.

A second photo follows, this one of what appears to be a pangolin furry in a partial fursuit beside She-ra, who is either fending off or trying to support Clawdeen as she lounges back against her side wearing a satisfied smirk. She only has one foot on the ground, her other raised and resting against She-ra's knee, truly forcing She-ra to center her gravity. One arm is crossed to prop up her other arm, hand raised in the air to show off her claws. The sword of power is lit with a dim rainbow in She-ra's free hand, for all that she seems to have forgotten it while managing her companion. The caption reads: thanks for the encouragement guys!! They were super cool.

--

It has been a long time since Adora pulled on her tail and Catra kind of *completely forgot* how much that does for her. The way she did it kind of hurt, but the effect it has regardless was compounded by how little she expected it. They were in public, and even though Catra selfishly hid what the touch does to her from Adora knowing she would *stop* if she knew, she still somehow expected Adora to have more decorum than that. It isn't a secret that it can turn magicats on,

even if it varies. She doubts it is mainstream knowledge to most people, though.

She-ra did it to Clawdeen once or twice in the show and they at least *note* it like it was merely an annoyance. To be fair, that's all it felt like to Catra before puberty too. The lizardfolk definitely smelled her reaction, but growling was enough to deter him from more than a look. Maybe she's desperately grasping for any distraction from her state – *and* the way she huddled into Adora while Adora was letting her – but she slips into character as soon as someone approaches them again.

Adora does too, following her lead and then taking it for herself. Following Adora's direction, they only stay half in-character, channeling some of their characters' attitudes, but the fan who approaches them actually knows who they *both* are and even fangirls over the sword, so they have a brief chat with her about cosplay before she moves on. Catra never leaves character though. She's in a mood – horny – and the uncertainty she felt at first at the idea of pretending to *be* Clawdeen rather than just channel her brattiness is less important than the reminder that she can flirt with Adora however she wants to right now.

She'd like to pull *her* tail, but the closest equivalent she probably has would be giving Adora a hickey or something equally explicit. Not that she thinks that touching Adora and purring flirtations in her ear – she *has* to stretch up until her lips are brushing her ear, of course, the con simply must be that loud and Adora's hearing is too dull to recognize it – is subtle, but it is *definitely* She doesn't make as much of a mess of Adora as she did during the photoshoot, but she goes from feeling generally awkward at the con to having a *great* day.

Once Adora fails to fight her blush down even when taking a photo for a fan, she seems to decide she can't take more and asks Catra if she wants to get dinner. It's only been a few hours since they had lunch on the road and Catra can't imagine Adora is hungry again after everything she ate, but she *is* Adora. Catra's nerves are starting to get grated by the sensory experience of the vendor hall so she

agrees. It isn't nearly as bad as she is insisting it must be, but it is annoying. Adora isn't putting her hands on her nearly enough for how much of her skin is exposed, so she kind of just wants to go put on normal clothes. Maybe Adora will touch her more when it feels less illicit, but it will at least be less disappointing if she doesn't.

"At least change first," Adora prods her when Catra collapses face first on the bed upon arriving back in the room. She isn't looking forward to tomorrow when there will be more people and more *noise*, even if running around the convention with Adora is admittedly fun. Adora's hand lands on her back, rubbing gently – no, not gently, firm but *soothing* – as Catra *whimpers* into the bed. She would have cared about keeping Adora's costume in good condition up until the moment when she put her hands on her, but now she couldn't give less of a shit.

Her tail is swaying and she is fighting – maybe even failing – to keep her fur from standing on end. Adora's hand pauses and Catra curses her own body's reaction. She wants to whine, she wants to flip over so Adora's hand will be on her front, and she kind of wants to crawl in bed and go to sleep because as electrifying as all this is, it's *exhausting*. It's early, not even close to when she normally sleeps, and they definitely still need to get dinner, but the shiver that runs through her body when Adora's hands start to properly rub at her lower back again is more important.

"You want to hang out here a bit before we go out?" Adora asks above her, voice quiet. Catra immediately purrs. Adora's hands stop again – *no* – and then she slides one up, resting it between Catra's shoulder blades. It takes Catra a second to realize she's feeling her purr. For some reason that flusters her even more than Adora's hands on her and the pace of her tail picks up. "Okay, we can do that. Changing, though? I spent a long time making all those fang details and I'd prefer they don't get crushed," Adora prompts.

Catra sighs dramatically, but Adora already isn't rubbing her back anymore, so she reluctantly pushes back off the bed to stand. She blinks down at Adora, who sat on the edge of the bed to comfort her

and is now looking at her with *falling* eyes that make Catra's face hot. Catra's tail starts lashing again when Adora rises and steps closer, her gaze fixed lower than Catra's eyes and hands lifting to her face-

Adora smooths her cheeks tufts down, the touch soft and intimate, but not going in to cradle her jaw like Catra *thought* she was going to – like Adora did when she kissed her . Catra's heart is beating rapidly against her chest as she gazes up at Adora with what she knows must be open awe, but fuck, that almost felt like an aborted move. She's projecting and she knows it – that light was only dancing in Adora's eyes because she finds it cute or whatever when Catra's fur gets messed up – but she isn't going to convince her heart to calm down, not when Adora drops her hands down to rest lightly on Catra's wrist instead, giving it a gentle squeeze.

"I'll go change in the bathroom. Ill give you time to change too," Adora says, nothing close to the declaration or at least *fixation* Catra wants. She forces her heart to settle as she nods.

She isn't going to make it through the weekend alive – not without fucking against a wall, at least.

--

Catra has been *inebriatingly* flirty, and as dangerous as leaning into it feels, Adora can't resist. After they both quietly catch up on their phone notifications in the room, she takes a risk on holding Catra's hand as they head down to the car for dinner. It's something they used to do sometimes, with or without reason, and though it makes Catra's tail lash and her ears twitch, she doesn't comment or pull away. Adora suggests Catra's favorite chain restaurant – *hope* chain restaurant, anyway, this trip was last minute and has the

budget to match—for their dinner—, but that feels more like being considerate than making a move.

Dinner largely just feels like a regular hang out, but she does manage to make Catra laugh at the exact right moment for her to inhale a small fleck of her food and nearly choke, which is bad but also good, and they at least manage to laugh about it more afterwards. She thinks about how good Catra looks in her passenger seat for the whole drive back to the hotel. When they return to their room, Catra sets to answering messages and working on promo posts. She stretches out on the bed to do it, so Adora turns the TV on—volume low with captions on so it doesn't bother Catra, of course—and settles unnecessarily close to her on the bed. Catra doesn't acknowledge it at all, which either means she didn't notice or didn't care.

.Or it could mean that she wanted to give *herself* plausible deniability, because Catra starts fidgeting not two minutes later.

"My neck hurts," she mutters, an aimless complaint and *justification* as she sits up, readjusts, and then drops back down much closer to Adora this time. She is laying on Adora's arm, actually, as if only Adora's pillow can provide proper support despite her own being identical—not that Adora is *complaining*. No, she is holding perfectly still like breathing wrong is going to scare Catra off. Acknowledging the touch might make Catra pull away, at least if she feels like Adora is mocking or rejecting it.

Holding still might be even worse though. Adora runs through the same calculations she always runs through when it comes to physical contact with Catra—at least outside of things like headlocks, so far from something with romantic intent that it always feels safe—and realizes that the results don't matter, because if nothing else, her arm is going to do numb soon. Catra's weight on it and the gentle rise and fall of her chest against her side feels incredible, but she isn't as lightweight as she looks. Adora could wait a few minutes and then risk moving her arm to wrap it more

comfortably – *pl ay* – around Catra, or she could do something far bolder: she could acknowledge it.

"Here, let me help you," Adora of fers, nervous enough that it comes out breathy and quiet, but Catra is looking down at her phone and doesn't have time to turn and see Adora's face flushing with embarrassment as she shifts. Catra's ears pin back as she sits up halfway. Adora sees her mouth open, no doubt to say something deflecting or outright cutting before she pulls away to her own side of the bed. Adora sits up before she can, reaching out and tugging Catra back into her arms.

If anything, Catra's ears flatten further back against her head and her tail starts lashing, but she closes her mouth and lets herself be repositioned until she is properly in Adora's lap, Adora sitting up with Catra between her knees and leaned back against her chest. Catra's ears pop up again as she settles down, the end of her tail lashing where she isn't laying on it. Adora *al y* wishes she could see her face right now, but all she has is the top of her head.

"Better?" Adora asks nervously, one arm wrapped around Catra a little too tight. Catra's tail, slowing down before she spoke, immediately picks up speed again and her ears swivel back as if to listen closely. Adora bites her lip, not wanting to breathe too heavily and blow air in her ear or something. She doesn't want to do *anyth ing* to mess this up. A sense of peace, or endorphins, or *somet hing* sweeps through her body as soon as she has Catra in her arms. She doesn't want to disturb her now, when it seems like she might be willing to accept this.

"Yeah, sure. Your tits are good for more than just looks," Catra replies, turning over as she speaks and *snuggl i ng*. Okay, she's actually just getting comfortable after Adora moved her, and settling her head in against Adora's chest, but that's *good too*, especially when it ends with Catra draped over her, head pillowed on her chest. This is so much more than she bargained for, or than she thought Catra would be willing to do, despite the fact this isn't necessarily a

new position for them. Even Catra's words are close to things that have been said between them going back to high school.

"Wow, kinda gay," Adora responds, because she has to *not* lock up and melt down as a human over Catra cuddling her despite how she *really wants to*. Well, primarily she wants to toss the remote aside and cuddle Catra back, but with that likely off the table, meltdown is her second-best option. Maybe in a few minutes, when they're settled again, she can shift and cradle Catra back without it being a big deal, but they've already pushed several boundaries.

Why are there boundaries between them, again?

"Almost like I'm a lesbian or something," Catra yawns, finishing off the movement by rubbing her cheek against Adora's chest. Adora's libido, previously quiet compared to the comfort the embrace was giving her, suddenly decides to start paying attention. Adora does her best to mentally command her body to settle, tightening her arm still thrown over Catra to try to satisfy the twinge within her that wants *more*.

This is already damn near perfect. Adora ducks her face forward and presses it into Catra's hair before she can doubt herself. She barely stops herself before she presses a kiss there, but nuzzling into Catra is far from new. It's a gesture of affection for magicats that she picked up young, and Catra is *so soft*, perfect for nuzzling and petting and running hands over as she *grabs* her and pulls her closer.

Okay, so her libido didn't quite go away entirely, but she's so happy with Catra in her arms that her desires don't feel strong, satiated at least emotionally with Catra's cuddling. Catra is still scrolling through stuff on her phone, doing her work or just fucking around, but Adora doesn't need her attention. Just having Catra in her arms is perfect on its own. She has missed being able to hang out together comfortably as much as she has missed cuddling her and spending every waking moment together.

Adora focuses at least half her attention back onto the random cooking road trip show the TV was already playing when she first turned it on. The rest of her is focused on the occasional small flicks of Catra's ears or tail, not to mention how warm and soft she is in her arms, but that's pretty normal for when Catra is with her. Cuddling like this is exactly what she wanted out of this trip. Sometimes hotels can be as uncomfortable as they are new and exciting, but this is *perfect*. This feels like a vacation in the truest sense.

She thought she wanted Catra to cosplay with her – and once Catra got comfortable, Adora had a lot of fun today – but this is something far more important to her. She thought cosplaying together would help them get here, but it ended up happening all on its own. It turned this weekend into something fun rather than something necessary. Adora intends to enjoy every moment of their – as Catra put it – weekend getaway.

She *hopes* to really turn it into one.

--

It was pretty early in the evening when they left the con. They have plenty of time to go back after dinner, but instead they spend the evening cuddling. Catra thought she was taking a risk when she settled herself right against Adora's side, moving too quickly for Adora to catch her in the act and hoping to get away with it, but it turns out all her risk calculations were completely off. Adora all but picks her up and snuggles her. It makes Catra bold enough to wrap around her, cuddling back, and Adora's scent relays utter contentment.

Catra does her best to let go of her nerves after that. It all feels so good, and for every time that she has second-guessed herself recently, it feels like Adora has accepted her advances, at least the

ones she took the risk on going through with. It feels so freeing, almost like a high, to stop worrying so much and just snuggle Adora until she's quietly purring. It's the kind of comfort they used to have between them. Uncertainty about Adora's feelings aside, they were always as physical as they could get away with. The return to it is bliss.

Catra purrs as she snuggles into Adora, absently rubbing her cheek and marking her, but Adora doesn't put up any protests. She hugs Catra back with the arm around her. Eventually they get comfortable enough that it doesn't even feel like a big deal when Adora nuzzles her hair and says she's going to take a shower.

"I'll be back once my hair is dry," she promises, and she is. Catra stretches out over the entire bed and occupies herself with her phone until the roar of the hairdryer dies and Adora returns, now in jogging shorts and a cartoon t-shirt she definitely got from a con at some point, or was maybe gifted. Her hair is still a little damp, but after wrinkling her nose and chuffing, Catra accepts a gently laughing Adora back into the bed.

This time their roles are reversed, Catra primarily focused on cuddling and only absently watching the TV as Adora picks up her phone and spends an hour on Instagram, but it's kind of perfect that way. Besides, if both of them were only paying attention to each other, Catra doesn't know how well she could hold herself back from doing something like kissing Adora. This way she can rub her cheek against Adora's head – only slightly deterred by her damp hair – which at least puts enough of a damper on it that she can fight the urge to purr – without having to worry about getting enchanted by Adora's blue eyes.

"Wanna walk down to the lobby and buy some snacks? I don't know I'll make it through the night otherwise," Adora asks around a yawn as she finally puts her phone down and then turns her face up, blinking up at Catra with those damn eyes that make Catra want to kiss her stupid. Luckily Adora's head is practically upside down to

look at her from this angle. It isn't a good position for kissing. Catra is safe from her impulses.

"You mean buy a snack size bag of chips for five dollars?" Catra asks, raising an eyebrow at her and totally maintaining her cool façade. Adora smiles at her and it is offensively honest, raw warmth that feels so vulnerable not because there is any shyness there, but because it feels so genuine and thus exploitable. She wonders if Adora would consider it fortunate or unfortunate that the only thing Catra wants to *exploit* is her goodwill until they're fucking on the hotel mattress.

"Yeah, but it's kinda cold out there and I don't really want to change to go find food somewhere else. I just wanna be in PJs mode and cuddle," Adora says, without a hint of shame, though her eyes are a bit wide – almost pleading, almost nervous, or almost like *she's looking at the rapist* and should just calm down. Her heartrate picks up just from Adora's words, though. She returns Adora's smile, though with less confidence than she wears it. Still, it makes Adora's widen some, so she must be doing okay.

"Alright, lazy, we can go find some sacrifices to throw into that blackhole you call a stomach," Catra returns. Adora lets out a mix between a giggle and snort, and it should be gross, or at least *dorky*, but instead Catra just wants to grab her face and kiss her breathless. Adora is already sitting up though – pulling away – so she isn't at risk of following through on her thoughts.

Unfortunately, Adora only gets more stunning when she turns to throw Catra a smile over her shoulder and Catra is looking at her right-side up again.

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Adora manages to convince Catra to change into her pajamas so they can match before they even go downstairs. They don't *technically* match since Adora is just wearing some comfortable clothes and Catra is wearing an actual pajama set, but it's the principle of the thing. Catra's pajamas are actually part of a matching set, one that Adora saw her, Scorpia, and Entrapta open and wear on her story last Winterfest with *not a boutique one*, but Adora has two more days of the con left to find something new and matching for them to have that Catra might accept, so she tries to ignore the jealousy.

Until then, snack runs in mismatched pajama it is. She loves dicking around hotels with Glimmer and Bow when they go to cons together and she is already having fun doing it with Catra. When they get back to their room, the TV's still on and showing a baking competition in the background, they mess around with the sad excuse for a table in the corner until they've managed to turn Adora's suitcase and a stack of the dry towels, plus a pillow folded in half, into two makeshift chairs. The structural engineering of Catra's seat isn't great and they end up sat right next to each other so Catra's precarious stack can lean against the suitcase to stabilize, but Adora enjoys their impromptu snack dinner even more than their real one.

They both laugh every time Catra nearly tips over and has to overcorrect by throwing herself against Adora's side, which happens nearly every time Catra shifts her weight. When all their food is gone, Catra grabs her laptop, nearly destroying her "chair" in the process, and they plan out what they're going to do at the con the next day, flipping between the panel schedule, the map of the vendor hall, their memories of what booths interested them, and Adora's list of unofficial meetups and other cosplayers she wants to make sure they see.

It's actually not that much with the focus of the con being something Adora is usually only casually interested in and Catra is largely *un*interested. Normally Adora is scrambling to fit every little thing in and messaging the cosplayers she's casual friends with to see when

they might both have free time for a quick catchup and photo. It's not hard to arrange things for this con with plenty of down time. It doesn't really make sense for them to be here all three days, honestly, but she wanted Catra to have the easier introduction on Friday and Perfuma's panel wasn't until Sunday morning. Only full weekend and Friday passes were still available online, anyway, everything held back for day-of sales or sold out.

They figure out their plans and then they return to the bed, this time both watching the TV and making fun of the bad choices people make in the competition. Catra stretches out on her stomach while Adora leans back against the headboard, but when it eventually comes time to brush their teeth and go to bed, Adora is relieved to find Catra far from done with contact. She crawls into Adora's arms with only a moment of hesitation, and Adora draws her in close just as eagerly.

"Just don't lay on my hair or something," Catra grumbles, putting in her token protest – at least, Adora hopes – as she shifts around and gets comfortable. She ends up on her side, Adora wrapped around her back. She's in more danger of suffocating in Catra's mane, but she lets it go because she can feel a subtle buzz in Catra's chest as she settles down into the pillows and she isn't about to ruin that.

"I'll be careful," she promises, her voice quiet to not cover the trace of Catra's purr in the air. Catra rumbles loudly, almost a growl except for how it's a sound of contentment, and sinks down into the pillow in response. As the acknowledgement drops away, a gentle but deep purr remains, seeping peace right into Adora's body. She's probably going to have to shift around a bit to find a comfortable position to stay in overnight that will let her cuddle Catra without breathing in her hair, but with the soothing vibrations running through her, she already knows she is going to sleep soundly.

She almost doesn't want to fall asleep because she wants to be awake to enjoy this moment, but she forces herself to squeeze Catra close for a moment and then release her with her own contented sigh. The pitch of Catra's rumble changes at Adora hugs her, but she

doesnt shift, still settled in Adora’ s arms, if a bit more loosely. There will be time for squeezing her tight like she might never see her again later, and it would be a bit *obvious* to start doing now, no matter how much affection is clamoring in her chest.

This is enough. This is *thing* .

Catra x Adora

Chapter Summary

> Clawdeen and She-ra have made their debut, but the con is already boring Clawdeen. It cant possibly be more interesting than messing with She-ra.

Chapter Notes

> I went back and tweaked formatting for the Scorpia text convo because it bothered me that it looked like it was written from Scorpia's POV. This has no bearing on anything and was literally just an alignment issue but it had to be done. I dont even know why I did it that way in the first place.
> Im posting this early in honor of Catra's birthday .

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Absolutely not," Catra says, her expression unimpressed, as Adora holds the ear cuffs up to either side of her face. Catra flicks her right ear and then her left in quick succession, swatting the bows decorating both the cuffs. The wire for them is very thin and wrapped in the same ribbon that forms the bows, so Adora is certain they could be bent to frame the base of Catra's ears comfortably, but Catra's disapproval has nothing to do with comfort, even if she has never worn ear wires before.

"Aw, c'mon, you'd look adorable," Adora cajoles. She knows this is going to go nowhere, but it *would* be cute. Catra sends her a withering look and turns away from the booth stocked with cutesy accessories. Adora shrugs, turning back to the vendor table and setting the cuffs back down. Nothing on the table is her style or Catra's, but she thought Glimmer might like something amongst the cutesy accessories. She likes to pick little gifts up from cons. She has a small box of them under her bed, waiting for Winterfest or a birthday to roll around.

She has been *tryng* to find something to get Catra – not as a surprise, just something matching they can share – before they head up to their room to change for a quick lunch trip, but it's kind of hard when Catra is hovering over her shoulder and quick to shut down any inclination Adora shows towards considering something for her.

"I'm right here, I dont need you to buy anything in my stead," Catra points out after Adora has moved on from the booth, a hairclip themed around the main character of Glimmer's favorite anime now in her bag. Adora pouts at her. It's not even about gifts – Catra was never really big on material possessions, and honestly, neither is Adora, she's just very attached to a few – but she wants them to have *somethi ng* .

"You have so much stuff that Scorpia or Entrapta have given you, or even stuff that *matches* with each other. The last thing we have like that is that chisel set I gave you," Adora points out. That was nearly *fourteen* . To her surprise, she sees a smile flash across Catra's lips before she seems to get ahold of herself and sends Adora a flat look.

"And I still use them. Id just donate any little figurine you got me. I only keep Scorpia's gifts because I live with her and shed notice me getting rid of them. Shed act like she was fine but shed probably cry about it or something," Catra replies, grabbing Adora's arm and pulling her out of the way of a large and *noisy* crowd of anime cosplayers without pausing. It brings them chest-to-chest, standing beside a geek 3D-prints booth. Adora finds herself blinking down at Catra, trying to restart her thought process when Catra's mismatched eyes are so close and taunting. Clawdeen's outfit isnt *helping* .

"You do?" Adora manages. It isnt exactly intelligent, but at least it isnt something stupid like *nice stuff* , which is currently poking out over the top of Catra's top. Adora is desperately trying not to stare at it, because then it will just look like she is staring at her tits – which are great too, dont get her wrong! Just not Adora's current

focus, nor should they be – but it always gets a bit hard to focus when Catra is this close. Catra raises a brow at her.

"Yeah. Sometimes I was mad about it, but I never actually wanted to replace them. I've sharpened them enough times they're probably shorter by now, but they're a good set," Catra says, shrugging and looking away. Her tail is twitching behind her. Adora gains enough awareness to realize there's plenty of open space behind her again and reluctantly takes a step back. Really that just gives her a better view of how exposed Catra is in her costume. She resolutely keeps her eyes on Catra's face.

"Well, I don't think I'm going to find matching power tools here, but I'll keep it in mind," Adora replies. Catra laughs and she feels her breath catch.

Maybe she doesn't need to find anything. It's a possessive instinct, truly, wanting something that matches between them so it doesn't look like just Entrapta and Scorpia have a claim over her. It's stupid, and Catra's sparkling eyes as she chuckles might be all she needs.

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Adora ends up with a half dozen small purchases she plans to bring back for herself or her friends despite the con – and its vendor hall – being animation focused. Catra doesn't recognize most of the stuff on the show floor, though she does quietly buy a small stuffed toy of a character she knows Scorpia likes, along with a shirt for similar reasons, resolutely ignoring the smug look Adora gives her as Catra drops it into the bag Adora is loading up before they leave the vendor hall.

The hall is loud today. Catra isn't a fan of it. She ditched the tail wrap for today because she didn't need any extra irritants, but it's a relief

to change out of their cosplays for an hour to go to lunch.

"Wanna stop at a gas station or something and get some snacks for tonight?" Adora asks even as she eats a sandwich roughly equivalent to a quarter of a pizza – in size, it's probably a whole pizza in calories. Catra doesn't even bother to send her an incredulous look. Adora's appetite hasn't surprised her since it turned into an all-consuming eldritch beast back in middle school, and cons always require extra calories, even for Catra. It has only been a few hours since they had breakfast, but she's more surprised that Adora has gone this long without eating anything than by the size of her flatbread.

"Yeah, sure. Just don't get anything that smells too strong. That room isn't big enough for it to dissipate," Catra tells her with a shrug. Adora's a freak who will eat pretty much anything, including fish skin chips, which most of the humans Catra has known avoid. As much as Catra likes them, they smell. There's a reason she never eats in her own room and it's not just because she doesn't want to have crumbs in her bed like Entrapta does. Adora flashes her a smile.

"No problem! I just need something to tide me over before dinner. And probably again after. And then in the morning. We're leaving after lunch, so I'll be fine then. Oh! Do you maybe want to stay over tomorrow? Like I take you back to the Best Friends Squad place and we have dinner or something?" Adora asks, taking a huge bite and saying the final half around the mouthful she is trying to chew as quickly as possible. The closest Weaver got to instilling manners in her is that she at least covers her mouth. Catra will take what she can get at this point. Adora's request is flustering her.

"What, you're not sick of me yet?" she asks, her tail thudding against the side of her seat as she turns that over. Is Adora only asking her for dinner, or to stay the night? Her words aren't clear. If it's the latter, is she expecting them to share her twin bed? Catra needs to go home at *some* point, and she especially needs to get back in the shop come Monday. She already took Friday off. She wants to say yes, but the responsible part of her – and the part that is always on

high alert whenever Adora is around and thus needs time away from her to be able to turn *off* before she does something stupid – says she shouldn't.

Adora finishes swallowing and sends her a kicked puppy look. Catra is broken on the spot, even if she manages to maintain a brave face. It's a lie.

"I'm not ready to say goodbye yet. I've missed this," Adora admits, her voice low. She fiddles with the edge of her plate, looking down at it and up at Catra alternatively as she watches her response. Catra feels her ears twitch and her eyes go wide. Even if Adora can't see under the table, her tail is audibly thudding against the side of her chair as she looks away. Meeting Adora's soft blue eyes is only making her more flustered. Okay, so in a lot of ways she feels the same, but she wasn't expecting *her* to say it.

"I can stay for dinner, but I have to be back in the shop on Monday," she says, ducking her hands below the table so she can physically grab her tail. The elf couple at the next table is giving it the side eye. To be fair to them, Catra might as well have been drumming with it, but to be fair to *her*, she definitely can't control it right now and she doesn't give a shit if it's ruining their lunch's ambience. This place has *bar* in its name, it isn't fancy.

"Okay! Maybe we can do something again when your commission is done? Not a con or anything, those take up so much time, I just mean doing stuff together for a weekend," Adora offers. The end of Catra's tail flicks, but she has the rest of it under control and it doesn't make a sound. She would like to spend more time with Adora – she would like to fucking fall asleep with her every night. If Adora wants her to spend the night *next* weekend. She can make that work.

"Alright," Catra agrees, looking down at her plate and squeezing her hand around her tail. "I'd like that," she admits in a smaller voice. It's a bit uncomfortable to admit – mostly embarrassing – but it's worth it when she looks up and sees Adora's eyes are sparkling.

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Adora texted Netossa last night and found a thirty-minute window between panels where they could hang out. They haven't seen each other in nearly a year and Adora really wanted to get a chance to catch up and show off her new toy to them. She's shown it to everyone in her life enough times that Glimmer is sick of seeing Adora with the sword, but she's still excited by it weeks later and she wants to be able to show it to a new fellow cosplayer and have them marvel over Catra's work.

They meetup in a random hallway, mostly because it's halfway between the panel Catra just had them attend because Scorpia is forcing her to attend these things in her stead, she claims, even though Adora is fairly certain at this point Scorpia doesn't even know Catra took notes on it for her and the upper level where Spinnerella and Netossa's next panel is. The couple is already waiting for them when they turn the corner and Adora waves at them as they walk up, getting a smile and wave back from Spinnerella but a raised brow from Netossa.

"Adora! It's so good to see you again," Spinnerella greets, already lifting her arms for a hug. Adora takes a quick second to assess her costume it doesn't look delicate before she steps in and squeezes her happily. Spinnerella gives great hugs. Netossa isn't as touchy with people who aren't Spinnerella. She's also in a costume with lots of embellishments on the front that Adora doesn't want to mess up, so she steps back and puts an arm around Catra's waist to pull her forward. Catra's tail immediately lashes and her ears twitch, but she doesn't protest Adora pulling her to the center of attention.

"You too! It was such a bummer we missed each other at PGS," Adora returns before squeezing her arm around Catra's waist, a warning and also a luxury she is enjoying while she can. "This is

Catra. We go way back. You might have heard me talk about her, actually, if you were ever at con with me where she had a piece showing,"Adora introduces. She doesnt know for sure that Catra has never met the couple, but she didnt have a reaction to Adora saying their names earlier when she said she wanted to meet up with them, so she assumes she would have mentioned it.

"I saw your shoot together , it was cute!"Spinnerella says as she reaches her hand out to Catra. Maybe Catra just shifts to raise her hand, or maybe she leans into Adora's side as she shakes hands with Spinnerella. Adora lets herself at least consider the latter.

"Cute is a word for it,"Netossa teases, throwing Adora a smirk. Adora feels her face heat. She hasnt even posted any of the provocative pictures yet, just the set from the ambush recreation. Then again, if you dont know what *to* is coming from the shoot, then that would probably seem like a risqué post.

"Oh, I thought she was *adorable* . She turns red a lot more than She-ra did, though. Made it hard to get shots where she looked all big and bad,"Catra says, immediately *jumping* on any opportunity to make Adora blush. Catra looks up to throw her that lazy, *kissable* smirk –at least, that's what the smirk makes Adora want to do –as Adora glares at her, aware that her cheeks are currently demonstrating Catra's point. Netossa –a known traitor –laughs. Even Spinnerella chuckles.

"Well who knows, maybe that's the direction they're taking the new one,"Netossa says, exchanging a conspiratorial grin with Catra. They're ready to team up to tease Adora, but Adora is just staring at Netossa, trying to decode her words. Netossa's brow lifts, seeming to notice Adora's –as Weaver used to call it – *mind spiral* . "I kind of thought you would be bouncing off the walls right now," Netossa adds, but her words are a bit slower, less confident. Catra's grin has dropped too as she glances between them.

"What, did something happen in the half day we havent been on our phones?"Catra asks, her voice that special *hovering* tone,

phoning tone that Adora knows well from every time she missed a social cue or Catra had to lie to keep them from getting in trouble back when they were kids. Half the time it was because Catra needed to take over the conversation, and the other half it was like *now*, where Catra is buying Adora time to figure out what she was expected to do. Usually it was because of one of Weaver's mind games, but it's useful in moments like now too.

"Maybe Adora should just check her mentions. I'm sure it's in there. I wasn't really paying attention, I just saw it and thought Adora would be losing her mind," Netossa says. As appreciative of her as Adora is, she doesn't really need Catra to cover for her now. There's no stakes anymore except an awkward social interaction, and she's spoken to Netossa and Spinnerella plenty of times without Catra. Clearly Netossa has some instincts on how to direct her finnicky attention—although Adora is very focused *now* as she pulls out her phone and checks Twitter.

She doesn't even need to check her mentions. It's the first thing she sees when she opens the app, because algorithms are good for *something* apparently.

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She-Ra & the Masters of the Universe @**DreamWorksSheRa**

A new era begins. The trailer for the new She-Ra & the Masters of the Universe reboot will debut next month at Retro FanFest.

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Adora @AnimaCon @SoSad

WHY DID NONE OF YOU TRAITORS CALL ME THE ANNOUNCEMENT HAS BEEN UP FOR 46 MINUTES MY PHONE SHOULD BE BLOWING UP

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Catra isn't sure Adora would have caught up with Spinnerella and Netossa at all if there had been any information beyond a single tweet copied to all the official studio accounts online, instead glued to her phone reading about it, but all that ends up happening is that the news re-invigorates her energy stores, partially-depleted from half a day of wandering the con. When Adora can't find anything more, they hurry to catch up before Spinnerella and Netossa have to leave.

Catra doesn't have a lot to say having never met the couple, so she spends the entire time flirting with Adora. They aren't pretending to be their characters right now, but Adora is just *hot* when she's dressed as She-ra, a little more confident and – ugh – bossy. It makes Catra want to press her against a wall. Consequently, she flirts with her more. She's channeling Clawdeen, if Adora asks – which she doesn't, oscillating between cocky and flustered as they all take photos out in the hallway together.

"I can't go sit in a panel now. What was on the list, the one with that actress? Are you okay if we skip it?" Adora says to her after the other couple leaves for a panel, shooting Catra a *I ook* as she speaks. Catra grins back at her from where she is hanging off her arm. She draped against Adora for the last photo they took with Netossa and Spinnerella and she hasn't let go since. Adora is too distracted – by the news, by catching up with her friends, by *a* – to make any attempt to pull away. Catra's choosing to believe it's because she doesn't really want to and not just because it hasn't occurred to her that she can yet. Maybe it's even why she's too worked up to sit down right now. Catra feels like indulging in the delusion. Her heart has been singing since the first moment she cooed to Adora and Adora did nothing to protest aside from flushing violently as Netossa laughed.

"We can skip. I'm not taking you for a walk, though. You'll have to go off-leash if you want to run around," Catra says. The only reason they were going to go to the panel was in case Catra could get an autograph for Entrapta from one of the panelists afterwards, but it wasn't likely, and this is far more fun. Adora is flushed up to her ears. Catra kind of wants to stretch up to nip at the side of her ear, just to see what she would do. *a* likes to have her ears – gently – tugged, but she doubts that kind of thing transfers to humans. She's still thinking about it. She still *ats* like she always does.

"You're such a brat," Adora accuses, sending her a glare that is far too flustered to be effective. Catra grins at her, her tail moving slowly and purposefully from side-to-side. Truthfully, she isn't teasing Adora *j ust* to make her blush. She watched doubt set in as Adora searched for information on the announcement and questioned out loud why they would change the name. The reboot could tarnish the memories of something she loves, but it's far too early for her to be worrying about that. Let her worry about if Catra is going to trip her up instead.

"This was your idea, princess. Not my fault you didn't think about consequences," Catra replies, throwing her a lazy grin – making it look *y* to rile her up like this, because it is. At least for her. She

hopes no one else can draw a reaction like this out of Adora. Adora —because she's She-ra right now, *that*— narrows her eyes at her, a light sparking in them that Catra knows means she isn't going to take it lying down. Good. Catra would rather she took *her* laying down.

"Consequences," Adora echoes, steadily, that fucking confidence in her voice that makes Catra's tail lash with anticipation. She turns towards Catra slightly and raises her sword —not high, almost as if it's an unconscious action, but it shifts Catra off her arm. Catra realizes that she doesn't exactly know what she's in for, but all that does is excite her. She raising a hand to place over Adora's hilt and casually turns the sword away so there's nothing in between them. Adora's eyes flare as Catra steps forward, abandoning her side so they can stand chest-to-chest. She grins up at Adora.

"You should have known what you were getting yourself into," she purrs. The words aren't seductive by themselves, not really, but the way she says them certainly is. It's the balancing act, the one step removed —say something flirty but keep her tone casual, or do her best to seduce Adora right there while they're talking about the weather. It's a game, but one she never wins. In moments like this it feels exciting, but she knows in another few seconds —or minutes, if she's lucky— the moment will pass and she will just be left disappointed by the outcome.

The corner of Adora's mouth lifts, a smirk beginning to spread on her face that has Catra instantly forgetting about everything else. Adora *leans in*, and for a moment Catra thinks that Adora is going to wrap an arm around her, maybe pull her close and say something equally flirtatious —as She-ra talking to Clawdeen, of course— but when Adora's arm slips behind her back, she doesn't wrap it around her waist. She grabs the base of Catra's tail and she *tugs*.

Adora can't know it, but she does it *just right*, her hand at the base so it doesn't hurt, her grip firm so Catra gets the pressure that drives her wild, and using a long, purposeful yank that makes her toes curl and her fur fluff up. A trilling moan erupts from Catra as she

lifts up on her toes, unconsciously trying to make the pull even harder. She gasps at the end, desire heating her blood. Her entire body takes part in the involuntary reaction, straining forward for more even as her back arches to shove herself further back into Adora's touch.

Adora's eyes go wide, realizing she has done *something*, but her hand hasn't let go yet and Catra is so turned on her brain isn't catching up with the fact that Adora didn't do that on purpose. She just touched Catra. *Touched* her, hands on the most erotic zone on her body aside from two fingers deep inside her. Her blood is on fire. She doesn't think, just acts, reaching up and grabbing Adora by the shoulders so she can *yank* her down. She means to bury her face in her shoulder, maybe even bite her to push down the purr still rolling through her, just do *anything* to bring Adora closer except the one thing she actually does.

She pulls Adora against her and gives her about three seconds of their bodies against each other to push her away, Catra's nose pressed against her cheek and their mouths *tantalizingly* close. Adora's lips part as she gasps, and she stumbles a little, but she doesn't pull away and Catra can't wait any longer. She pants, once, and then kisses her full force. It's too aggressive, but the pause was all the courtesy she could manage. She is so turned on she kind of wants to *fight*, just do anything to get this coiling energy out of her body. It's probably a bad reaction to have, but it goes back to all those times she couldn't do *anything* about what Adora was doing to her, so she would wrestle her because at least then she could feel Adora against her.

Adora doesn't immediately push her away, so Catra does her level best to make their bodies one, pulling Adora closer so she can feel her against every inch of her like her body is demanding after a touch like *that*. She readjusts and kisses Adora again, because she didn't get with the program and kiss her back yet. Somewhere in the back of her mind, a red flag goes up and a voice screams *you're winning* but she doesn't stop—she can't, not when Adora's

hand flexes on her tail again. It's probably just from surprise, but it makes Catra moan, their lips still touching but not kissing anymore as Catra pants to draw in air.

"Catra," Adora gasps, surprise and *something* that sounds a lot like desire to Catra's desperate ears lacing her tone. It's not a *stop*, so it instantly makes Catra want more. She arches her back again, gasping out the start of a purr when that gets her a little more pressure on her tail. She's doing the exact thing she has been holding back since they were fucking fourteen, and she knows she's being desperate and aggressive and maybe even fucking *involving,* but at this point she doesnt care, not when Adora crossed the line first touching her there.

Adora's hand flexes again and Catra moans softly, tilting their mouths together to kiss her again. This time, Adora kisses *back*, gentle and cautious and just like that first time in her workshop despite how desperately Catra is clutching her. If she thought the touch to her tail did it for her, this is another realm entirely, a relief shivering through her body that Adora *matches*, *just' as* . Adora's other arm comes up now, wrapping around Catra's waist and holding her firmly with the sword awkwardly bumping against her arm. It isnt the same desperate attempt to mold their bodies together Catra has been going for, but it's almost better, supportive and –somewhat– grounding.

"Catra," Adora breathes again when their lips part. The burning desire in Catra that *needs* to be met hasnt dissipated –if anything it *grows*– but Adora kissing her and saying her name like that *does* meet it, and it makes it a bit easier to breathe.

"*Adora*," Catra purrs back, her voice fucking besotted and she' s not even sorry, not when it makes Adora draw in a sharp breath and kiss her again, still just as gentle as before, at least until Catra gets involved and kisses back hard –too hard, but she doesnt care even when their teeth nearly bang together. Adora lets out a soft moan, so small even Catra's hearing almost misses it, but she *does* catch it and it makes her press even closer, her tail lashing behind her. She

has Adora pressed against every inch of her but it isnt enough. She needs her pressed against the wall so that when Catra presses closer, Adora's body doesnt give an inch, the two of them as close as they can be.

Catra drops her hands to Adora's hip and pushes, doing her best to guide them back to the wall without breaking the kiss. She totally fails, but it does mean they are pulled far enough apart for her to see Adora's eyes go wide when her back hits the wall. Catra is grinning as she presses in for the next kiss, which makes it considerably harder, but it still feels just as good, so she doesnt care. Adora's hand fell from her tail when she pushed her back, which she definitely cares about, but a few seconds after Catra pins her to the wall, her hands come back up to wrap around Catra's back, suddenly missing the sword.

Then she flips them.

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Adora's body is *on fire*. She still feels several steps behind, even if she is putting together a picture of what happened to get them here now. It's slow work when every cell in her brain is devoted to the thought of *Catra*. They've been flirting for the last thirty minutes straight—well, Catra was flirting with her and Adora was mostly being flustered—but things didnt feel as electric or hot as they have in the past when nothing happened between them.

At least not until Adora touched her tail. Considering the moaning and *writhing*, Adora can figure that one out. She knows that can be a thing for magicats, thanks to a not-at-all disproportionate amount of magicat porn she has seen, but considering she has been pulling Catra's tail since they were kids and she never reacted *once*, Adora assumed it just wasnt a thing for her. The way Catra is kissing her

proves she was wrong. She might have never been as wrong about something in her life, but if the result is Catra kissing her like this embrace is the only thing she wants to feel for the rest of her life, then Adora is okay with it.

Some part of Adora is aware they're in public, but the rest of her just needs to get her hands on Catra and –maybe, unfortunately –slow her down. She doesn't want to stop kissing her, but she wants them to say like, five words, *I love you*, to make sure they're on the same page here before they find the nearest room with a lock and Adora spends her next hour kissing every inch of Catra's body. Adora is already mapping out the quickest route to their room from here, but she needs to know this isn't just because of a single touch before they go that far.

She normally treats the sword like it is the most precious thing in the world, but now she vaguely leans it against the wall without much concern so she can grab Catra and flip them, using Catra's surprise and her own bodyweight to pin Catra tight against the wall. Adora wouldn't put it past her to try to wiggle out the moment she realizes Adora is trying to talk rather than kiss. A kiss can happen first though, because Catra lets out a downright sexy growl and grabs her face, pulling her down into another one. Every one of the kisses has been messy in some way, but Adora certainly isn't bothered by it, not when it's because of passion. Kissing Catra gives her a high that spreads all the way down into her toes and makes her moan as Catra's hands drop to her shoulders.

Their lips part naturally as the kiss finishes, another about to begin until Adora pulls back far enough to suck in a real breath. Either Catra is onto her or she's just impatient, because she pushes on Adora's shoulders and *hops*, using her as leverage to get high enough to wrap her legs around her waist. Adora scrambles to keep from dropping her, her hands finding her ass as she is forced to press in again just to get more support by pinning Catra between her body and the wall. She distantly hears a clatter off to the side that is

definitely the sword falling over, but she tells herself it's built sturdy as she blinks up at Catra.

Her heart beats wildly, a drum in her chest as she gets to watch Catra smirk down at her with a flash of fangs visible for about two seconds before Catra kisses her again. Adora is supposed to be pulling back – *backing off* – but instead she feels herself pressing closer as she kisses Catra with just as much enthusiasm. There's a part of her that says the moment they stop, this will be just like every other time: the electricity will fizzle out, and they'll be left awkwardly pulling back from each other, pretending it never happened.

Adora can't *do* that. She needs this, forever. She needs to feel that vibration in Catra's chest forever, a purr or a play growl or just something *good* that tells her she's kissing her right and she's making Catra happy – that it's Catra against her, no one else it could ever be. Having Catra in her arms, legs around her waist, is *perfect*, something she wouldn't have thought of herself but now she never wants to put her down. She wants to get them to a bedroom, but that would mean leaving this spot and leaving this moment.

If she puts Catra down, she can run her hands over her again like she did back in the shoot. That might be worth it. She flexes her hands on Catra's ass. The problem is that feels good too. Touching Catra, kissing her, feeling the tiny little gasps she gives in between kisses and then kissing her again all feels *too good to stop*, no matter what Adora knows she should do. Catra took her wall plan and totally turned it against her by wrapping her legs around her waist. Experimentally, Adora lifts Catra's ass, bringing her a little higher and a little tighter against her with some effort.

Catra moans. It says a lot that Adora's attempt to rub Catra up against her abs gets a smaller moan than pulling her tail did, but it *is* a moan, and she is kind of grinding Catra against her, so Adora is fucking soaked. No wonder pulling her tail had such a reaction when it is apparently second to this. *This* is incredible on its own, even if it isn't what she should be doing.

Talk. Put her down. *Bedroom*. In that order. She can do this.

.Is what she tells herself as she goes in for another kiss, letting out a pathetic, whimpering moan when Catra wraps her arms around her shoulders and threads her fingers through her hair, fisting it and consequently pulling on it. Adora already knew that was a thing for her, but fuck, it's a *thing*. Normally she has her hair up and it wouldn't work as well, but in costume she can lose herself in the delicious feeling of Catra pulling her hair and wonder if this is what it felt like for Catra when she pulled her tail.

For all her mental efforts to be responsible, she isn't the one who stops them. In the middle of nipping Adora's bottom lip, Catra suddenly pulls back, tugging on it harshly and making Adora moan, but the movement wasn't on purpose. When Adora flutters her eyes open, still processing the spike that caused in her desire, she sees Catra is looking over her shoulder and down the hall, her eyes wide. Her ears are fixed forward too, twitching slightly.

Adora knows she should be concerned, but instead she's thinking about how pretty Catra looks with her lips bitten.

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It's a group of three congoers, all in merch shirts and sporting plastic bags from the vendor's hall. Catra vaguely heard them come around the corner, but it was the awkward *ow, that's hot* that finally made her pull back. Once she has made the most excruciatingly painful eye contact of her life, she quickly turns her face away, ears pinning back as Adora finally looks over her shoulder and breathes out an awkward laugh. She tries to lower her down and Catra doesn't fight it, pulling away and wrapping her arm around herself while Adora waves awkwardly over at the trio and bends down to retrieve her sword from the ground.

"Sorry about that, well just be going now," she says, reaching out blindly for Catra and managing to grab the wrist of her dangling arm. Catra tenses as Adora steps back from the wall and pulls on her, still looking over her shoulder and focused on the trio. She is still looking at the floor, her heart having dropped to the bottom of her chest and then slipped between her ribcage to land somewhere in her stomach. It's over. The moment's over and they're over, because Adora is going to step back and that's going to be it.

"Let's go to our room?" Adora prods, her voice gentle and hopeful and worried. Catra's ears twitch and then slowly swivel forward towards Adora. She hears Adora draw in a quiet breath – relieved? – as Catra's tail flicks slowly to the side. Their room, sounds promising. Their room sounds like maybe that wasn't the harsh wake up call Catra never wanted Adora to have – like maybe she wants to get them somewhere private so they can continue.

"Come on," Adora murmurs, pulling on her arm again, but this time Catra lets her. She drops the arm she has around herself and lets Adora guide her forward, into hers, which is a big shock, but Catra's face heats as Adora wraps a cautious arm around her waist and she finally glances up. Adora looks worried, but a happiness that shines like the sun breaks through the moment they make eye contact, which only makes Catra's face feel hotter as her tail lashes behind her. She immediately looks down again, but this is a different kind of embarrassment and she thinks Adora knows it. She continues to smile in her periphery as she leads Catra back down the hall and towards the – unfortunately – more populated parts of the building they have to go through to get to hotel lobby.

"Soooo." Adora opens with, like a dork. Catra snorts, despite herself. Of course that would be what Adora goes with after they finally fucking kiss – outside of a photoshoot or the threat of one, at least. "Shut up. I wasn't expecting that," Adora returns, but her tone is lighthearted as they navigate away from the panel hallways. Catra chirrups, because words feel dangerous – if she starts talking, Adora might actually start talking – but she still wants to roast Adora.

"How long has, uh, *that* been a thing for you?" Adora asks, avoiding saying it directly as they pass through the halls. Of all the things for her to ask now, it's probably the safest. It doesn't make Catra's fear spike. If anything, the fact they're talking about what *turned her on* as Adora leads them back to their room gives her hope.

"Ten years, give or take," she replies flatly, looking up to watch Adora's eyes widen and her cheeks flush. Flustered is a cute look on her. Catra is sure she is remembering the other times—few, but still very much there—when she has pulled her tail over the years. Like fucking *hard*, even if she didn't do it right then. It still turned Catra on, but it was also kind of painful. It didn't make her want to jump Adora, at least not enough to throw all caution to the wind and *do* it.

"Oh, okay," Adora replies, her voice high and strangled. Catra chuckles to herself, her tail swaying behind her as she relaxes. Adora's tongue darts out to wet her lips as she tries to process that and come up with a response. Catra watches the action closely and, when she tears her eyes from it, realizes Adora was watching *her* watch, and now they're both just staring at each other and turned on in the middle of a hallway. Catra growls under her breath and sets forward again, dragging Adora along with her this time. *The room* is what she needs right now. Adora hasn't pulled away yet. She's hopeful and turned on and seemingly *eager*. Catra wants to pin that eagerness against a wall.

"You, uh, never told me," Adora says, her voice still strangled, but there's an edge of teasing creeping back into it. Catra's face feels hot. They're close to the lobby now, and then it's an elevator ride and two short hallways until their room.

"Did it *seem* like I wanted you to stop?" Catra replies, all sarcasm and bravado because it's what she has. She knows kissing Adora like that was over the line. Even if she gave her an opportunity to push her away first, she certainly didn't *want* it. This is why you tell people you want to fuck them through a mattress before your body just decides that it's happening here and now. Catra glances back

over her shoulder to find Adora's face flushed. It gives Catra some of her confidence back. She throws Adora a smirk before looking forward again to watch where she's going.

They're finally within sight of the elevators. Four floors up, and then they'll be free. They don't have to wait for the elevator to arrive when they call it, it's already there and empty. It's a relief to finally step inside and have the doors close behind them, leaving them *alone*. After the photoshoot in front of Adora's friends, Catra wouldn't have thought being interrupted would bother her like that, but it was just uncomfortable and she wants to get away from other people.

The relief lasts for all of two seconds before she realizes she is alone in a box with Adora and *she* knows it. Adora was fucking smart and waited until Catra was trapped to do anything, but now she tightens her arm around her and turns, looking down at Catra with a serious expression. Catra tenses, her ears twitching back. Adora notices, worry pinching her brow as her expression shifts more into unsure.

"I need to make sure we're on the same page. That this is okay," Adora says as the elevator finally starts moving, swaying Catra slightly where she stands. Adora immediately tightens her arm around her, but she shifts with the elevator's movement too, so really it just feels like she's trying to keep her from running. Catra doesn't want to run anywhere except *into* her, but she's also nervous. She wants them to be on the same page, she's worried that they're not, and she doesn't want to kill the mood when they might finally be close to *doing* this, potential disconnect between their desires beyond this moment aside.

"The page where you blow my back out on the hotel mattress? That page?" Catra asks, her heart racing. Adora has an immediate reaction, letting out a rush of air that sounds a lot like a squeak and flushing all the way up to her ears and *down* to her tits. Catra's tail lashes as Adora's desire hits the air. *Yes, that page, please.*

"Yes, but-" Catra's tail stills, "also the page where you let me take you to dinner afterwards and we stop being all performative on Instagram because we don't have to fake anything anymore," Adora rushes out before Catra's dread can climb too high. It's Catra's turn to blush and let out a noise, but it's far quieter than Adora's was and her dumb senses can't pick it up. There's no way. Catra is letting herself *hope this is* as Adora sends her a small, hopeful smile that really only makes sense if she heard Catra's own small, hopeful sound.

"Obviously," Catra scoffs, like she knew it all along, like this was her grand seduction plan from the start and it's about time Adora caught up. A smile blossoms on Adora's face like the sun rising, but before Catra can get too caught up in sappy, romantic thoughts about how beautiful she is, the elevator stops and the doors slide open. Catra doesn't wait, grabbing Adora's wrist so she can drag her into the hallway. Adora follows, skipping a little to keep up, and then Catra is speeding up to stay ahead and suddenly they're racing down the hallway, inexplicably giggling. Well, Catra is giggling from excitement and nerves and *hope* mixing in a strange cocktail of endorphins. Adora is giggling because she's a fucking dork and she does stuff like that.

Adora catches up with her at the door, and the next thing Catra knows she's being spun around and backed against it, Adora grinning down at her. Catra's tail is lashing. She really wants to wrap her arms around Adora's shoulders and pull her into a kiss, but they're *so close* to being inside and then there's no more interruptions and it's just them. Catra still raises her hand, but she lifts it to Adora's chest instead. Adora makes the exact same face – surprised and horny – she made yesterday when Catra reached into her bra for her business card, but *this* time Catra slips two fingers beneath the edge of Adora's top, seeking out the hidden pocket she knows is there now.

Catra has her hotel key in her own bra, but she would rather watch Adora's eyes go wide and *feel* the soft resistance of her tits as Catra

feels around for the cards. Catra throws her a lazy smirk, never looking away as she pulls the key out and drops her hand down casually to hold it against the door reader. She has to move it around and fumble a bit to get the reader to register it and beep, but from the scent of Adora's desire in the air, Catra thinks she's a bit too preoccupied to notice.

"That first page, princess?" Catra reminds as she pushes off of the door, bringing them closer together so their chests are touching. Adora's eyes flare as Catra finally manages to turn the handle behind them, still smirking up at her as the door swings open behind them.

"Gladly."

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Catra is on her the moment the door has closed behind them. She barely gives Adora time to set down the sword and turn the lock before she kisses Adora almost the exact same way she did when she pounced on her downstairs, hungry and desperate, but this time Adora is ready for her, wrapping her arms around her waist and kissing back with just as much passion. It's hot and needy, but far better than a desperate press of lips in the heat of the moment while Adora's brain chugged a few steps behind. This is a kiss that leads to *more*.

Catra doesnt hesitate to grab her hips and pull her back into the room. Adora stumbles a little and they end up bumping into the bathroom wall, Catra sighing softly as her back hits it. Adora expects her to correct and start dragging them to the bed again, but instead she sets to pulling Adora as tightly against her as she can, still kissing her hungrily. Adora groans softly at the sensation of Catra wanting her so desperately, but she's a little more together than she

was down in the hallway and she is aware now that being pressed together like this is a bad idea.

"Costumes, Catra," Adora reminds, having to straighten up to pull out of the kiss because Catra *bites* her when she tries to simply pull back. Catra lets out a low growl, ducking down and nipping her neck instead. Adora immediately gasps, pressing closer despite the rational voice in her ear that says the pauldron and fangs on Clawdeen's costume are going to get damaged – if they didn't already. Adora wasn't exactly paying attention to what Catra was wearing earlier.

Catra's lips on her neck, growl reverberating through her fangs and into Adora, has Adora's hips shifting forward, her knee pressing between Catra's legs without her even thinking about it, she just needs her. Catra seems pleased with that, though, because the growl shifts into a purr as Catra kisses at the side of her neck, experimenting with a few different ones that all thoroughly ruin Adora's attempt at getting her mental processes online. The kiss with a scrape of teeth at the end especially undoes her, Adora releasing a whine. She's breathing heavily and flustered, unsure how they're even going to *get* to sex if Catra just kissing her feels this way.

"We're going to damage something," Adora manages to add, but her voice sounds pathetic even to her own ears with how she pants as Catra latches onto the side of her neck and sucks. It hurts, but Adora's kind of into that if she's honest, and the mere thought of Catra giving her a hickey has her rocking her knee forward – partially to give as good as she's getting, and partially because it lets her shift Catra's leg further between her own. She's *there* already, as desperate as Catra was in the hallway downstairs. Now this is happening, she wants it to happen *now* – to have her hands all over Catra, and to feel her claws dig into her back, and to finally hear what she sounds like when she comes.

"We need to be naked," Adora tries instead. *Slow* Catra stills, and then releases her neck, finally pulling back to meet Adora's eyes. Adora knows she must look like a horny idiot, but Catra's eyes are

blown out and her face is pink, so she isn't much better. Her lips are pink and Adora wants to kiss her so bad, to *devour* her, but instead she runs her hands down her sides to hook her thumbs into the edge of Catra's skirt. Catra's tail immediately lashes to the side, ears quivering.

"We, uh, can put on other clothes if you want, but we need to change at least," Adora says, hopeful but far from confident.

"You're an idiot," Catra says, and then she's stepping forward, forcing Adora to take a step back as Catra advances far enough to push off the wall and push *her*, giving herself enough room to reach up and undo the anchor strap under her arm for the pauldron. Adora knows she is about to be confronted with Catra's tits about two seconds before she actually pulls her top off. She flushes, trying to only look at Catra's face and failing the moment Catra's top crosses over it.

She used to be jealous of Catra's chest when she was still trying to deny her desire for her and make it just about body envy. Sure, Catra did get off easy with her smaller chest, but there's honestly not that big of a difference between them—not big enough to justify the thoughts Adora had about her or the glances she stole. Part of her wants to reach up and finally touch her, but the rest of her says there's an order of operations to these things and they should get undressed before they touch each other again or this is going to *devolve* and costumes are going to get ripped anyway.

Adora licks her lips as Catra drapes the top over her arm and sends her a smirk. She sees her shift her weight, probably preparing to walk closer, but Adora takes a step back first. She takes a deep breath and then bends to remove her shoes. Her outfit is a one piece. She can't just take the top off like Catra can. In her periphery, she sees Catra's tail lashing as she sets both her shoes aside and straightens again, making eye contact to check in before she moves further.

Catra's eyes are on her, dark and hungry. She definitely doesnt want her to stop. Despite the kisses downstairs, and in the entry, and the *onti on* in the elevator – as brief and surface level it was – it' s only now finally sinking in for Adora that this is finally happening. She has no idea what to do – *how* to do this – but she is finally going to have Catra beneath her hands and that's worth any potential fumbling or awkwardness.

She sets to stripping with total efficiency.

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Catra purrs as Adora's hands land on her hips and guide her to fall back into the bed, Adora climbing over her and settling to rest over her hips. Her eyes sweep over Catra and Catra returns the appreciative look, reaching up and palming Adora's abs because her tits are a little too far back with her leaned back like this. She will get to them, though. She has *pas* , and now they're both down to just their underwear, she can finally fulfill them. Adora is fucking gorgeous, but that's nothing new – being able to touch her *i s* and she takes pleasure in running both her hands over her sides until she settles to grab her hips and pulls her closer, pressing Adora down against her. It gets her a delicious hitch of breath, the exact kind of thing she has dreamed of hearing from Adora.

She looks up to make eye contact and freezes when she sees the blatant awe in Adora's gaze as it flicks between her body , her face, and Catra's hands on her own hips. Catra's tail is partially trapped beneath her leg and their combined weight from how they're sitting, but the end still lashes to the side as she does her best to throw Adora a smug smirk as if joy isnt flooding her chest. That' s a look she has *n* from Adora, and though it isnt the first time she has ever seen it, usually it was related to her pulling off a build or something. It's never been directed at her mere existence.

"Fuck, it's *you*," Adora says, nonsensically, as she reaches up to grab Catra's face the same way she did when they kissed for the first time in her workshop. When she sweeps in to kiss her, however, it's nothing like that first one, open mouthed and hungry. The closest it comes is how purposeful it is, leaving Catra's breath shaking as she kisses back, wrapping her arms around Adora's back to keep her from sitting up and pulling away again. Adora's words dont actually make sense, but Catra still understands the sentiment. She feels the same way: it's Adora, above her and wanting her, the one person she always *hated* to love her.

She kisses Adora back with just as much desire, nipping at her lower lip when they part enough for air and not even bothering to hide her play growl, fueled by pure pleasure, when Adora shivers slightly and gasps in response. In just their underwear, bodies together, Catra can easily smell how turned on Adora is and they technically haven't *done* anything yet. Adora seems to be having a similar thought, though, because she slips a hand around to the back of Catra's head, giving her proper leverage to hold her close with just one hand and leaving the other open to run down her body.

Catra's back arches as Adora cups her chest and squeezes, but after a light squeeze, Adora keeps moving. Catra huffs and nips *hard* at Adora's lower lip, tugging on it in the same slow, purposeful way she did during the photoshoot even though she knows that it is far from a punishment. Adora groans, her hand behind Catra's head dropping now so she can run both hands hungrily down her body. Catra gasps, arching up into the touch and shivering a little as Adora shifts back, dropping her hands to her thighs and encouraging them to part.

Shifting back breaks the kiss, but it's worth it for when Adora's knee slips between her own, letting Catra settle down snugly on it. It's not enough to be more than indistinct pressure, but it helps settle some of the breathless desperation in her. It *is* enough for her to appreciate it when Adora leans forward over her, coming in to kiss her again, and Catra gets to watch her tits sway before she *feels*

them press against her. When their lips meet, Adora is the one kissing hungrily now while Catra lets out a gentle sigh, satisfaction quivering through her.

She rolls her hips, shifting and giving herself a bit more stimulation, as Adora returns to running her hands over her. She can touch Catra anywhere she likes—or even *not* touch her—as long as she keeps kissing her like this. Catra whines when Adora's hands find their way back to her chest, Adora rubbing a thumb experimentally against her nipple. It feels good to have her hands on her, but the touch itself kind of hurts, tugging on her a bit painfully. Catra reaches up, covering Adora's hand with her own and directing it down to cup her breast largely from below.

"Too sensitive. Just play with them," Catra mumbles into the kiss, somehow too embarrassed to say the word *nipple* despite the fact she's grinding on Adora's thigh. Adora holds absolutely still while she talks as if any shift is going to make her miss Catra's words. When Catra tries to kiss her again, Adora responds, but she moves slower, lagging behind like she did down in the hallway. Catra tries to arch her back, pushing herself up into Adora's hands to assure she does still *want* to be touched—fuck, does she want—but after a moment Adora pulls back, dropping a hand to the mattress to brace herself in a half-sitting position.

"*Adora*," Catra whines, fucking *embarrassingly*, as she tries to wrap her arms around Adora's shoulders and pull her back in. The calculating look in Adora's eyes fades, at least a bit, when her lips part and she releases a soft *oh* that has Catra's ears straining forward. She can't pretend that she isn't hanging onto every slight noise from Adora, but at least how flushed she already is from being turned on is probably covering any possible flush from embarrassment. Slowly, Adora's lips curve into a subtle smirk.

"Show me how you like it," Adora requests, voice breathless and sincere in a way that somehow makes Catra feel more flustered and self-conscious—in a way she *likes*, fuck her—than anything else that has come before. Catra drops her hands from reaching up for

Adora, instead fisting one in the hotel duvet and hesitantly lifting the other to the side of her chest not covered by Adora's hand. She bites her lip, feeling her ears twitch as she cups herself and massages against her tit.

Adora watches, her eyes bright and focused as if she is studying, for a few moments before she mirrors the movement on Catra's other side. It feels *ridiculous* and the moment that Adora starts touching her, Catra kind of wants to drop her hand and bury it in Adora's hair instead, fisting it and pulling her in closer, but instead she forces her eyes to flutter shut so she stops watching Adora's reaction and hopefully stops feeling so damn self-conscious.

"My nipples are just really sensitive in a not-fun way. Sometimes I-" she pauses, flicking a claw carefully over the tip of her nipple, "but just touch the rest of my chest and I'll be fine. Or feel me up like you did during the photoshoot. I really liked that," Catra admits, because if she has to suffer through more hesitance before Adora finally *touches* touches her, she might just die. She feels Adora shift, and then a second hand is brushing against her own. Catra *really* likes Adora's tits and has wanted to get her hands on them for awhile, so she's trying to let Adora have this in case it's mutual, but-

"I'd really prefer if you *touch* me, though," she adds, trying for confidence as she opens her eyes and sends Adora the best attempt she can make at a smirk right now. Adora's gaze jerks up from where it was focused on her chest, her flush somehow darker than it was before as she sends Catra a smile that is *definitely* excited. Her hands obligingly run down Catra's body, taking her hips and *fisting* them. Catra groans, her eyes fluttering shut, as she rolls her hips up into the added pressure and manages to hit her clit just right on Adora's thigh. She gasps, her eyes flying open and fixing unseeingly on the ceiling as she squirms and tries to get that same stimulation again, but it's fleeting and difficult on such a broad surface.

“*Ad* , fuck me or pull my tail or something already,”Catra huf fs, frustrated. She glares up at Adora, but she knows how ineffective that must be with how flustered she is, her fur sticking up in a few places from Adora’s roaming hands. Adora grins down at her, a mix of cockiness and affection in her eyes as she shifts back, taking away Catra’s sad excuse for stimulation but dropping her hands to her underwear.

“Y ou sure?, uh, really like my tits being played with and can take a lot more than that. I dont want to do it wrong and, like, hurt you,” Adora says even as she hooks her fingers over the waistband. She doesnt move further , though, looking down at Catra with that damn earnestness that made Catra fall in love with her in the first place. Catra’s tail lashes as she arches her hips enough for Adora to easily slide her underwear off of her.

“I ve been thinking about your fingers in me for years, princess. Im sure,”Catra tells her . Adora’s eyes immediately darken. She doesnt hesitate to slide her underwear down.

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Catra drops her own hand between her legs and shows Adora how she likes to be touched, which turns out to be way harder to emulate with Adora settled between her legs, but when Adora slides her fingers between her folds all that gets abandoned as Catra bucks up and tries to get Adora’s fingers exactly where she wants them.

“Just fuck me and Ill handle the rest,”Catra gasps out, and that Adora can *d* , inexperience aside. Pressing her fingers into Catra – sliding them in, because Catra takes her first and then her second finger with ease –is a delicious feeling. Catra’ s soaking as Adora presses in and is met with nothing but giving heat. She slowly sets to thrusting, and then when Catra’s tail lashes and she hisses through

her teeth, she moves faster until Catra's panting little *b*a s with every stroke. Catra's hand between her legs never stops moving over her clit, and Adora's ga*z*e is caught between carefully watching the movements and watching Catra's face as she flutters her eyes shut, tilts her head back, and *l o*s herself.

When she pants out, "*A*da ,"like a moan and a prayer , Adora forgets all thoughts of pacing herself and making sure not to hurt Catra again in favor of a *ne*d to hear her say that again. Fucking her desperately doesnt seem to be a problem, though. Catra starts to sq irm beneath the touch, rolling her hips and whining as she fumbles her hand on herself, almost dislodging in the desperate movement. She looks utterly *l o*s as a combination of both their hands brings her over. Feeling Catra clench around her and then cry out, the sound soft but *b*a ti f*u*l in how lost it is, has Adora forgetting how to breathe, holding it all in so she doesnt miss a *s*nd of Catra's whimpers.

She holds her fingers deep inside Catra, afraid of thrusting as she finishes and comes down, but that insistent press inside her seems to be enough. H*e*r walls roll down on Adora in waves, Catra' s entire body twitching with the contractions as she pants heavily, her own hand finally still and falling away to land somewhere on the bed. Adora slowly eases her fingers out as Catra finally flutters her eyes open again. She's still panting – she' s still *tw*t*i*ng even as Adora's hand falls away – and her ga*z*e is blissed out as she stares at nothing.

She looks fucked out and utterly relaxed. Adora forces herself to shift up from kneeling between her thighs. The scent of Catra's desire is filling the room and if Adora stays there any longer she doesnt know how she's going to hold off from ducking down and tasting her. H*e*r mouth is watering right now, but when she hasnt even really touched her clit yet isnt the time to dive headfirst into a kind of sex she has a feeling is way more complicated. She at least knows how to touch *h*s*e*f and could transfer the knowledge to Catra if they werent both too worked up for Adora to take the time to master it.

Catra asked to be fucked anyway. Adora isn't great at doing both at once, though for Catra she plans to *learn*. She shifts up, laying out beside Catra and carefully sliding one arm under her, pulling Catra into her arms. Catra rolls into her easily, happily tucking beneath her chin and informing Adora she was *purring* so quietly she couldn't hear it, but she can *feel* it now. What the fuck, that's so cute Adora kind of wants to scream.

She scatters kisses over the top of Catra's head instead, and then shifts to focusing on her ears when she brushes against them and realizes how soft the fur is against her lips. Okay, she really likes Catra fucked out and purring for her, but number two on her list of new Catra discoveries is ear kisses, because they feel amazing and with each one she only wants to kiss her *more*. She isn't sure how she is ever supposed to stop, really, but Catra pulling away forces her hand. Adora very maturely whines about it.

Catra's eyes are sparkling as she drops her head onto the pillow beside her and gazes into her eyes. Her pupils are completely blown out, and her purr has grown so that every breath – still heavy from her orgasm – rumbles in the air. Their bodies are still pressed together even if their faces are far enough apart to look at each other and Adora can feel the rumble running into her, sending a shiver through her alongside it. She's absolutely soaked but she kind of doesn't care how tightly her underwear is clinging to her, not when she has Catra like *this* in her arms and getting off would mean moving.

"You're fucking beautiful. I want to see you like this every day for the rest of my life," Adora says, because she has never done anything by half measures and she feels like she is exploding right now. Catra trills, her eyes widening and her ears pinning back. She immediately turns to bury her face in the pillow, only one golden eye peeking out at Adora over it. Adora grins. That's so *cute* and she just made Catra do that. She tightens her arms around Catra, shuffling a little closer together. Her ideal would be somehow morphing their bodies into

one right now, but failing at that, she wants to cradle Catra as tightly as she can.

"Is that okay? Because I really , really mean it," Adora asks, even though she's fairly certain *okay* is underselling it from how red Catra's cheeks are getting. Her tail lashes over the sheets as she shifts, wrapping her arms and then legs around Adora, latching onto her tightly without ever breaking eye contact.

"Yeah, *idiot*," Catra huffs, but her voice is syrupy with pleasure and affection – not to mention the purr that is *still going* – so her attempt at distance doesn't do much to fool Adora. Adora grins, shifting closer and pressing a kiss to the sliver of cheek visible.

"Perfect, 'cause I've kind of been in love with you for a long time and I would love to get to do something about it," Adora continues, because she's so fucking happy she can't stop herself. Catra gasping, hitching her purr before it returns even louder, is all the encouragement that she needs. Her blood is thrumming right now , happiness and excitement and pleasure and raw desire all making her throw her caution to the wind, but Catra already kind of vaguely agreed to maybe date out in the elevator and after *that* of doing so, she can't keep holding it back anymore.

"I- Really?" Catra asks, her voice so thin and hopeful it makes Adora want to scream in a less positive way than her purring did. Adora tightens her arms around her, hugging her tightly.

"Since high school, at least. It kind of took me awhile to realize, I'm not really sure when it started," Adora finally admits. The way Catra's breathing hitches doesn't seem *bad* even if it is clearly emotional.

"Middle school at least, for me. It just feels like it was always. That's why the leaving stuff went so bad. I was kind of thinking of us as life partners already and it...shattered that," Catra replies, starting breathless and ending in a mumble. Adora swallows, her arms loosening a little around Catra. She meant to give her room, but clearly Catra doesn't want that, because she squeezes her even

tighter. "It wasn't fair to either of us, *don't go*," Catra rushes out, barely separate words. Adora freezes. Catra draws in a deep breath.

"We've talked about it. We can talk about it more later if you want to, but right now I just want to be happy you love me back and all those times I thought we almost kissed were real," Catra adds, still breathy but speaking at a mostly normal pace now. Adora swallows, but she nods. She wants to let that small spike of anxiety go, and with Catra clinging to her, it isn't hard to. There probably are more words left to say about that they'll need to drudge up another time, especially now they can hopefully be completely honest with each other about how they felt, but for now Adora agrees that she just wants to focus on this.

"I love you," she says. The words make her heart flutter. All of Catra's limbs tighten around her.

"I love you too," she breathes back.

It sounds like happiness.

Chapter End Notes

> Writing a line even remotely positive about algorithm-based social media physically hurt me but these are sacrifices I make to write gay shit.
> Twice as much was supposed to happen in this chapter in half the word count but holy SHIT did this all take more words than I budgeted for (which, like, I don't think y'all will complain about when you get smut out of it) so this is where we're at. Yeah there's a reason it's taken me a bit to do this and the previous update. And there's more ahead, because this fic has gotten stupid long. It was supposed to be 20k (⊙ ʖ⊙)

Adora x Catra

Chapter Summary

Clawdeen discovers all she is to who she loves.

Chapter Notes

It's very possible I have to up the chapter count still, but well see.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora seems very intent on cuddling Catra, which she has no protests about as she luxuriates in the post-orgasm contentment, but she can't simply sink into hormone-fueled bliss like she normally would, not with the scent of Adora's desire lacing the air. It's a heady taste on her tongue, Catra unable to ignore how turned on Adora is as she nuzzles into her neck and rubs her cheek there. Her own scent marks can do nothing to cover how Adora smells. The way it makes her mouth water keeps her from moving on from sex and fully into the afterglow.

Adora doesn't put up any protests when Catra starts roaming her hands over her, still pressed tightly together but moved on from clutching to *feeling*. Adora has gotten to touch Catra's body more than Catra has hers, between "platonic" petting over the years and things like the photoshoot more recently. Catra has definitely done more groping with intent, but usually it has been things like palming her abs in moments where she thought she could get away with it and "pokingly" swatting her ass with her tail. It feels freeing to roam her hands over Adora, following the lines of her muscles and finally sinking her fingers, *claws*, into her ass as she squeezes it.

"That took you at least two minutes longer than I thought it would with all your comments," Adora says, her tone dry and teasing. As she says it, she kisses the base of Catra's ear, the kiss feeling far

too sweet compared to what Catra is doing. Catra growls, short and mostly playful, but also a little flustered, before she lets go and swats Adora's ass with her *hand* this time. It isn't hard enough to be a spank – though Catra thinks the next hotel room might be able hear it if anyone is home – but it's satisfying to feel beneath her hand. The small gasp Adora lets out in response and the slight stutter of her hips lights a fire in Catra's heart – or maybe somewhere further south.

"I spend at least twice as much time thinking about your tits, you just flaunt them less," Catra corrects, and to prove her point, she wriggles down and nips the top of Adora's breast. Adora releases a noise, maybe a squeak or just a very high-pitched moan, that reminds Catra what Adora said back when she was playing with Catra's tits. She latches on and sets to marking a hickey. She isn't quite sure what to do except bite and suck, but both feel good to do so she goes with it. She's just high enough on her chest that it *might* be visible in her She-ra outfit, though Catra doubts it. That possibility excites her though, as does the needy gasp Adora lets out, expanding her chest and pressing it up into her – or maybe that's just the way she arches her back.

"Catra," Adora whines, voice rough. Catra wants to see her right now – from her voice, she knows she is dazed and turned on and *beautiful* – but her eyes have fluttered closed from satisfaction and they aren't opening again while she has her mouth on Adora. She's just so plush and satisfying to sink her teeth into, even while holding back to not hurt her too much. Adora isn't acting like it hurts, but Catra knows how sharp her fangs are even if Adora says she can take it. Speaking of taking it though…

Catra releases her, pressing a soft kiss against the spot before she presses a much filthier one just a little further down, kissing her way to her nipple so she can carefully take it in her mouth. Adora gasps when she first does it, but to her surprise she *giggles* when Catra flicks her tongue over her. She pins her ears back, feeling a dark spark in her that says *she'd do anything* she *wasn't* asked to. She

didnt expect that to feel bad – she has no idea what she' s doing, it's to be *fair* she doesnt immediately make Adora moan every time – but Adora had her clutching the sheets earlier and she just wants to do the same for her, *to* her.

Adora's hand threads into her hair, thumb rubbing against the base of her ear. She hums lightly, turning to something closer to a rumble or a moan when Catra tries again firmer, laving her tongue over her. Adora shifts a little, huffing out a breathy sound that might be pleasure, or might just be a laugh again. She twists her fingers in Catra's hair and Catra groans softly, her ears pricking back up on instinct. The noise Adora releases this time is *definitely* pleasure.

"You're adorable, and that tickles," Adora says, her voice fluffy and sparkling with laughter. It's *beautiful* and if Catra wasnt eager to make her come apart as a person, she would love that, but instead she releases her, defeated, and slits her eyes open just enough to confirm a bruise is starting to form where she bit earlier before she does it again, just to the side and a littler harder than before. Adora gasps out, her body jolting a little as if to get closer , or maybe pull away. Catra doubts Adora herself is sure.

"D-didnt say that was bad. *Ah*," Adora whines at the end, heady and desperate. Adora usually hates being tickled, complaining and demanding recourse even as she laughs until she's breathless and crying. Catra isnt sure she quite believes her , at least not until Adora tugs with her hand in her hair and guides Catra lower down again. Catra isnt going to say *no*, so she latches on and laves her tongue over her nipple again. Adora lets out another high, huffing giggle, a tinge of a moan on the end.

Maybe that sound doesnt mean she fucked up. Maybe it' s the prettiest thing Catra's ever heard.

"Sorry , I dont-" Adora sucks in a breath, because like always, even just giggling makes her a little breathless, "-know why that makes me laugh. I havent exactly been able to try it before," Adora explains. She doesnt sound confused, not with a tinge of moan in her words,

but the shard of disappointment that was in Catra's chest has faded now. *Adora* isn't disappointed, so that's good enough. She tries something different, pressing the tip of her tongue against her nipple rather than the flat of it. She gets that huffy moan again, a sound she's *really* coming around too.

She decides she has enough confidence to explore more now, small crisis over Adora's tits aside. She just likes them a *lot* and would like it if Adora enjoys *her* enjoying them too. Adora was all moans and groans earlier, but apparently that's not all the noises she can make and really that's beautiful, now Catra has a better idea of how to interpret it. She places a hand on Adora's hip, running it up her side and squeezing at her waist.

If Catra is honest, there isn't a part of Adora she hasn't fantasized about. Touching Adora's waist felt especially obvious, *probably*, so she has thought about holding her there as she pressed a thigh between her own, digging her claws in to hold her firmly as she pulled her down onto it and earned moans. That's actually a *fantastic* idea, so she shifts her legs – which were kind of still wrapped around Adora – and holds Adora in place as she tangles their legs together. She releases her chest as Adora hitches a leg over her hip, apparently all too happy to press their bodies together.

Catra nuzzles into Adora's tits, marking them but also just enjoying how pillowy they are, as she presses her thigh up in between Adora's own. It's really a damn shame Adora is still wearing underwear, but it doesn't make much of a difference when she's soaking through it. Catra groans at the same time Adora does, nipping her again because her instincts say to latch on and fuck her senseless, but she doesn't know how Adora likes it – *if* she likes it, but Catra has a pretty damn good guess that she does – and she's got a lot of Adora she'd like to touch.

"Tell me-" she slides her hands down over Adora's hips, hooking her fingers into the waistband of Adora's underwear and tugging to the side, but not *down*, "I can take these off," she asks, her voice rough. Adora's breath hitches, tits swelling forward into Catra's face. She

happily buries her face down into them again, ears pinning back out of the way.

"Yes, Catra, fuck, you can do just about anything at this point," Adora says, not at all what Catra was expecting despite how thick the scent of Adora's desire is in the air. Her tail immediately lashes, her arm tugging on Adora's underwear just on instinct because she wants to grab, pull, hold down and close. She pulls on Adora's underwear and somehow the scent of her desire grows stronger as she pulls it away. She sits up in order to tug the garment down, Adora reluctantly unhooking her leg from Catra so she can pull it all the way off.

She turns back to Adora to find her laying half on her side, half on her back, flushed from her ears to her tits with a shy smile on her face and her legs pressed together. Either she's trying to get a little stimulation, or she's embarrassed. She looks gorgeous either way. Catra throws her the same predatory smirk she has been giving her all weekend as she reaches out, taking her thigh in her hand, and pulling it aside so she can get a look at her. Adora shifts with it, rolling properly onto her back and tilting her hips self conscious from the adorably flustered look on her face.

It's probably because she's soaked down her thighs, even the thatch of dark curls between her legs glistening from how she has shifted her thighs together. Catra immediately doesn't care about her inexperience, or insecurity, or whatever, she just needs to touch her. She shifts, pulling Adora's legs further apart as she lays back down next to her, draping against her side. As much as she wants to watch, Adora seemed to fumble a bit adjusting to doing this from a different angle, and she'd rather feel Adora's deep breathes and moans than watch her fingers slide over her – this time, at least.

"How do you like it? Rough?" Catra asks as she rubs their cheeks together. She half expects Adora to giggle again, but instead her breath hitches and she lets out the tiniest, *ti ni ti* little grunt of a moan, rubbing her cheek back. Or maybe nodding. Catra traces her fingers up her inner thigh, dragging through the spread slick.

"Yeah. Um, at least compared to what you were doing at first. When you got all fevered – which was really fucking hot, by the way – that's how I like it," Adora says, tone a little embarrassed but mostly anticipatory. Catra scrapes her teeth along the edge of her jaw as she finally traces her fingers through her folds. "Oh," Adora breathes, soft and *beautiful* as Catra feels her, spreads her, rubs her fingers against her entrance and then drags them up to her clit.

"You like to be fucked?" Catra teases, because she wants to know and because Adora's hips stuttered slightly as she pressed against her, as if desperate to press down onto her fingers. Given the way she smells and the gentle trembling of every breath, Catra thinks she would take her easily. Adora keens quietly, properly rutting herself up against Catra now to get stimulation. She *told* Catra how she likes it, but it feels like a luxury, an *epiphany* to be touching Adora lazily – it's the furthest thing from lazy or casual, but it's gentle and not yet fevered – and she feels like she should build up to that at least a little, regardless of Adora's promises.

"*Yes*, I just- I don't need it this time. I need to get off," Adora says, whines, pleads, flexing her hips again. Catra presses back, rubbing in slow, purposeful circles, but she is at least pressing down hard enough now – she thinks. Adora doesn't stop straining up like she isn't, but she starts whimpering beautifully, so Catra must be doing something right. She is absolutely keeping that in mind for later – maybe not today, but *later* – but for now she presses a gentle kiss to Adora's jaw and purrs when that seems to instantly quiet her, her hips stilling as Catra keeps touching her.

It's *nothing* nothing but affection – affection from her – and it's enough. Adora turns her head, nudging her nose against Catra's cheek.

"Kiss? And faster," she requests, breathless. Catra could never deny her and doesn't want to anyway. She doesn't know why Adora even asked when she could have easily kissed her herself, but it's kind of really hot that she did, so she kisses her and picks up the pace of her hand, ramping up as Adora whimpers against her mouth. The

kiss starts fairly sweet, but the faster, *hard* Catra works her hand, the filthier it becomes.

She loves it. She loves the moans and gentle groans Adora pants into the kiss as she twitches occasionally but mostly holds still, because when she *does* twitch, she's wet enough that Catra's hand slides off her and that makes her whine. Catra cant deny she *loves* Adora's twitches though, the way nothing seems to be enough for her like she needs everything Catra could possibly give. Catra bites and tugs on her bottom lip and Adora groans loudly, arching her back off the mattress but managing to mostly keep her hips still.

"Catra," Adora moans, voice thick with desperation. Catra growls, biting and tugging again. It makes Adora gasp, her chest expanding and body lifting again. Catra can feel every twitch, hear her heart hammering and the moans she's *pretty* sure Adora is trying to keep down but are louder than Catra usually is when she's home alone. Energy coils beneath her skin, the only thing that can possibly meet it how Adora gasps her name, which she does *again*, making Catra shiver and growl as she presses down harder, rougher than she ever is with herself, but it makes Adora *pout*, and any hope of them kissing is gone as Adora pants soundlessly and tenses up.

Her muscles quake as her orgasm comes over her, and Catra decides to do for her what Adora did when she was fucking her and hold still, giving Adora the pressure but not overworking her as Adora twitches, arches, whines, and *collapses*, falling back against the sheets panting. Catra finally pulls her head back enough to get a look at her as Adora twitches so hard down on nothing that Catra feels the shift even with her hand up by her clit. Adora is flushed, her skin glistening and her face utterly slack despite the slight shiver working through her. Her eyes are closed, eyelids fluttering slightly. She's so beautiful, so *pretty*, her lips parted as she pants in the come down.

The room reeks of hormones and sex. It's delicious. Catra could go again easily, but she doesnt want Adora to move again, not when she looks like *this* when she is fucked out. She drops her head to the

pillow, wiping her hand on the sheets absently before she curls around Adora, holding her close and nuzzling into her. Okay, she's turned on again and would love to lazily ride Adora's fingers right now, but she's also more than happy to wrap around her and go to sleep, both of them fucked out, happy, and *hanging*.

"You're beautiful," Catra mumbles, kissing Adora's neck when her lips brush against it because she can. Adora lets out a soft, pleased sound that Catra has only heard before when she was half asleep.

"You're amazing," Adora replies, indistinct but still enough to make Catra rumble softly as she kisses her again. "Wanna stay like this. That okay?" Adora adds, still sex content as she shifts to hug Catra back, wrapping back around her. Catra purrs again, louder this time. She has to shift a little to allow Adora to hug her back without Catra letting go either, but after a moment they're wrapped together, arms around each other and legs tangled together, Catra's face nuzzled against the side of Adora's face and her neck.

"I might want to stay in bed with you forever," Catra replies. It's more than okay. She knows, logically, they're going to have to return to the con at some point, though that doesn't *have* to be today. Adora's hunger is going to be a more pressing issue, because it's a gnawing void on its own and Catra can only imagine it gets worse with something like sex to fuel it. She's still turned on, but she's settling down now, and she just wants to be close against Adora. As much as she has lusted for Adora over the years, wanting her doesn't just mean wanting her like *that*.

It also means like this, Adora's breath settling slowly as she holds Catra close, both of them naked and every inch of their bodies pressed together. Catra has wanted this her entire life and part of her is waiting for it to all be some practical joke now the afterglow is settling, but Adora just releases a happy hum, nuzzles her cheek, and then kisses it before going limp again. Doubts like this are why they stopped talking for three years, but they don't catch hold – they *can't* – with Adora's arms wrapped around her.

She knows what having Adora is like now. She's going to make damn sure she doesnt lose her again, even if it means fighting herself. Her insecurities are strong, but she's stronger.

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Eventually, Catra decides she's uncomfortable and needs to go to the bathroom. Adora reluctantly gets up when she does, grabbing the t-shirt she wore to lunch and tugging it on. She grabs fresh underwear, but she doesnt put it on yet, planning to follow Catra in the bathroom once she finishes. When Catra walks out, she makes a show of pouting and reaching up, framing Adora's chest with her hands and squeezing her tits together as Adora flushes.

"Do you have to cover them up?" Catra says, like she's actually upset and it's a reasonable request. The pout is exaggerated and there's a sparkle in her eyes, but Adora would be flustered even without the hands on her chest, Catra squeezing a little more as she presses in close so she can drape her naked body against Adora.

"I- Well, I mean, I guess not? I dont, um, usually hang out naked though," Adora says, flustered and fumbling. Catra snorts, but it ends with a purr as she sneaks her hands beneath Adora's shirt and runs them up her sides to play with her chest directly. With them standing so close together, she can really only squeeze at the sides, but that is what she was doing before anyway.

"You're cute. And an idiot. Im just teasing," Catra stretches up to kiss Adora's cheek, her hands finally falling away, "Not that I would complain if you did change your mind," she finishes with a wink, stepping aside so Adora can finally head into the bathroom. Adora's cheeks are red. She ducks her head, stealing one last look at Catra's smile, amused and satiated, as she finally steps into the bathroom. If

she thought Catra was going to be the death of her before, now Catra has permission to *touch* her, she might be a little ruined.

She does briefly consider complying with Catra's request as she uses the bathroom and washes her hands, but in the end she decides it sends the wrong message. Sex was great – sex was *fantastic* – but she doesn't really want to go again right now. She'd rather hold Catra, and kiss all over her face, and talk while she pets her soft sides. Okay, so she might have a bit of a double standard, because that would be a lot easier if Catra was shirtless, but she would also be very easily distracted by her tits, so it would be for the best if she gets dressed too.

When Adora wanders out of the bathroom, not decent but at least covered by her underwear and shirt, Catra is similarly dressed. She's wearing a tank top for her part, and though she's stretched out on her back, from what Adora can see the cut of her underwear is at best – worst? – cheeky, but possibly all the way to *thong*. She was wearing a thong when they first undressed, but things were going a little bit too quickly for it to matter then.

It *didn't* matter now, Adora's face warm as she approaches the bed and sends Catra a hopeful smile. Catra raises her arms, a blatant request for Adora to come cuddle that she isn't about to pass up. She climbs into bed, noting the small pile of electronics Catra has managed to gather beside her while Adora was in the bathroom. Both their phones, Catra's laptop, and the TV remote are piled together, off to the side. It probably means Catra intends for them to stay in bed for a while. Adora definitely doesn't have any problems with that, at least not until dinner rolls around.

"You're gorgeous," Adora tells her, honestly, because she *is* and she *is*, as she drapes over her side and wraps her arms around her. Catra purrs, turning her face and rubbing her cheek against her. Adora can't begin to guess how many scent marks Catra has left on her over the last hour. The thought makes her breathing just a little heavier, her arms tightening around her. She turns to kiss Catra's

cheek, nuzzling against the spot where she thinks her scent glands are, roughly. Catra purrs louder, the sound throaty.

"Not bad yourself, princess," Catra returns. Despite her casual words, her voice is thick with affection and buzzing a little from her purr. Adora grins. She knows she's hot – her Instagram comments tell her that much – but it's something else to have Catra compliment her, even with how clear she has been about her thoughts on Adora's body. For a long time Adora was worried attraction was all there was between them, every flirtation a double-edged sword that felt good but could be *mean* .

"We're dating now, right? Like, we're girlfriends?" Adora asks, because she has to, even with the *I love you* s exchanged earlier. They've lived in uncertainty for too long. She wants to be able to kiss, and cuddle, and fuck Catra without fear of going too far or being too much. Catra snickers, turning to kiss Adora's cheek now, but Adora is already facing her, so after a moment of bumping noses Catra decides to kiss her softly instead.

"Yeah, dummy. We're girlfriends," Catra promises when they part, her voice impossibly soft and fond even as she says the "insult." Adora grins, nuzzling her cheek again while she dims her smile so she can kiss Catra again.

Girlfriend . It really ended up being a romantic weekend getaway, but she isn't about to apologize to Scorpia.

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They don't go back to the con. Catra didn't really want to. Part of her is kind of excited to put the costume back on and dance around Adora with no limits – with Adora allowed to *touch* her – but there's something that feels profound about laying around half-dressed

together, messing around on their phones and watching TV when they aren't just making out. She likes being able to turn her head and kiss Adora – she's been dreaming about it for a *long* time – and they wouldn't be lazily making out if they were out in some random hallway, or worse, a panel.

Catra reluctantly pulls away from the cuddle – by which she means she rolls off Adora and just lays next to her instead of on top of her – to send emails when Scorpia texts her with an update on their commission. She also has things she has to answer and check-in on, so she spends a few minutes stretched out next to Adora on her stomach, typing away as her tail flicks behind her. She's on her stomach partially because her tail has been stifled a lot today from sitting and laying down – usually she spends all day on her feet – and partially because she knows it's killing Adora to see her in a thong.

Catra doesn't really like underwear. She finds thongs more comfortable, more often than not, but she hadn't realized that until she was in her twenties – it wasn't like she was about to get one back when they lived at fucking Weaver's – so Adora has never seen her in one before. She has her phone in her hands as she *tries* to focus on Instagram, but Catra can see her eyes frequently wandering in her periphery. She likes Adora's eyes on her. Her tail is swaying with slow satisfaction, which only seems to be drawing Adora's attention to her ass more. She's stealing looks that are familiar to Catra. She's worn this expression several times over the years, but especially in the past few weeks, and this weekend.

"So," Catra says, watching Adora immediately jerk her eyes back up to her face. "Clawdeen," she prompts. Adora pauses, blinking at her for a moment.

"Yeah?" Adora asks, throwing Catra a somewhat dazed smile. Catra rolls her eyes, putting her phone to sleep and turning to face Adora, pillowing her cheek on her arm. Adora's expression doesn't look caught yet, so she can guess that she hasn't figured out what Catra's getting at yet.

"You've fantasized about me as her before, haven't you?" Adora's eyes immediately go wide, her face darkening. Yeah, Catra was onto her from pretty much the moment she asked her to do the ship photoshoot, but Adora's expression is all the confirmation she needs. This whole cosplay was straight out of her wet dreams. Adora quickly looks away, embarrassment radiating off her. Catra throws her a smug grin. She *knows*. Adora can see it out of the corner of her eyes because her flush gets worse.

"Yeah," Adora admits, finally looking back to throw her a sheepish smile, fidgeting a little with her phone. Catra is sure that Adora would be a lot more uneasy if she weren't smiling at her, but right now she just looks embarrassed and a little unsure. Catra leans in, getting close to her face and watching Adora nearly cross her eyes in an attempt to maintain eye contact.

"You want to fuck with the costumes on," she purrs, tone sing-songy. Being right in Adora's face for this only ups the effect, but it also prevents her from getting a good view of the instant reaction Adora gives, twitching and *gasping*.

"No! I mean. Well. We should probably get more experience with regular sex before we, um, try stuff like that," Adora rambles, because even embarrassed she can't deny it—either doesn't want to or knows there's no point in trying. Catra snickers as she pulls back enough to properly look at her, smirking. Her tail is swishing behind her and, even this embarrassed, Adora's eyes flick down to her ass again.

"But you *do* want to," Catra corrects. Roleplay isn't her thing—in life or in the bedroom—like it is for Adora, but she thinks she would be fine with it. It definitely isn't something she wants to do right away, but especially if it's *just* the costumes and not Adora's dumb character acting thing, she doesn't mind it. Adora gives up on fiddling with her phone and raises her hands up to her face to hide behind them.

"Yes. Eventually. It was really about *you*, though, not her," Adora mumbles out. Catra raises a brow at her. When Adora peeks at her between her fingers, she huffs. "Like, when we were teenagers, I would project you onto her because then I could think about *us* without it feeling wrong, or like overstepping, because I could tell myself I was just thinking about the characters. I'm not trying to make you into her. It's kind of the opposite," Adora explains, fumbling but earnest. Catra's tail curls to one side and then whips to the other.

"Wow," Catra says, and she's actually a little awed, her sarcasm only a thin veneer. That wasn't an assurance she was looking for – yet – but it is one she's desperately glad to have. She shifts, wriggling closer so she can rest her chin on Adora's shoulder, half draping over her side. Adora drops her phone in favor of working her arm out from under Catra's opposite side so she can wrap it over her back, squeezing her closer. Catra's own phone is forgotten on the pillow.

"You wanted to fuck me that bad, huh?" Catra teases, her bravado back even if her heart is thudding heavier than usual still. Adora snorts, sending Catra a small smile. Then she does a rolling scratch down Catra's spine that has her sighing and melting down into the mattress. Adora releases a noise low in her throat, quiet and satisfied.

"Or kiss you. Or cuddle, or just *touch*. Every time I got to pet you or get any moment of contact it just felt like..." Adora trails off, gaze wandering away and fixing somewhere in the general direction of the TV. It isn't on. Adora's cheeks are still flushed, less than before but very much still present. "It felt like *something*. Like the world was stopped on your touch. I don't know how to say it without being too much," Adora manages, an edge of nerves in her voice and free hand waving vaguely.

She wouldn't be worrying about that if she were actually looking at Catra's face right now instead of staring at the wall. Catra's ear flicks, her heart squeezing in her chest. She turns her head to rest her cheek on Adora's shoulder instead of her chin and rubs a small

mark, mostly to reassure Adora and partially to reinforce her claim to her because fuck is she never letting her go again.

"I was the exact same way . I mean, I've been *thinking of* at you all weekend," Catra assures, voice low just because they're so close and not at all because she doesn't want to admit it. She *does* want Adora to know, and that matters more than her nerves. She has been having those moments for years. She tilts her head forward to bury her face in Adora's shoulder, just processing that it was mutual *the whole entire time* . Adora's head turns and she pulls back a little, trying to look down at Catra, but Catra stubbornly wriggles closer to keep her face hidden, ears pinning back. Adora is silent for a moment, and then her free hand falls into Catra's hair, smoothing over it.

"I thought you might just be messing with me," Adora admits, scratching carefully at the base of Catra's ear. Catra decides she can leave Adora's shoulder, leaning back into the touch as a scratchy purr starts up in her chest.

"That was a bonus. You're cute when you're embarrassed," Catra tells her, words buzzing a little. Adora snorts, but she doesn't stop scratching. Well, she kind of does, but Catra doesn't consider interspersing the scratches with ear rubs when her fingers get tired to be much of a downgrade.

"Glad to know you were enjoying my pain," Adora says, but her voice is sickeningly affectionate. Catra slits an eye open to find Adora watching her contentment with an expression bordering on *hungry* , a tinge of awe around her eyes.

"That's part of girlfriend privileges. Besides, you get off on being teased," she says. Predictably , Adora's face flushes. Her expression is indignant, and she opens her mouth to no doubt protest, but then she closes her mouth again. Yeah, like the fantasy about Clawdeen, Catra *knew* . She grins as Adora resumes scratching, letting her eyes flutter closed again as she leans back into the touch.

"Hm, if that's the toll, then you're worth the price," Adora decides. Catra would point out, once again, that Adora *I i k e d i t* , but Adora has managed to turn things around on her. Catra isn't going to get all blushy and flustered regardless of how much that sentence makes her feel, though, so she elects to keep her mouth shut and just lean into the affection.

She could get used to this. She can't *w a i t* to have this enough that she does.

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After an evening of flirting, and cuddling, and making out, and *m o r e* feeling each other up and nearly having sex again until Entrapta calls asking where Catra left a tool at the shop – why she needs it at 10pm on a Saturday is a question, but it grinds the mood to a halt enough that they eventually end up falling asleep together still only half dressed – Adora wakes up with Catra in her arms, snuggled close and purring. She's rubbing her face against the closest part of Adora to her, not to mention the pillows, though Adora is pretty sure those are just collateral damage.

It's adorable and Adora can't squeal over it like she wants to because then Catra would *w a k e u p* and stop. Or maybe she wouldn't, because Catra marked her probably a hundred different ways yesterday and doesn't seem shy about, but she doesn't want to interrupt her sleep regardless. It's pretty early in the morning, although if they got up right now, by the time they managed to get dressed – she imagines that will take a while, given how much they made out yesterday – and had breakfast, the con would be open. Adora wants to go out and have some fun on the final day before they leave in the afternoon, but unless Catra sleeps for another hour, she isn't going to worry about it. Knowing how weak she is for

sleeping Catra, she might not wake her for another hour after *that* anyway.

She carefully maneuvers around Catra to get her phone off the end table so she can kill time doing something other than thinking about how cute Catra is. She's wont be able to hold back from kissing all over her face if she lets those thoughts go too far and shell wake her up. She does take a risk on kissing Catra's ear when it flicks in her sleep, which makes her flick it again, but luckily it doesnt rouse her . Adora happily settles back down to occupy herself with Instagram. She posted more photos from their photoshoot last night, some of the teasing images from earlier in the shoot where Catra is *obviously* toying with her.

Glimmer wasnt wrong about the eyefucking even if Adora wishes she never acknowledged it. The tension in the photoset would be Oscar worthy if it were anything except embarrassingly real. Adora isnt sure she's ready to post the most risqué photos – and she's definitely going to need permission from Catra if she does – but she posted these last night mostly because she wanted to "do" something and feel accomplished even while they were laying around. She also just really likes the photos – likes them even *more* now she knows Catra was feeling the same way during the shoot that she was – and wants to share them.

There's one photo where she's holding the sword to Catra's neck, the lights on bright and looking especially magical through the lens. Adora wanted to show off Catra's work as much as she wanted to show off her. She has the usual roundup of comments to go through. Thirst comments, people gushing about the characters or cosplay, obvious questions like who is Clawdeen – *@ them* tagged – or who the characters are – again, Catra is credited, *Sad*, and if there's someone on her page who doesnt know who She-ra is, theyre very lost – but she's surprised to see a couple comments that are upset. Not because she's a stranger to negative comments, that kind of comes with the territory of having hundreds of thousands of followers, but because of what theyre upset about.

They dont like that it’ s a Clawdeen photoshoot. She doesnt really care. At least she tries not to. Comments always get to her occasionally – even leave her crying in her bed at times – but this is kind of a petty concern. On the other hand, she kind of gets it. She’s pretty firm on Teela being the only choice of She-ra in the show, but this isnt the show , it’s a cosplay shoot she did with her *girlfriend* , who happens to be a good match to Clawdeen.

They can be upset if they want. Catra is more important. That thought lets her brush it right off – she doesnt give a shit about a stranger’s opinion if they’re not-so-subtly shitting on Catra as a part of it, or if they would have preferred they that never did the photoshoot, because that photoshoot was a *portal into* her – but she decides to post to her story just to clear things up.

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Larry the Lobster after HRT shared a story with you

If Teela had been a magicat, we would have done that instead, but I wanted to cosplay with my girlfriend and it’s fun to explore other possibilities for a shoot. Ill block anyone that’s rude to Catra. She’s an amazing Clawdeen.

Tap to view

This fake Instagram thing is going a little far Wildcat

Yeah
About that

You okay?

Im fine
It’s just
Not fake anymore

What?

We're dating now
As of last night

Oh
Ok

Scorpia
We talked okay. We were both idiots. And pining
And we just fucked up
We're okay now

Are you sure

Yeah

Ok
I want you to be happy

I know
You deserve to be happy too

Thanks wildcat

I mean it
You're going to find someone nice
Who likes watching those dumb romcoms with you

Aw cmon you like them too
I can see you smile when they finally kiss

That was ONE TIME and it's because I was thinking about something else
Im being genuine, asshole

If you were being genuine you wouldnt have called them dumb

THEY ARE DUMB
love is dumb it's all overrated
Whatever
Youre going to find someone incredible who's a softie like you
And youll be disgusting together
Dont hold yourself back from trying because you think you
arent good enough or whatever
That's an order

You got it boss

Ill hold you to that

--

Catra wasnt expecting a… *ontation* –not confrontation, no matter how her brain wants to label it as that –with Scorpia upon waking up today, but she hasnt been thinking about much except Adora since yesterday. It's hard to tell over text, but she thinks that went okay. It's hard to straddle the line of being considerate and *hers* . She doesnt want to pretend that she's not in love with Adora anymore either. She doesnt want to take this thing from herself.

She just also doesnt want to hurt Scorpia. She resolves to take proper notes at the cosplay panel Scorpia was interested in, rather than the occasional things she jotted down in the other panel she sat in for Scorpia yesterday. It's not exactly a make-up present, but it cant hurt. They didnt *fight*, anyway, it's just something easy she can do for her. Adora is supposed to be paying attention for Bow and Glimmer, but about five minutes in it becomes clear Catra's notes are for both of them.

Whatever. She's taking them anyway, and Adora pulls her weight just by knowing Perfuma. After the panel –which Catra *does* find

interesting, although she's sure it's a lot more engaging to someone like Adora who is actually invested in cosplay, or even more so, Scorpia – they're able to walk up to Perfuma as she leaves. Perfuma immediately greets Adora brightly, pausing to hug her as they leave the room to make room for the next panel.

She pulls back from Adora and sends Catra a questioning look, which could be a prompt for an introduction, but apparently Perfuma knows enough about who she is to think they're dating, so it could be that she's also wondering if she should hug Catra. Catra immediately tucks herself down into Adora's side, an act of protection with maybe just a hint of jealousy to it. She hasn't forgotten the photoshoot Perfuma and Adora did, Perfuma's hand *totally* caressing Adora's cheek. Adora is hers now – she always was – and she's not above making that clear regardless of what Perfuma has assumed about their status.

"That was really great, Perfuma. I was worried when the audience questions came up but you handled them so well," Adora says as she, without hesitation, wraps an arm around Catra. Catra's tail sways, satisfied. Perfuma sends Adora a bright smile as she leads them away from the doors to the panel room and steps off to the side of the hallway. She turns to face them now they are out of the way of foot traffic.

"Thanks! To be honest, I was nervous too. I could handle it, but I really didn't want to bring that kind of negative energy to the panel when it had been going so well. I'm glad everyone worked with me to make it a positive space," Perfuma replies, her voice sparkling with that certain kind of *niceness* that Catra's brain always warns her is fake, but Perfuma is friends with Adora *and* Entrapta, so she knows she has to be overreacting. She doesn't usually trust people who project goodwill, though. It feels like they're covering for something. She's gotten better – she's learned that Adora isn't the only good person in the world – but the instinct still hovers in the back of her mind even as Perfuma looks to her with bright eyes.

"Oh, this is Catra. Catra, Perfuma," Adora introduces, gesturing between them. "She's been cosplaying this weekend because she *loves* it," Adora singsongs the words, smug and *infuriating*, which is the only reason Catra blushes and slinks down into Adora's side, "but normally it isn't her thing," Adora finishes, sending Catra a smug smirk. Catra elbows her, sending her a glare, but she doesn't pull away from her side.

Adora is such a cocky shit, and unfortunately, she *likes* it. It's the certain kind of combative that makes her fur itch until she wants to take off her clothes – and Adora's. Adora is probably just explaining why she's in full costume and Catra is dressed normally right now – the answer is they already had to check out of their room and Catra wasn't about to change in the car or drive three hours home in Clawdeen's "armor" – but of course Adora had to say it in the most annoying way possible.

"It's nice to meet you!" Perfuma says, sparkling and genuine but missing that earnestness Adora and Scorpia have that turns off Catra's fight or flight reflex, even if she knows she's being ridiculous, "It was a very queer panel, so I hope you were able to enjoy that aspect of it even if you don't like to cosplay." And see, that's why she knows her gut instinct is stupid. It was a good panel. They talked about things like transforming your gender presentation to match a character – or why somebody might not be comfortable with that, something Catra knows by association but hasn't really heard anyone but Scorpia talk about – or transforming a *body* to match the presentations you are comfortable with.

"Scorpia wanted me to take notes for her, so I came. It was interesting to see the different sides," Catra settles on. If Scorpia were here, she would have been watching it with hearts in her eyes, and that's how Catra knows that it was good. Perfuma put the whole thing together – according to Adora it's her dream panel that she has been trying to get off the ground for years – and she was a great host. It's an impressive introduction. Catra's gut instincts don't have a place here. She shrugs to Perfuma, trying to downplay everything,

but especially how flustered Adora made her. To her surprise, Perfuma's eyes sparkle.

"Anything I can do to promote some intersectionality! Scorpia works at your shop, right? I think I've seen her on Entrapta's Instagram, but it's hard to tell when she never tags anybody," Perfuma says. Catra snorts. Yeah, Entrapta uses social media in her own unique way that the rest of the world hasn't caught up with yet. That includes at least a fourth of her posts being photos of light fixtures she has come across – for some reason, all Catra knows is that Entrapta likes looking at them and that's about it – and doing exactly zero things to help with engagement.

To Catra's knowledge, she has never used a hashtag and only mentioned someone *once*, when they had just opened the workshop and Catra all but wrote a promo post for her so people knew who to contact when they wanted to hire her. In between all the lighting and half-gutted electrical posts, Entrapta posts some cool builds. Part of Catra's job as her "manager" is trolling through Entrapta's comments once a week and directing people to their main page for the workshop if they want more information.

"Yeah, Wildcat Workshop is me, Entrapta, and Scorpia. Scorpia's the one who named it, actually. I'm not egotistical enough for that, but none of us could come up with anything better so she got her way. Here," Catra says, reaching into her pocket. The big advantage of her being dressed normally – aside from *exceptionally* – is having pockets again. One of them had to carry Adora's car keys now they're checked out anyway, so it was either pockets or a bag. She pulls up Instagram, not having to scroll far down on her page to find a post she tagged Scorpia in. She's welding in it, the video a slow motion shot of sparks flying past her forearms. She turns to show the screen to Perfuma.

"That's Scorpia. She's on the opposite end of the workshop from Entrapta so they can trap me in the middle of their bullshit and annoy me," Catra says, giving Perfuma a few moments to watch the video – her eyes dilate, *intensifying* – before she clicks through and pulls up

Scorpia's profile. "Her page. Since Entrapta is allergic to tagging," Catra says. She watches Perfuma's face do something *interesting* where her eyebrows raise and her mouth twitches, her eyes focusing on one part of the screen.

"Larry the Lobster after R T?" she reads off, finally looking up to make eye contact with Catra. Catra pauses, and then shrugs. Scorpia did that like two months ago and Catra is pretty sure she has forgotten about it. She should probably talk to her about changing it so the page looks a bit more professional – unlike Entrapta, Scorpia does do *some* purposeful promo work on hers, even if it's very little and that kind of thing is mostly left to Catra – but it was funny and it seemed rude to bring up, so she didn't. It leads to moments like this, though, where Scorpia isn't exactly out but she is far from stealth.

"Uh, yeah, you know . She likes to joke about it." There, vague enough. Still obvious, but deniable. She doesn't think Scorpia would mind Perfuma knowing – she doesn't know what else she expected Catra to do if something like this came up, she *did* make it her display name, after all – but she still isn't going to come out and say it without any indication of permission. Perfuma's gaze slides over to make eye contact with Adora instead. Adora shrugs. If Catra isn't sure what Perfuma wants, she doubts Adora knows, but Perfuma's eyes sparkle like that was all she needed.

"I can't believe I have to have her ," she says to her , an almost wry smile tugging at her lips – as if it' s a joke, as if being attracted to Scorpia is funny. Adora offers Perfuma a kind of twitchy, weak smile back along with an awkward laugh as Catra stares at her.

"You don't have to," Catra corrects. Adora does dumb things and Catra thinks *that idiot* and *all me* in the same breath, but she doesn't know Perfuma well enough to tell if that is what' s happening here, and Adora seems so awkward – or maybe just confused – that Catra can't judge anything off of her. Perfuma glances down at the screen again.

"No, I do. I mean, is she single? Do you think she would be interested?" she asks. Catra's ears twitch. Perfuma had an immediate reaction to seeing Scorpia – which Catra doesn't blame her for, because Scorpia is hot – and that was a good enough answer for Catra to feel like Perfuma's thoughts are in the *that's not the* direction, but she still feels caught off guard. She isn't sure if it's because Perfuma is being so bold or because she knows that the interest is mutual. Not that Scorpia knows much about Perfuma outside of her Twitter feed, but she has been following her ever since the panel announcement put her on her radar. Scorpia has a history of only going after people she can't have, for various reasons. Catra wasn't the first, just the first since high school.

"Uh, yeah, maybe-" "definitely," "but she isn't a hookup type," Catra settles on, because she's pretty sure that's what Perfuma means and she's just too classy to say *fuck*. Perfuma sends her a dazzling smile, straightening up and opening the small clutch she is carrying – her dress is way too lightweight and whimsical for pockets to do anything but ruin the flounce – to produce her phone.

"I'm not really either," Perfuma replies. Catra is certain she's pulling up Instagram on her own phone. She shifts from foot to foot, glancing at Adora to get a read on the situation. Adora doesn't seem put-off or anything – at least not anymore – but the best she can give Catra is a small shrug and smaller smile. She's pretty sure the latter is supposed to be assuring, but it *is not* when combined with the former.

When she looks back to Perfuma, she's clearly reading Scorpia's handle off Catra's screen. Catra finally lowers her phone and puts it back in her pocket when Perfuma looks back to her phone for long enough she's *playing* following Scorpia now. Perfuma doesn't message her immediately, though, smiling at the screen in a way that is a little sweet – that reassures Catra, a little – before she puts her phone to sleep and slips it back into her clutch. When she looks up, she seems to finally catch *something* in Catra's expression.

f will back of f if she doesnt express interest. I already thought she was an impressive woman when I saw glimpses of her before, and with a sense of humor like." Perfuma trails of f in the middle of her assurance, clasping her hands behind her back and pursing her lips as she thinks.

"Adora?" Catra supplies, by which she means idiotic. That word doesnt really fit, but it' s a certain kind of dorky innocence – naivete – combined with a *fe*w lacking braincells that cant really be summed up in any way that doesnt sound like an insult, except to say Adora, because that's obviously a compliment. A smile flashes across Perfuma's face and she glances back to Adora, who huffs at Catra.

"Y es," Perfuma agrees, laughing a little. Then she shrugs. f have to have her," she reiterates, only Catra is more comfortable with it this time. She can quiz Adora on what she knows about the other woman on the ride home, maybe. She already knows Perfuma is a queer activist, so at least she *e* , and that's an important trait in a person. She's also pretty , definitely, not in the way Catra likes, but in a way she's pretty sure Scorpia does. And she's friends with Entrapta, which might say even more than being friends with Adora. In combination, it's enough.

"ll tell her to check her DMs when I get home," Catra decides, with a shrug. Perfuma didnt send anything of f yet, but it gives her a timeline. If that doesnt convince her not to fuck around, then Catra will have gotten a better idea of what she's dealing with and if she needs to scare her off. She doesnt want Scorpia to get heartbroken – she' s been spending the last year trying not to be the source of that *he* *f* . Perfuma brightens, clapping her hands together.

"Oh, please! I would appreciate it," she says, and *the* *s* that earnestness Adora and Scorpia have that makes Catra relax. She nods to her, feeling a little better. When they started this conversation, she meant to ask her a few things about the panel – something about why she chose the people she did, maybe – to potentially add to her notes, but getting Scorpia a date is probably far better than letting her experience a panel second hand.

As long as it’s a good date. She can ask Adora about that in the car.

Chapter End Notes

I know I said I didnt want to mess with real properties, but Meta made the Larry the Lobster joke and I had to do it.

She-ra

Chapter Summary

> They dont need the deflection of characters to be who they are anymore.

Chapter Notes

> This chapter has been 1-2 scenes from completion for literally two weeks but Ive been so sick I havent been able to finish it until now.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Ill be honest, Ive got a lot of equipment, but Im still kind of jealous of this," Catra says, her hand on the clear top of Adora's laser cutter as she peers down into it. Really, it's more like *Bow's* laser cutter. They all split the cost to buy it, and Adora uses it for a lot of her cosplay projects, but she usually needs a little help from Bow to do it and he also uses it for his own stuff. Glimmer uses it on occasion too, but not nearly enough to justify her buying one on her own. The thing is invaluable to Bow and Adora, though.

"I love it. Sometimes I miss having a larger CNC, but if it was that or the cutter, Id chose the laser every time. Especially for what I do," Adora says, shrugging. She didnt really have a reason to bring Catra up into the workshop, it just felt like a good place for them to be. Besides, Glimmer and Bow are home, so disappearing upstairs seemed like a good call. She was too eager for Catra to come over to delay it enough to coordinate a time when they could be alone. It has been five days since they came back from their con trip and that's way too long to be away from her *girlfriend*. She said yes as soon as Catra texted about visit.

Introducing Catra as her girlfriend when she brought her back Sunday night was interesting, but even though Glimmer seems to be

a bit protective, she has mostly been letting them slide. Bow is definitely helping. He saw Adora's Instagram post on Sunday morning, apparently, and started running interference so Glimmer was too busy to see it before Adora got home and could give a proper explanation. Adora is pretty sure he thought she was so useless that the post was still part of their game and he was trying to delay Glimmer yelling at her until after they had parted ways so Catra didn't overhear anything too obvious, but Adora managed the biggest accomplishment of her life that weekend and she was proud to show it off.

"Yeah, I couldn't trade mine in for this either even if I wanted to. I need a CNC's power. It's still sexy, though," Catra agrees, pushing off the cutter and turning to face her. The way she stands puts her directly between Adora and Bow's heart lamp on the wall, the heart perfectly framed above her head by her ears. It feels like the universe nudging and winking at her, especially when something must show on her face because Catra's ears *twitch* and she levels her with a look that makes Adora want to kiss her.

"You're really pretty," Adora blurts out. She has been keeping stuff like this down for years and it's still sinking in she doesn't have to. She definitely doesn't *want* to, especially not when such declarations make Catra squeak and duck her head. She's blushing as she looks up at Adora with wide eyes that immediately put her heart in a vice grip. Catra has her whipped – she has for a long time.

"I'm just standing here," Catra says, flustered and still looking at her with that wide-eyed look. Adora can't resist anymore, stepping close and reaching for her. Catra immediately turns towards her, letting herself be drawn in so their hips are together, chests pulled back just far enough for them to keep eye contact. Adora grins at Catra, even more besotted with her up close.

"I'm always thinking about how pretty you are," Adora counters, watching Catra's eyes blow out in response. It's so cute, Adora can't resist any longer, swaying forward to kiss her. Catra makes a soft noise – pleased, Adora thinks – and kisses her back after only a

moment of surprise. Adora doesn't know *why* she was surprised, she thinks she was pretty obvious with how she drew Catra in and she hasn't been shy about kissing her since they finally confessed, but it's nice to feel Catra melt into her.

Catra's chest rumbles softly as Adora presses close, aware at this point that Catra likes them to be pressed together as close as possible when they're doing this. She has to adjust her arms, wrapping one around her waist and the other around her back with her hand splayed between her shoulder blades, to hold her in place and kiss her with the intent that she wants, but the rumble is far from a *complaint* about that. Adora kisses her until she's out of air, and then she pulls back only far enough to breathe, nuzzling her nose against Catra's cheek.

Actually, she wants to see her face. She draws back again and is rewarded with Catra's smile. Catra with joy in her face will never stop being Adora's favorite sight. Her eyes are hooded, pupils mostly round, and she's watching Adora with what Adora *sees* is a reflection of the look on her own face. It's love and the *joy* of being loved. It's such a contrast from where they were a few months ago, Adora wouldn't have believed it was possible.

"Fuck, I love you so much," Adora says. She can say it now, and she loves the way it makes Catra's eyes sparkle.

"Adora, I'm just breathing," Catra replies, her voice rumbling with laughter. It's far from a genuine complaint. Adora grins, pulling her a little tighter against her.

"I just *did* and I can't keep it down anymore," Adora tells her, laughing a little as well. She knows she's being ridiculous, but those three years were hard. She thought she'd lost Catra forever, but that did nothing to dim her feelings, it just made them *hurt*. She feels her smile fall and watches the light leave Catra's eyes as well. A new one replaces it: anxiety.

Adora lets go of Catra, which only makes the anxiety on her face flare, but she quickly reaches up and frames Catra's face with her hands, holding her just as close as she did before and maintaining eye contact. Catra resumes breathing, at least, but nerves are written on her features as she flicks her eyes all over Adora's face. She's searching for assurance. Adora plans to give it.

"If anything ever happens between us again – which I *really* hope it doesn't, but if it does – know that I love you more than anything else in the world. And if- if I ever make you feel like I don't, please talk to me. Let me fix it. I want to be with you for the rest of my life," Adora says, her voice low and begging. They've talked, but she needs to say this – she *needs* Catra to know it. Catra's eyes widen and she draws in a small, startled gasp, holding Adora's gaze for a few long moments. The only thing in the air is their heartbeats, because even if Adora can't hear Catra's, she knows it's likely as loud as her own.

"Adora, I-" Catra stops, cutting off to swallow. Adora knows just how *much* that declaration was, but apparently she didn't give Catra enough before, and she has always wanted her to see every part of her. "Okay," Catra agrees, her voice low, "Don't let me go either. I was an idiot to not see it sooner with how you chased after me, but I was convinced you just wanted the convenience of our life together back." Adora's heart starts warm, but she's gaping by the end of the sentence.

"*How*?" she asks, even though she already knows. It's a rhetorical question, she's just appalled at the idea of ever *thinking* of her like that. She knows what she did wrong, but she loves Catra so much, she can't imagine such a wide gap between her intentions and how Catra felt.

"Adora, one day you just stopped looking at me. You stopped caring about the shop and our builds, you spent all your time sewing or on your phone. It felt like you were *hating* on me, only I knew there wasn't another girl really, just a better life," Catra's words taper down to a whisper and her eyes fall closed. Her head turns down, either leaning into Adora's hands or trying to turn away. "One that didn't

involve me,” she adds, words quiet and laced with emotion. Adora didn't know she could go from being so happy to wanting to cry like this.

“Catra, *no*. It always involved you. It was- I was blinded trying to build something so I could leave the horde – so *we* could, hopefully – but I never wanted to leave *you*,” Adora promises, all but pleading with Catra to believe her. She *loves* her. She can say it now, but this isn't about her getting to say it, it's about Catra feeling it, *believing* it. Catra opens her eyes and looks at her again, expression fragile but still hopeful enough for Adora to breathe again.

“Yeah, I know. Now at least,” Catra responds, voice gentle. She reaches up, grabbing Adora's wrist to hold it steady as she turns and presses a kiss to her palm. Adora strokes her other cheek as Catra looks up at her again, eyes wide from this angle, cute and making Adora want to wrap her up all over again. That's where this all started, where she always comes back to: Catra, and how much she loves her. For a long time her world centered on her. She doesn't think they're going to break again, not after talks like this, but these promises make her heart calm down even if it still hurts to think Catra felt like that.

“You *have* built something now,” Catra adds, voice still low. She holds Adora's eyes, an assurance, or maybe a statement: you have it, so make time for me now. Knowing Catra, it's probably both. Adora offers her a smile, not nearly as happy as the ones she was giving before this conversation, but still real.

“Yeah. So have you. It's incredible,” she breathes back. They're both in a better place. They're busy, with their businesses and projects and lives outside of each other, but they're to a point where they can do *this*, hold each other and be honest. A smile tugs at the corner of Catra's mouth, a testament to their progress in its mere existence. She never would have been able to lift up after such an emotional moment back when they were teenagers.

"And we'll find a way to build more together?" Catra adds, something that shouldn't be a question but there's a lilt to it like she thinks she might be overstepping – dreaming too big, or saying too much. Adora turns her hand Catra is holding, sliding down and threading her fingers through Catra's. Catra smiles and squeezes her hand back.

"A life, and some cool ass projects," Adora promises. That brings the sparkle of laughter back to Catra's eyes. She leans into Adora's hand still on her cheek and squeezes the one that she's holding.

"We can build something when we're back in my shop. I think Bow finished convincing Glimmer to leave a few minutes ago," Catra returns. Adora pauses, blinking at her and then glancing over her shoulder towards the stairs. Catra snorts. "He started as soon as we headed upstairs, but the front door closed a bit ago. We're alone," Catra adds. Adora feels her cheeks warm as she looks back at Catra. Catra sends her a look almost cartoonishly seductive – a leer, really – but it still manages to make her flush even as she laughs.

"Come on," Adora says, dropping her hand from Catra's cheek and stepping back. Catra follows her back towards the stairs without hesitation. She doesn't imagine they're going to do anything like they did last weekend after a talk like that, but she could definitely go for a make out and some time with Catra in her arms.

--

Catra | Wildcat Workshop mentioned you in a post
@adora.cos is ruining my organization system trying to find some scrap that's "inspiring" enough to find us a project to fill our afternoon
Tap to view

The video shows Adora attempting to scale a series of drawers, shelves, and cubbies that are luckily all solidly affixed to the wall. As Catra lets out a rattling sigh, Adora glances back over her shoulder and throws the camera a dazzling smile. Her ponytail is crooked and some of her hair has escaped to flop in her face.

--

Adora shared your story
We made a cat toy. Melog isnt impressed
Tap to view

Adora kneels on the floor in the video, patting the floor and calling quietly to Melog, who has wedged himself under a table and almost entirely disappeared, though the glint of his eyes is still visible as he eyes the toy set beside Adora, a solid base with a twirler, some springs, and a few wooden sliders attached to it. It probably is supposed to be bursting with stimulation for the stray, but he has settled on suspicion.

--

Catra makes all these little *noises* that Adora never would have expected before the first time they got in bed together – and even then, further experience has shown she was holding herself back – and they just might be Adora's favorite thing ever. It's not even exclusive to sex, just seeming *fun* . Adora will pull Catra into a hug upon reaching her front door and be greeted with a small,

contented sigh. Shell absently rub Catra' s shoulder as her hand rests there and get a small grunt, just the hint of a rumble.

In bed it's a symphony of gentle h s, gasps, whimpers, and play growls. Catra is quiet about it, but she makes a lot of noises. Even just kissing like they are now , sprawled over Catra's bed in her bedroom tucked between the living room and Entrapta's master, Catra lets out gentle rumbles of approval as Adora nips at her lip and then kisses her way down her neck. Catra tilts her head back and lets out a quiet sigh of satisfaction as Adora trails kisses up and down the side of her neck. Just Adora' s breath on her neck can make Catra give a small growl of anticipation, so quiet Adora might not hear it, but still feeling it through her hands as she pulls Catra close.

I love you,"Adora breathes against her neck as she kisses back up to the corner of her jaw and nuzzles into Catra' s cheek tufts. They're ticklish, but they're also so soft. Catra rumbles, shifting so she can rub her cheek properly on Adora's face. She basically rubs herself against her nose, which kind of hurts, but Adora lets her leave her mark. Every time Catra nuzzles against her , her chest fills with emotions she feels like can't even be encompassed by *l ove* .

"Y ou too, dork. One day well manage to have sex without you saying it,"Catra tells her , voice rumbling with amusement. Adora pulls back to give Catra and exaggerated pout. Catra throws her a lazy smirk which, when combined with her shirt pushed up almost to her armpits so Adora could run her hands over her, fairly successfully distracts Adora. She licks her lips, her eyes trailing down.

"Y ou.love it,"her words come slow , her mind a little *fuzz* on the sight in front of her. Catra's laugh is quiet, but it makes her shoulders shake and Adora's eyes are draw to her chest and her stomach jumping as she laughs near-silently . She buries one hand in Catra's stomach fluff, right above her low waistband where it starts thickening, and skims the other up her side and frames her chest

with it. She knows how Catra likes to be touched now, and she *does* like it, Adora just has to do it right. She's very dedicated to studying.

"Doesn't make you less of a dork for it," Catra says, arching her back a little beneath Adora's hands. Adora tears her eyes from her body to look at her face, which is just as enchanting. She loves seeing Catra's smile, her expression relaxed and cheeks just a touch flushed as she waits for Adora to move things forward. They both love the buildup, though, and now that they've done this enough times, Adora doesn't feel like she is exploding every moment she isn't touching Catra. She doesn't need to rush forward anymore. She might miss some of those small noises if she does.

"You would pout if I stopped," Adora counters, and then she leans forward and kisses Catra, putting an end to that line of conversation. Sure, they don't have to rush ahead, but she *really* likes kissing Catra and wants to be doing it. This time she gets to feel Catra's amused rumble for the brief moment before she sets to kissing Adora back with just as much dedication as Adora meets her with. Now they have some experience with this, Adora loves kissing Catra slow and thorough, just sinking into each other and enjoying having one another.

Catra lets out one of those gentle *hahs* she loves so much as Adora readjusts and gentle squeezes her chest in her hand. Catra drapes her arms over Adora's shoulders, plastering her hands against her back and pulling her in closer. Adora loves how close Catra likes them to be, but it does force her to abandon her hand on Catra's stomach so she can brace herself on the mattress next to her. Feeling Catra's warmth up against her makes up for it though, especially getting to feel Catra's next play growl as she nips at Adora's lip. Adora stutters out a gasp herself, turning Catra's growl into a purr of satisfaction.

Adora is so focused on earning more sounds from Catra, there isn't room for anything else. She also doesn't have Catra's hearing, so when a door suddenly slams just outside, Adora nearly has a heart attack, jumping and turning with a fist already raised, ready to defend

them. Catra, who probably knew they weren't alone *the whole time*, laughs down on the bed as Adora tries to take steady breaths and control her adrenaline upon being greeted with an empty room.

"I appreciate how ready you are to fight a home invader for me, but it's just Entrapta," Catra says, laughter hitching her voice. Adora turns to pout at her, still working on controlling her heartbeat. Catra's fond expression helps soothe the fear-adrenaline at least. Adora leans forward, bracing both arms on either side of Catra and burying her face against Catra's chest to calm herself. Yes, she's basically hiding in her tits, but it's soft and warm and *Catra* so it helps. Catra purrs – amusement or trying to soothe Adora, who knows – and reaches down to pet through her hair. She took out Adora's ponytail back when they first started making out.

Adora takes a few moments to just breathe and let her heart calm down. Catra's touch is gentle and soothing as the adrenaline fades. After a few moments, she nuzzles up to press a kiss over Catra's heart before she commits to pulling back, bracing herself up properly. Catra offers her a smile, expression soft and fond. She shifts her hands from her hair to lightly frame her face, gently pulling her in for a gentle kiss. It does just as much to soothe Adora as the cuddling did. By the time they part, the effects of the momentary startle have faded. Still, Adora can't help glancing back over her shoulder even though Catra's door is still closed. Entrapta's door is just on the next wall – a wall they share between their rooms.

"We're not having sex, are we?" she jokes, looking back to Catra. That wasn't a given anyway, though she's pretty sure that's where they were headed anyway. Catra snickers, stretching up to kiss her nose.

"Probably not, but we can definitely make out," Catra promises. A smile tugs at the corner of Adora's mouth. She leans down, kissing Catra again happily. That's definitely good enough for her.

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Adora mentioned you in a post
I dedicate this post to my girlfriend's amazing prop skills. I mean just LOOK at this sword!! I couldnt stop playing with it, I have probably six more photodumps worth of pictures of me posing with it, but I narrowed it down to this selection.
Costumes by me, sword and Clawdeen by @ctraprops, 📸 by @owtastic
Tap to view

--

My agent just called

Why do I have a bad feeling

It's not bad, I just got selected for a photoshoot

You do like a photoshoot a month why are you telling me this

It's a perfume ad

Ok? You do a lot of cosmetics for someone who doesnt wear them

Perfume ads tend to be a certain way

You're going to be naked arent you

Probably not
But they did ask if I could be willing

And what did you tell them

As long as I wouldn't be posing with a man
I mean it's going to be in magazines it can't actually show anything
In all likelihood I'll be in lingerie. Because that was part of the offer

Ok

Is that okay?

Since when do you need to ask me for permission?

Since we started dating?
I know I've done stuff like this before
But you tend to be jealous
I'm not trying to shame you I just don't want us to have problems

It's okay
I know what I am
I did really hate it at first
But I also liked being able to look

It's just that other people could look too

Yeah
I've gotten used to it
As long as you aren't being naked with other people then I'm fine with it
For a professional shoot anyway
Ship photoshoots are different

Okay!
I figured ships might be a problem
I can just do like pairing photoshoots where we don't get flirty just the two characters together

Stuff like the photos we took fighting
Not the... other photos

Yeah that's fine

Typing for an awful long time over there

Ugh
It's just
Im trying to be supportive
And not be controlling

I know
And I want to be able to cosplay my way
And take the opportunities Im interested in

Yeah

But
I also dont mind limiting stuf f like that
It's not a hardship to wear clothes

Speak for yourself I think you should ditch them at home

I have roommates!!

when Im home with you

me huh <3

Oh shut up
The point is that it mostly makes me jealous when other people are involved

Okay. I can work with that
And Ill let you know when stuf f like this comes up

Yeah. Thanks
Im not going to pretend that sometimes I dont wish other

people couldn't see you like that
But really it's fine
Let them look
And be jealous of what's mine



--

Adora's arms loop around her waist from behind, threatening to make her lose her balance on her stool, but quickly Adora's embrace solidifies into a strong hug, Adora dropping a kiss on her shoulder as Catra tips her head back. They're too close for her to look at Adora's face, but she does get to rub their cheeks together, which is good too.

"Whatcha making?" Adora asks, turning her head to kiss Catra's cheek. Catra isn't going to get tired of that. Every time Adora casually kisses her sends a shiver through her. It seems like Adora can't keep her hands off of her since they got together, but the feeling is very much mutual, so Catra is far from complaining. They haven't hung out once without making out at least a *little* so far, and they're managing to see each other at least twice a week.

"New commission. Trying out some ideas to make it a little better that the client might be willing to pay for," Catra tells her, dropping her head back down to look at the two notepads she's sketching across, not to mention her laptop open up beside her. Adora hums, leaning over her shoulder to look at her work. Catra moves her hands out of the way so Adora can see. She used to prefer to cover her work, back in the Horde where you had to deliver something as perfect as possible, as quickly as possible. She doesn't have that pressure here. She can sketch out a dozen failed attempts and choose none of them.

"These look good. You don't like the client vision?" Adora asks. They aren't all good, some of them are *fine*, but Adora is merely glancing at them, so Catra lets it go. She reaches for her laptop and switches tabs so Adora can see the original client specs.

"It's *fine*, just not... impressive enough to represent me, you know? I mean I'll do it if I can't convince them to spring for any of these, but this whole 2D thing is insultingly simple, and they're going to be incorporating it into their booth. I'd rather make something more technical, challenging," Catra says, shrugging a little. If her business was ten years in, maybe five years in, she—probably—wouldn't be pushing the client to accept a grander vision like this, but she does have standards, so maybe she would. If she can convince them to go for it, it will be better pay, too.

"Yeah, I get that. I mean, you know what a perfectionist I am. I don't usually try to make my work harder, but I'm not surprised you are," Adora says, teasing, as she kisses Catra's cheek again. Catra huffs. She's not just making her work harder. Everything she puts out now to speak to her skills, and it's important that she draws in new work as she builds up her client base, so *imaging* is a priority right now. When she was in the Horde, she did the best work she could, but nothing was credited to her anyway and the deadlines were tight, so she would never add to her workload like this.

"It will be more fun to build," she adds, because that's also true. This 2D construct? Program some shapes in the CNC and then it's mostly painting, which isn't her favorite. Her proposal to add just a few 3D elements won't increase the price too much, so she hopes they'll at least go for that. Her grand proposal to turn the entire thing 3D and add some lights... She might not bother presenting that, because as exciting as it would be to do, she refuses to undervalue her time and give them a discount on that work. It's outside their budget.

Decisions like this—and *meetings* like the one she will have to have to pitch this properly—aren't her favorite thing about her owning her own business. It's the kind of thing Hordak or someone else above her would do without her ever knowing and the final specs would be

handed to her already immutable. As hard as striking a balance with clients and negotiating is, though, it's worth it. She talked a little about improving the display when she was on the phone with the client, and they seemed receptive enough even if they stressed their budget was limited. Shell find something that works for both of them so that whatever she ends up making, she's proud of what she managed within the constraints.

Pride in her work was in short supply when she didnt own it. Adora was able to hang onto hers a bit more, but that might have been part of why she burned out so fast. Now, Adora flips through Catra's sketches and taps one, one of her proposals to mix 3D with 2D elements to make something both close to budge, and easier to transport than a full 3D construct.

"This one looks good. I mean, this all-in sketch you have is awesome, but if budget's a problem I think you have a good balance here. Want to ideate with me or would you prefer cuddles while you work?" Adora asks, looking at her with an expression softened by affection. Catra purrs for no good reason, she just likes Adora looking at her with such blatant emotion.

Adora asked to come over mostly on an impulse, because she was already nearby running an errand, and Catra does have to finish this today so she's ready for the call tomorrow, but she could opt just for cuddles and take a break. She cant pass up an opportunity to work with Adora, though. Ideating is almost like a debate, and they both always loved that aspect, even if they've fought more than once about it. Catra is sure that wont happen with this. It doesnt matter enough, and she has final say anyway – well, final say over what she presents to the client, anyway.

"Both can happen at the same time," Catra points out, lounging back against Adora. Adora chuckles, hugging her closer for a moment before she drops one arm from Catra, adjusting so she can still hug her even as she reaches to pluck the pencil out of Catra's hand.

“Alright, fine, be like that. I would switch these elements around.”… And they’re off. Catra grins as Adora starts working through her logic as she draws a shittier sketch of what she’s thinking. She would blame the angle, but Adora’s art skills have always been entirely based on the technical skills needed to design things and not a step further. Catra is still fond of it, though. Maybe she just likes watching their styles—their ideas, their work, their *lives*—mingle together on the page.

She’s sappy, she’s just a lot quieter about it than Adora

--

Adora @adoraFTW

So excited about the new She-ra casting!! Not what I was expecting, but now I’m really excited to see where Mara takes the role 😁 Really hoping the reboot lives up to the original!

Wrmista @wrmistaSW *Replying to @glyngtoons*

Did you see that photo of her making her wife wear a Halloween store Teela costume? The normal clothes under it and the dead stare make it.

Adora @adoraFTW *Replying to @wrmistaSW*

Omg I didn’t that’s so cute. It’s so cool they cast a fan! And obvs the original actress came out way later, but it will be cool to have

an openly gay She-ra while the show is going on. I can already tell her interviews are going to be great

--

It takes some trial-and-error, and a few frustrated texts late at night, but they manage to bully their schedules into some semblance of lining up. It's harder to fit around their *normal* schedules too, because at first Catra wants to be with only Adora when they're together, but those difficulties force them to spend some time with Glimmer and Bow, or Entrapta and Scorpia, while they're together and slowly Catra seems to warm up to them.

The first time Glimmer tries to crash their date by flinging herself onto the couch while they're cuddling, Catra growls at her , but two weeks later she's only somewhat begrudgingly allowing Glimmer to join them as they watch a movie in the living room. As long as they're only seeing each other a few times a week, Adora agrees with Catra that she wants time together where they can be entirely dedicated to each other, but it's also kind of magical to finally be fitting their new lives together, not pretending that it's just the two of them like they were three years ago, but being together how they are *now*.

"I was really worried about her at first," Glimmer says, almost casually, as Adora wanders into the kitchen about an hour after Catra left for the night. They dont sleep over that often unless it' s at Catra's house. Adora can keep any hours she likes, but Catra tends to stick to something approaching regular business hours at the workshop. Catra's hours lean slightly more *nocturnal* than most businesses', but that' s the benefit of being self-employed. She still needs to have plenty of crossover with when her clients are up, so she has worked something out that, coincidently, matches up

decently with Adora's terrible sleep schedule borne from too many late-night sewing sessions before a deadline.

"I know. And I appreciate you looking out for me. But reconnecting to her is the best thing that's ever happened to me," Adora says, leaning against the counter right beside the stove and folding her arms. She isn't being defensive, just getting comfortable in pretty much the only spot she can make eye contact while Glimmer watches the hotpot she's making. Glimmer glances up at her with suspicion. It makes Adora furrow her brow – she's being *genuine* here and she thinks it's kind of obvious – before she realizes she's closing in on Glimmer's food and she has a *bit* of a reputation for giving her friends puppy eyes until they let her have some.

"Even better than when you got to host the She-ra fan event?" Glimmer teases. Adora can't help but smile at the memory. She was bouncing off the *walls* when she got the call from her agent. The event was a lot of fun, even if she spent the whole thing running on a baseline level of anxiety that felt like an adrenaline rush. She was worried something would go wrong, or that afterwards she would be pulled aside and told she represented the brand wrong, but it turned out to be a near-perfect night. It's one of her favorite memories, and definitely her favorite thing that her career has enabled her to do. Adora hums.

"Yeah. Don't tell Catra it's stiff competition though," Adora replies, grinning. It's mostly a joke. Sure, that was *living* and *hanging*, but in a more metaphorical and emotional sense than an actual impact on her future. It helped her career, but that's nothing compared to spending the rest of her life with someone. *Hopefully*, anyway. She knows they have a long way to go, but she *wants to be* with Catra.

Glimmer snorts, sending her an amused look as she stirs her food. Adora glances down at it. Glimmer immediately reacts by blocking Adora's line of sight to it as much as possible with just one arm.

Now it's on. Adora reaches over to move her arm and soon they're – carefully – battling for the pot, Adora making a bid to steal Glimmer's ladle even though she has no intention of trying to eat anything so

steaming hot. It's all a game, and they're laughing as they battle by hip checking and elbowing each other, all while being mindful of the hot stove. Eventually Adora backs off so one of them doesn't get burned. Glimmer returns to guarding her stove, Adora now settled one cabinet down as a peace offering.

"I used to do stuff like this with her all the time, you know," Adora says as they both catch their breath. Glimmer rolls her eyes, clearly unsurprised.

"Oh, so is that where the burn on your arm is from?" she replies. Adora pauses, uncrossing her arms and lifting each one up until she spots the pale patch of skin near her elbow. Right. No, she was actually careful when she and Catra would wrestle like this. In the shop, less so.

"Hot glue gun," she corrects. Glimmer immediately winces. Anybody who works in crafts knows the pain of a hot glue gun. It will inevitably happen. You can be as careful as possible and then, while you're watching the gun and what you glued, you lean your elbow in some dripped but still searing glue – hypothetically. Adora was usually the one to handle any gluing they needed though, so she has learned to work with it as best she can. She wasn't going to saddle Catra with glue stuck in her fur, possibly pulling it out. She's rather a fan of Catra's fluff.

"Well I'd still prefer not to get burned, so if you back off I *might* let you have some. If you also do the dishes," Glimmer tells her. Adora pauses, considering. She wasn't really making a bid for Glimmer's food, but any night she doesn't have to cook is a good one. Doing dishes is easier than cooking, at least for her. Catra would have the opposite opinion, but that's just proof they were made for each other. While they're still navigate their new relationship isn't the time to jump into living together again though, as much as Adora wants that. She also likes the life she has here with Glimmer and Bow.

She is sure Catra likes living with Entrapta and Scorpia too, as much as she complains about them. They'll have to figure out how to make

their living situation work with their relationship eventually, but that is not a hurdle for the first few months. If anything, it will come up when one of their leases is due for renewal. Adora misses waking up with Catra, but she would miss this too if they moved out somewhere together –a fourth person certainly can't fit in one of their current homes.

"You have a deal," Adora agrees, if for no other reason than because she wants to hang around the kitchen and enjoy time with Glimmer while she can, and that might be a little difficult if Glimmer is eyeing her with suspicion. Nothing is changing soon, but it will one day, and her time in the Best Friends Squad house has been some of the happiest in her life, even missing Catra the way she did. Once they get to wake up together every day –someday –she isn't going to really wish she was back here, but she will miss it sometimes. She wants to know she enjoyed it while she had it.

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Adora mentioned you in a post
I know I keep posting photos from this shoot every couple days, but there's so many great ones.
Costumes by me, sword by @catraprops (also Clawdeen), 📸 by @owtastic
Tap to view

--

Making out in a car isn't all it's cracked up to be, but even with Scorpia and Perfuma's first date looming –Scorpia has been

giggling while texting her and gushing about the woman to Catra when she manages to trap her in the middle of a build she can't walk away from—Catra isn't quite comfortable making out with Adora in the shop, at least not while Scorpia is there. They barely held back from having sex on her work table a week ago, but even though they were "alone," Melog staring at them from a shelf killed the mood.

They had all of lunch to be wrapped up in each other—emotionally, at least, Catra has enough sense of propriety to not sit in Adora's lap in a public restaurant—but now that they're supposed to part ways so Adora can go work on her latest cosplay and Catra can help Entrapta with her current build, they can't untangle themselves. Leaning over the center console is uncomfortable, but it's kind of worth it to frame Adora's face with her touch and feel Adora's hands threaded in her hair.

Adora kisses her with this *purpose*—this determination—that makes Catra feel like she is so focused on her she can't possibly even notice anything else. Adora's grip tightens slightly in her hair, then softens, her fingertips stroking at the base of Catra's ear as Adora coaxes her into a deeper, softer kiss. Twisting together in the car is so uncomfortable but it is *worth* it if she gets to have this, even with her back protesting. She lets out a small whimper she can't even find it in herself to be ashamed of, but it makes Adora draw in a soft breath, and that breaks the kiss.

Catra pulls away already mourning the loss of Adora's lips, but her back thanks her as she drops back against the passenger seat. Adora blinks her eyes open on a delay after they part, gaze a bit dazed. Catra can't say she's feeling any more eager to return to reality than Adora is, but her back wasn't going to let her keep drifting for long anyway, no matter how good it feels to have Adora's touch be the only thing anchoring her. She smirks at Adora as her gaze refocuses, finding Catra's and holding it. For a moment they just look at each other and then Adora pouts, exaggeratedly.

"I don't want you to go yet," she says, and Catra's heart trips. She doesn't know if she'll ever get tired of Adora saying things like.

Fueled by pure gay energy —or love, if you want to be gross and sappy about it —Catra leans forward again, ignoring her back's protests so she can give Adora one more quick kiss. It's almost disappointing compared to the one they just shared, but kissing Adora could never be disappointing, so it's at least a consolation prize now they're finally parting.

"Unless I get another commission, I'm mostly free this week. We can spend time together later, princess," Catra promises. She doesn't have a commitment herself at this moment, but she did promise to give Entrapta a hand and she isn't going to let her friend down. They all built what they have now together and she's hoping that as long as they keep supporting each other, they'll be able to keep succeeding. Hopefully they're only *beginning* to succeed.

"I'm going to hold you to that. Actually, you should come over tomorrow and annoy me while I work," Adora tells her, reaching for her car door when Catra goes to open her own. Catra laughs as she steps out of the car and circles around it.

"What, can't work up the motivation and need someone to bully you into meeting your deadline?" Catra asks. Adora shrugs as she leans against the door to the backseat, smiling at Catra without any hint of offense. Catra happily crowds forward, the end of her tail lashing as she drapes herself across Adora's front. Adora's hand find her hips and she ducks her head to rest her forehead against Catra's.

"Maybe. Or maybe Glimmer and Bow won't be home for the afternoon, so if I get my work done early I'll have time for *other* things while we're still alone in the house," Adora replies, a tease as much as a promise. Catra rolls her eyes, but she's smiling as she stretches up on her toes and gives Adora one last goodbye kiss that she maybe gets a bit too wrapped up in, Adora's arms sliding around her back and their tongues meeting in the least appropriate parting kiss in history. Whatever, it's not like anyone else hangs out on this lot and there's some trees between here in the road.

"You'd better work fast, then," Catra tells her when they finally part. Some of her bossiness is cut by the fact that she has to *clear her throat* after a kiss like that, but Adora smirks back at her as Catra steps back.

"I can with the proper motivation," she promises, pushing off the car. The cockiness in her smile almost makes Catra want to push her into the backseat and say *fuck it* to whatever Entrapta needed her help with – well, no, it *definitely* makes her want that – but that would make her as shitty of a "boss" as it would a friend. She reluctantly takes another step back just to cut the temptation a bit. Proximity to Adora always makes her blood light up.

"I'm sure I'll think of something," she promises, smirking back for a moment before she lets it fall into a genuine smile. The posturing slips from Adora too, something Catra doubts would happen so easily if they didn't both know they were parting. Otherwise they would probably keep peacocking at each other until one of them was shoved against a wall – or in this case, the side of the car again. Instead, the smirks fall in favor of looks of one last, long look of affection before they're forced to turn away from each other.

For a *year*. Fucking hell, they're so dramatic. Catra wouldn't have it any other way, though.

"Goodbye, Adora," she says, almost following the cadence of the old flirtation she likes to purr out, but this is far too soft for that. Adora visibly softens, looking at Catra in a way that it feels near impossible to look away from. There's so much *love* in her eyes for no goddamn reason and Catra never wants to forget what Adora looking at her like this feels like.

"Bye, Catra. Send me Melog pictures," Adora says, earning a laugh and an eyeroll that finally forces Catra to break eye contact. She sniffs as she turns away.

"I'll think about it," she says vaguely. They both know she's going to hunt Melog down as soon as she gets inside anyway. If she didn't,

he would get really indignant – and noisy – when he realized she was home and hadn't given him attention yet. She has crossed all the way to the shop's side door before she hears Adora's car door slam, which means she watched her walk away for entirely too long, but Catra is also wearing leggings today and she *knows* what her ass looks like right now.

Or maybe Adora was still being sappy. She is Adora, after all.

"I'm home!" Catra yells as she steps into the shop, squinting a little to adjust to the change from the harsh sunlight of outside. With how often she has to corral their asses, it's basically a warning to put away any illicit projects so she doesn't have to be the boss and tell them to stop. *Or* *maybe* *she* *is* *trying* *to* *help* *them* *avoid* *getting* *in* *trouble* with her. A vague cheer – it might actually be the word *hooray*, wow her idiots are cheesy – comes from Entrapta's corner. Despite her promises, Catra walks past it to head for her "office" first. She needs her toolbelt, probably, or at least her Leatherman, and sixty seconds to get settled before Entrapta gives her a crash course on her project sounds nice.

"Call me whenever you need me," Catra says, loud enough to carry, as she walks past Entrapta's area.

"You gotcha!" Entrapta responds, her thumb sticking up from under her desk. Catra almost U-turns to see what she is doing down there, but she manages to remind herself *not to look* unless something starts smoking and she keeps going. It's usually better not to know until she has no choice except to, she reminds herself as she hears the unmistakable sound of electric zapping and sparks.

She takes a deep breath as she steps into her own space, feeling her shoulders relax as she re-enters her territory. She loves her shop. The first time she came here with Entrapta, the whole place was the kind of mess you expect to see on a hoarding TV show, not to mention the grime and rust that had built up in the disused parts of the shop. Entrapta had already relegated herself to her corner, likely

because she could keep up with the maintenance over there. It wasn't neat, but it was functional, and it wasn't dirty like the rest.

Back then, Catra was daunted by the task of getting the shop into working shape. She wasn't picturing ever being at ease in it – after all, she was never at ease in their workshop at the Horde – but just a few months in it started to feel familiar and comforting. There is stress in this space – builds gone wrong, long hours beating her head against the wall trying to figure out a solution, and stress over money and running her own business – but there is also freedom, and the good memories layering over everything help a lot. There isn't a single part of the workshop where she hasn't laughed with Entrapta, Scorpia, or now Adora.

It's home. Not where she sleeps – usually, she's not Entrapta – and not the only place she feels comfortable, but it is home as much, if not more so, than the house they share. It's the first place where she could set her craft free and do whatever she wanted, *how* she wanted, and then she could show the result to her friends and get congratulations, compliments, and sometimes even awe. It's such a different experience, it bakes warmth into the space where it all takes place.

Maybe Melog agrees, because he's napping in her office when she enters, but it's more likely that he came here seeking out warmth because he's curled up on top of her computer. Catra should check her emails before Entrapta needs her, but she stops to take a picture for Adora first, and a few for herself. She has a folder for Melog in her phone, though she would never admit it. Everybody knows she loves the stray, *sue me*, but she doesn't have to go admitting it. She's already being vulnerable enough with Adora.

She sends one of the pictures off to Adora as she finally sits down. She doesn't have the time to wake her computer before Scorpia pops into her office doorway.

"Hey, boss! I know Entrapta needs you, but we got an email while you were out and they wanted to speak immediately. You're going to

want to hear this,” Scorpia says, an *energy* radiating from her that instantly has Catra’s full attention.

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Sorry Princess, but I’m probably going to have to cancel on tomorrow
New potential client reached out
I promise the job is worth the wait

--

Adora knows she’s being ridiculously needy – she *knows* – okay, Glimmer and Bow don’t have to keep sending her judging looks – but she’s kind of stupid in love with Catra and right now Catra is too busy for them to spend much time together. She’s negotiating a new contract, or something, and they have still been able to text a lot, but every time Adora asked about meeting up over the last week Catra said she couldn’t until she had a plan approved for this new job. Adora’s not *anxious*, she just misses her girlfriend and that’s perfectly reasonable.

Okay, so she’s a little anxious. Mostly just needy, though. Catra has still been affectionate – in the Catra-form of affection, anyway, which mostly consists of light bullying and horny jokes with occasional fits of honesty – while they text, and she has been perfectly clear on why she is busy and that it is very temporary. If they still lived together, it wouldn’t be a big deal because they would still be getting time together.

When Catra texts her that she has enough worked out to step away from the shop for the day, Adora jumps on it and lightly bullies Glimmer and Bow into coming home late so she can have as much time with Catra as possible. In truth, she's hoping to lure Catra into spending the night—it *is* a Friday, and she usually takes Saturdays off—and she doesn't have much intention of them emerging from her room once Glimmer and Bow do return, but the longer they can have the house to themselves, the better.

She's been a bit anxious, but all of that eases when Catra appears at her door with a bounce in her step—metaphorically, Adora is usually the one who *literally* bounces—and a grin on her face. Adora gets to blurt out, "Catra!" with probably too much excitement before Catra reaches up and pulls her in for a hello kiss. It isn't a filthy kiss, but it is *deep*, the two of them drawing close together. Adora is more than happy to breathe Catra's air as her arms work their way around her waist and she *finally* holds her girlfriend in her arms.

"Adora," Catra purrs back, the seductive and rough quality in her voice putting Adora's own greeting to shame and sending a shiver down her back. She kisses Catra again, just as deeply and pulling their bodies tighter together this time. They're still in the entryway, but they're alone and Adora isn't stopping, happy to kiss them both breathless. She's a little lightheaded when they part, but resting her forehead against Catra as they both draw in air feels *good*.

"It has been, like, a week," Catra says, but she sounds amused and not nearly judging enough for it to be a real condemnation. Adora can feel her beginning to *purr* in her arms. She missed this as much as Adora did, and that fills her chest with light. She knows that, at the start, they went this long between seeing each other and often *more*, but Adora's requirement for Catra time fundamentally shifted the first time they kissed. Their first week together, they went five days without seeing each other in person, but now they've reached the point where they usually hang out three times a week and she *literally* missed it while Catra was busy.

"You missed me too," Adora accuses with total affection, tilting her chin up to kiss the bridge of Catra's nose. Catra scrunches her nose up, just like she always does, but it's *adorable* and far from a complaint. There's crinkling at the outer corners of her eyes.

"Mm, maybe. You can't prove anything," Catra replies, letting her eyes fall closed and nuzzling Adora's cheek. Adora closes her eyes as well, nudging back so their cheeks can rub together both for the affection of it and to help Catra mark her. Catra purrs softly. For a long moment they just hold each other. Adora swears she can feel her heartrate slowing down—although it had jumped with excitement upon greeting Catra, so maybe that isn't directly correlated—as her body calms beneath Catra's touch.

"You're purring," Adora counters. Predictably, Catra's ears twitch and her face flushes. Unlike their teenage years, she doesn't push Adora away. Instead, a grumble joins her purr, but she stays in Adora's arms, cuddled against her. It's only proving Adora's point.

"Whatever. You want to hear about what kept me so busy or you want to pout?" Catra says, finally pulling away. Not far, she just drops her hand to hold Adora's and stays by her side, but they're no longer pressed together. Adora *does* want to pout, but mostly at the distance. The way Catra says those words—an excited current running through them—has her pausing. Her instinct is to pout and complain—not seriously, but still not entirely performatively—about Catra's sudden business, but now she has her curious. It would make Adora a hypocrite anyway. She travels pretty often for her work, usually for several days at a time. They'll be apart of longer in the future.

"I thought you were signing an NDA?" Adora settles on as they finally start walking into the house. They should probably take advantage of having the run of it while they can, but her feet instinctually lead her back to her bedroom. She'd like to spend some time with Catra up in the workshop, but she also wants to cuddle first. The embrace in the hallway wasn't nearly enough. Catra grins as Adora holds her door open for her, slipping inside and wandering out of arms' reach. It's

tolerable, though, since now they're in a small room – *Adora's* room, is really the most important part – together.

"I did, but you know I trust you. And you're going to have to sign one too, so it doesn't really matter," Catra says, this giddy edge to her voice that has Adora's own heart rate picking up. Catra got a *good* gig then, and she's excited about it, but Adora's confused. Catra pauses in front of Adora's desk, mostly in disarray but still her favorite part of the room – aside from her old TV – thanks to her long-time sword prop now hanging over it.

"Is it so I can still visit the shop while you're working or something?" Adora asks, crossing the room – it's not that many steps – to get close to Catra again. Catra hums, reaching up to pull Adora's sword off the wall. For all her teasing about Adora's love for it, she can't seem to resist stealing the prop – whatever version of it is around – when it's present. Usually that's when Adora has it in her hands, though, and she kind of thought it was because Catra wanted her full attention.

"So you can help me deliver to set, actually. I didn't want to push for too much in the initial talks and have them think I'm more trouble than my work is worth, but once they see it *is* worth it, I'll see what else I can do. Besides, they found me *through* you, so it isn't like I'm asking to bring in some rando," Catra says, inspecting the sword with artful disinterest. Adora's brow furrows, making Catra smirk when she half-turns to glance over to see Adora's confusion.

"I got commissioned by a props master to make a few key pieces for a TV show. Big debut and big *people*. I'm going to be pretty busy getting them done and beautiful, but I was mostly staying in the shop this week so I would have everything settled by the time I told you," Catra says, shrugging, still trying to be so casual despite the light dancing in her eyes and her flicking tail. Adora is still confused, but she knows Catra finally getting her work on screen – with her *name attached* – at least – is a big deal.

"That' s great, Catra!" she opts for , pushing her confusion aside for a moment because this is something that should be celebrated. Catra's smile broadens to a grin, her excitement obvious, but that *house* is still sparkling in her eyes as she steps closer, absently running her fingers down the rainbow acrylic of the sword's edge.

"Come on, Adora. Ask me," she prompts, voice warm. Adora *w* she is purring from satisfaction already, but unfortunately there are an entire few inches between them, so she can't be sure.

"What, uh, why are you bringing me in?" Adora asks, not really sure what her question is because she' s just a bit too derailed to pick one. Catra's whole smug, sexy *thing* isn't helping her decode her cryptic statements. Catra grins.

"It' s the least I can do after your incessant posts from our shoot got me commissioned to make the new *official* sword," Catra tells her . Adora sucks in a sharp breath and feels her jaw drop.

Now, Catra *finally* purrs.

Chapter End Notes

> If you didn't notice, I had to bump the chapter count, because I'm always like this and constantly underestimate how much I have to say. Nine will be the final chapter, though. Honestly I consider it more of an epilogue in content and length. It's pretty short.

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

She-ra plays with her new sword.

Chapter Notes

Im not ready to say goodbye to these girls! □ But all stories have to end. Thanks for being on the journey.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra |Wildcat Workshop tagged you in a post
It's the end of a long, fulfilling project. I cant show the work to you now, so have my favorite idiot loading up the van with everything I spent the last few weeks on. A long drive and then a date night are in order. Ill be able to post more regularly now the commission is done.
Tap to view

The photo shows the back of an open SUV, loaded with several cases, many of which are thin. In front of it, Adora stands mid-turn, her knee still rested on the bumper from leaning in to load a case she is only just setting down. She has had just enough time to flash the camera a smile, but her ponytail is still a little blurry from turning around.

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Adora is freaking out a little. Just, like, a *small* amount. Catra seems amused by it. She's being all smooth and professional like she didnt also grow up watching every episode of She-ra with Adora. She has

been to set before and talked with a couple of the people in production, though. Technically they *are* on set, just in the production studio so Mara can do a screen test with the – hopefully final – sword prop. The prop master took a look at it last week, but once it passed his inspection it was time to pass it onto Mara and make sure it works for her and gives the final look they want.

It will – Catra considered things like her proportions carefully when she made it – but it's a check that has to be made now before they go and start filming out on location. Adora doesn't know what the location *is*, but it's exciting to know there is one. Everything won't be done in a sound stage, at least, and they got Catra to make them a prop with some *pizzazz* effects, which has only upped Adora's hope and excitement for the new show. Watching Mara walk into the room from the sidelines makes her blood buzz.

She looks *amazing* in her full costume, and also just in general. Adora only just found out Mara doesn't have a stunt double because she does it all herself ten minutes ago, and seeing her now, it's easy to believe. She always seemed so personable and nice in interviews – and she *is now*, smiling and talking warmly with the PA leading her to the camera set-up – that Adora wasn't expecting her to be so casually-intimidating. It isn't a fan worship thing – this is her first time seeing her as She-ra, for all she knows she'll hate her rendition – she's just really strong, really pretty, and *all good*.

"Should I be worried?" Catra teases, leaning over to whisper the words to Adora without looking away from the center of set. The camera is set up in front of a green space with a few props – mostly bolder-looking things Adora suspects Mara is going to be doing flips over or something equally cool with – and they're both facing where Mara is walking up to exchange a few words with the director. Adora certainly isn't about to look away. She's already taking notes on the new She-ra costume – a little more modern, which could be concerning for the series direction, but it has *pants* and wouldn't that be a relief at winter events. Her inspecting eye *might* be easily mistaken for lust, and maybe it wouldn't even be entirely wrong, but-

"Never ," Adora promises Catra. A slight rumble and a flash of teeth in the corner of her vision are the response she gets, but Catra doesn't say anything else, because at that moment Mara looks up and spots them. Adora feels like she has been mildly electrocuted as Mara smiles and begins walking towards them, the director vaguely calling something after her that Adora doesn't hear as she tries to push down the blood rushing in her ears.

"Catra and Adora, right? Is this my sword?" Mara asks as she approaches, raising a hand to shake, maybe, or to take the sword out of Adora's arms. She can't exactly shake Mara's hand, so she almost just shoves the sword at her instead, but Catra beats her to the punch, shaking Mara's hand. Adora has *no* idea what the protocol for this is. At the Horde, they always just sent their work off to the prop master for whatever production they were working on. They never went to set and they certainly never met the actors. Adora has never been more grateful for her career change in her life, because she's pretty sure Catra managed to get this arranged exclusively because Adora is considered an influencing voice when it comes to the fandom. Not that she can *use* that voice to talk about this for a while, but as soon as the embargo is up? Yeah, she's going to host multiples lives about this.

"That's us. It was a bit of a challenge, but it should stand up to anything reasonable you put it through. Adora would never forgive me if it couldn't go through some cool swordfights," Catra says, slipping into talking shop easily. Adora can't help but wonder if she's nervous too, because Catra's speech sounds a bit odd, but Adora hasn't come up with an appropriate greeting yet, so she can't really criticize. Catra is still ribbing her anyway , so she can't be that nervous. Adora just nods along with Catra's words and shifts to hold the handle out to Mara.

"The fight scenes were some of the best parts of the original, at least after all the gay stuff. The sword had to be able to stand up to it," Adora says, flushing a little because that was *stupid* , but Mara chuckles as she takes the sword, so maybe it was okay. Mara

practically sparkles as she sends Adora an amused look and then hefts the sword. For a second, she tests its weight, and then effortless she shifts her stance and strikes *thpose*, the lines of her body hardening into a solid foundation as she thrusts the sword up in the air.

If this were in an episode, a rainbow reflection would flash off the edge of the blade, but Adora's brain might as well add it in automatically with how easy it is to look at and see She-ra standing before her, even with the new costume and as a new actress.

Okay, so maybe she has some hero worship for Mara already. Sue her. She *hopes* the writing is as good as the casting and prop department, because Mara already seems like a perfect She-ra. Mara grins as she drops the stance, switching the heroism on and off at the drop of a hat. Stuff like that is why Adora never got the hang of acting, but Mara makes it look easy as she takes several more steps back and swings the sword around experimentally. The light of joy dances in her eyes.

The part of Adora not wholly dedicated to freaking out glows a little with pride for Catra. She made some minor contributions to the sword herself—mostly back in the prototyping phase, pitching things with Catra and acting as a sounding board—but the final build is all Catra. A handoff like this is unusual and they never got to watch an actor get giddy to play with their new toy back at the horde. She can only imagine how proud Catra is feeling right now given how she is feeling herself secondhand.

"Mara, come do that in front of the camera!" the director calls from across the room. Mara laughs, glancing back over her shoulder and seeming to send them a sheepish smile. She turns back to them even as she takes a step backwards without needing to look.

"Thanks, guys!" she says, throwing them a thumbs up and then turning on her heel to rush off to the filming area. Adora watches her go for several long seconds, and it isnt until Mara is already centered in front of the camera and slipping back into that hardened,

serious state that Adora feels like she begins breathing with a normal rhythm again. Her heart is still going too quickly and she doubts she will feel normal again until their car is driving off the lot. Luckily, everyone is either focused on Mara starting to go through her paces in front of the camera—she's feeling out the sword, probably, but she already handles it with a level of confidence and skill Adora can only be jealous of—or doing their own jobs.

No one is looking at them anymore—again, they *don't need to be* *here*, but fuck is Adora glad Catra managed to arrange it even if the interaction only lasted seconds. Any longer might have killed her, anyway. Catra sidles closer, resting an arm on Adora's shoulder and leaning against her like a piece of furniture, but Adora is used to that and doesn't look away from the swordplay. It's grounding, honestly, to have Catra leaning on her and despite being something so very *them*, it doesn't feel like PDA or anything, so it feels allowable if someone does care to glance over at them.

"She's married," Catra reminds, her voice quiet and quivering with suppressed laughter. Adora's face feels hot, but all of her feels kind of hot. She's pretty sure this is a belated adrenaline response. She felt like this the first several times she hosted an event. She can push through it—in some ways it makes her sharper, which almost makes up for the ways it makes her stupider—but she's glad it didn't hit until after Mara walked away.

"Not like we aren't—" See, it makes her *stupid*. She clamps her mouth shut. Her face is *definitely* hot now. Catra makes a sound that could be a snicker or could be her choking on surprise. Luckily it's just as quiet as the rest of their conversation has been.

"We aren't *her*, princess?" Catra asks, and yeah, she's laughing at her, but that's better than her being upset or something. Adora bites her lip.

"We're in it for the long haul too, is all," she mumbles out. Sure, they're a long way from *marriage*, but Catra is going to be her damn life partner if she has anything to say about it. She doesn't think that

intent is a secret or *one-sided* . Catra doesn't laugh or pull away , at least. There's just a moment of silence before she speaks again, voice low.

"Yeah," is all she says, an agreement quiet from gravity . This isn't the time or place to have this conversation, but it does help Adora's body calm down from the adrenaline, even if Catra wasn't the initial cause of it. It doesn't quite feel appropriate to hold hands right now , but she fumbles her hand over towards Catra – without actually lifting it, because Catra is still leaned on her shoulder – and finds her tail, squeezing it for a moment before letting it go.

Catra's arm drops from her shoulder and she takes a half step back, putting a normal amount of distance between them for two people who don't feel like they're dying if they break physical contact. Adora finally tears her gaze away from the display before her to glance at Catra and check in, but Catra just sends her a reassuring smile back. Adora takes a deep breath, feeling herself relax as they both look forward in unison again.

Yeah, today is going up there in contention for the best day of her life.

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Normally Catra wouldn't be anywhere near filming. She would bring her work into the studio and talk with the props master, but that's the closest she's ever been to a set before, and even that she only did twice with the Horde since deliveries weren't usually her job. She couldn't be trusted to not screw up relations, apparently . This production seems to be a pretty small core team, though, at least compared to the movies she did work on for the Horde, and they have had no qualm about her being around their star so far .

The careful hinting and then negotiation of bringing Adora in was a bit more complicated—mostly because Catra was angling to get Adora in the same room with Mara or one of the writers instead of just dropping something off to a sound stage—but by the time she actually requested it, they were game. After several weeks, they finally ended up here, present for the first screen test so they can talk with the director and prop master about how things turned out and any potential changes.

Catra does most of the talking, though. She's the one who made the prop, after all. It's a new design, though clearly inspired by the original, and made using a similar technique to how she did Adora's. That technique was what caught the production's eye, after all. It had to stand up to some tougher use and they wanted the effects to be a bit different, but the design was more mutable than Adora's recreation and they were able to put in the tweaks that were needed made the whole thing work.

Adora mostly stands next to her with hearts in her eyes when they get called over to talk to the director, Diana, while filming. They mostly want to ask a few questions about the lights and possible tweaks to their programming. It's stuff above Adora's head, and she's really just here to watch anyway. Catra leaves her next to set when the prop master calls her over to ask her a question about a few of the other pieces she brought. There are several similar-style blades, none as grand and visibly distinct, but clearly there's some kind of story going on there because her reference material made it clear the weapons were at least from the same society, if not the same *group*.

Catra was only commissioned to make a few big pieces, mostly the ones that were related to each other and needed to be cohesive, so she have to talk with the prop master for too long. By the time she returns, however, the camera test seems to be done. No one is focused on the set anymore, anyway, and Mara is now off to the side, talking to Diana again—who Adora is still standing next to. She

isn't freaking out, she has actually managed to be shockingly calm about this whole thing, but her excitement is still obvious.

Catra sidles up to her, keeping her focus on Adora so it doesn't look like she's being presumptive about talking to the star or trying to interrupt the director. Adora actually looks away from Mara when she approaches—Catra really didn't expect her to take her eyes off of her when there's practical stars in her eyes—and offers her a bright smile. Catra smiles back and lightly nudges her with her elbow as she stops beside her and crosses her arms, ostensibly waiting to be spoken to or dismissed, but still managing to have an entire conversation with Adora in a few smiles and light nudges.

Oh, hey, you're still here!

You look delighted to be here.

Catra is still smiling when Diana nods to Mara and then turns their head to acknowledge Catra's presence.

"The last round of revisions was worth it. It fits the vision exactly. Fantastic work. My assistant will email you by the end of the week to settle final details," they say. Catra nods her head, inclining forward enough to make it almost look like a casual version of a bow of respect.

"It was a joy to work on. I can't thank you enough for the opportunity," she replies, doing her best to thread the needle between coming across as professional, genuine, and excited. Catra might not be bouncing off the walls like Adora is, but okay, maybe this is a bit of a dream project. Out of all the things she gets to make, weapons are her favorite. Sci-fi weapons, especially, but given this show's connections to their childhood, it was an amazing project to work on, and doing the extra lighting effects helped scratch the itch sci-fi weapons usually supply. She's glad she was able to bring Adora onto her team for it—even if she isn't a part of Wildcat

Workshop – so they could iterate on ideas, but especially for now , when Adora gets to stand beside her at the studio.

"If we need further outside work, well be reaching out," Diana says, before their eyes slide over to Adora for a moment. "And as always, there is a social media blackout until the review embargo is up," they add. Adora didn't even bring her phone – it' s in the glovebox of their car to avoid suspicion and temptation – but she nods seriously as Catra similarly inclines her head. Diana seems happy with that, nodding back to them both.

"It was a pleasure working with you," they say , waiting just long enough for Catra to say, "Likewise," before they turn and walk of f towards some member of the production staff that Catra hasn't been introduced to. It's a pretty clear dismissal, so Catra unfolds her arms and prepares to turn back to check in with the props master one last time before leaving, but she pauses when Mara shifts to face them instead of the air the director was previously occupying. Mara just seems *ni e* , smiling at them when Adora – subtly , but still noticeably to Catra – instantly perks up.

"It was nice to meet you two," Mara says, waving her hand a little at her side in the same dorky way Adora sometimes does. Not that Mara could be described as *dky* , really, but the term is a bit of a stretch to apply to Adora too. You don't usually call models dorks. Catra still does it. Regularly.

"You too. We can't wait to see the show ," Catra says, both for herself and for Adora, because she has faith in her girlfriend but she also *knows* her and she isn't sure she is going to be able to say much, or at least what she wants to, too overwhelmed to choose her words carefully in the moment. Mara beams, turning to Adora and reaching her hand out to her now. Adora hurries to take it, flashing Mara a smile back just as dazzling. That' s Adora being Adora, though. There's no star power there, she doesn't need it when she' s just so earnest and excited.

"I cant wait to film it and show it to the world. It' s really a dream come true,"Mara replies, chuckling a little. Adora nods seriously at that, clearly in agreement, though her smile cuts the intensity in her eyes.

"It' s been an honor to meet you. Ill definitely be watching every week. I can already tell youll be an amazing She-ra,"Adora rushes out, a bit breathless and just *shy* of stopping herself from bouncing on her heels, Catra can tell, but none of that seems to bother Mara, because her smile back is sparkling, seeming genuinely flattered.

"Thank you,"she says, nodding to Adora, likely getting ready to say goodbye, "Y ou are too, you know. Ive seen videos of you cosplaying. You have that spark. Im not surprised fans resonated with you,"she adds.

Catra's breath hitches entirely for Adora's sake, knowing how much that must mean to her, and then she immediately remembers *how much that must mean to her* and hurries to raise a hand, placing it on her shoulder as if in support or congratulations, but really she just wants to be able to catch her in case she passes out. Adora looks *elated*, smiling and flustered and yes, very possibly on the verge of fainting.

"Th-thank you. That means a lot,"she says. Her voice is a little high. Mara doesnt comment, just smiling back, softer and a bit reassuring.

"I hope the show lives up to everything you've dreamed,"she pauses, seeming to think about it for a moment, "and everything I have,"she adds, with a hint of laughter about her as she shrugs. Even when preparing to leave, she's personable and *genial*. Catra has an instinct in her that always triggers when something – some*one* – is a little too good to be true, and Mara is right on the verge of pinging it, but the problem is, as put-together as she is, she's a put-together *diva*, and that immediately gets through Catra's barriers.

Apparently She-ras are really just like this.

"I'm sure it will," Adora manages to reply. Catra predicts she has about four more words left in her before she either has to have a fan freakout or keels over. Mara does a similar nod as Catra did when Diana left earlier, almost a bow.

"I hope to meet you again," Mara says, thankfully leaving, because Catra can hear Adora's heartbeat now she's listening for it.

"You too," Catra says for them both, waving a little with her free hand as Mara smiles broadly and steps away, waving herself before she turns to walk off. Adora is also waving, far more weakly. She doesn't stop after Mara has turned her back, at least not right away, her hand looking more like it is wiggling as it eventually falls by her side.

"Let's checkout and head to the car, princess," Catra says to her, voice soft to keep from being overheard and also to offer encouragement: we'll be alone soon and you can scream if you need to. Adora releases a noise of acknowledgement that is a little too strangled to be causal, but she doesn't pass out as Catra places a hand on her lower back and steers them away from the set.

Well. That was more than she dared hope for when she first started scheming to get Adora on set.

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Adora can die happy now. She's kissed Catra and achieved a life's goal she didn't know she had, and she's *in love*, apparently, so yeah, she's all good. Bucket list done. This moment was the peak and every moment after is just bonus credits. She keeps reliving the conversation with Mara in her mind as Catra wraps up with a member of the production and they return to the car. She's red in the face by the time she has sat in the passenger seat – she's in no

shape to drive and they both know it – but frankly it's a miracle she kept it down that long.

She *probably* kept it down that long, anyway. She couldn't see her own face. Catra seemed a little amused by her reaction, even if she was overwhelmingly supportive and steady. Once they're in the car, however, Catra gets buckled and then just sits, giving Adora a minute to process. She's going to need all of the two hours it takes to drive back home.

Mutters . The *other* just said Adora did a good job.

"Hey, Catra?" Adora asks, her voice still a little too high for normal speech.

"Yes, Adora?" Catra replies, amusement in her tones. Adora is staring, unseeing, out the front windshield of the car, but she knows Catra is smiling at her from the driver's seat.

"Remember what you said that first evening after we got together?" she asks, her voice still not normalizing. There's a moment where Catra tilts her head in her periphery.

"About fucking with the costumes on?" she asks, her voice shaking with laughter, but there's raw affection there. Adora is embarrassed, her face red, but Catra nailed it. It's not- none of that made her *horny* – though she definitely appreciated Mara in the new She-ra costume in the casual way of being in a hot person's presence and not in the way Catra implied – but she is absolutely coursing with energy that she needs to do *something* with, and nothing is going to get the show out of her head right now.

"Yeah," she agrees, breathing the words because she can either go above or below normal speech but seemingly not land right on it at the moment. She has way too much energy to just sit and watch the show, and playing around with her own sword isn't going to do it for her right now. Besides, Catra has been *training* today – always –

and she’s occupying any parts of Adora’s thoughts that arent busy screaming right now. Catra chuckles as she turns away from Adora to settle looking forward in her seat.

“Get us the house to ourselves,”she tells her as she puts the car in drive. Adora all but lunges for the glovebox, hurrying to pull out her phone as Catra laughs beside her. Adora doesnt care if Catra, or Glimmer, or Bow makes fun of her for this. This is the best day of her life.

Chapter End Notes

> Fic notes are up on my tumblr! I dont know exactly when, but I plan to have more stuff coming soon.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!